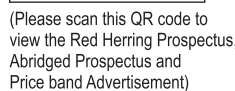


DEEPA JEWELLERS LIMITED
(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Corporate Identity Number: U74999TG2016PLC109435

Registered Office: Ground floor and first floor, door no. 3-6-343 & 344, Basheerbagh, Himayathnagar, Hyderabad-500029, Telangana, India.
Telephone: + 91 76809 62117; **Website:** www.deepajewel.com; **Contact person:** Vandana Modani, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; **E-mail:** cs@deepajewel.com



INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF DEEPA JEWELLERS LIMITED ("OUR COMPANY" OR THE "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A PREMIUM OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[●] MILLION ("OFFER"). THE OFFER COMPRISES OF A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹2,500.00 MILLION (THE "FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO 11,848,340 EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[●] MILLION (THE "OFFER FOR SALE"), COMPRISING OF UP TO 5,924,170 EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[●] MILLION BY ASHISH AGARWAL AND UP TO 5,924,170 EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹[●] MILLION BY SEEMA AGARWAL COLLECTIVELY (THE "PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDERS"). THE OFFER WILL CONSTITUTE [●] % OF OUR POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL.

**As certified by NSVR & Associates LLP, Chartered Accountants, pursuant to their certificate August 25, 2026. For further details, see "The Offer" on page 66 of the RHP.*

BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 84 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 84 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹2 EACH THEREAFTER. THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FISCAL 2026 FOR OUR COMPANY AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND (I.E. FLOOR PRICE) IS 13.15 TIMES AND AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND (I.E. CAP PRICE) IS 13.85 TIMES AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 23.92 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026. WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NET WORTH FOR LAST THREE FINANCIAL YEARS IS 45.26%.

The details of the Fresh Issue, Offer for Sale and the post Offer market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

BID/OFFER PERIOD	BID/OFFER OPEN
	BID/OFFER CLOSES ON: THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 03, 2026 ⁽¹⁾

^(f) UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 PM on the Bid/Offer Closing Date

Our Company processes and supplies 22K hallmarked gold jewellery, including plain and precious-stone studded ornaments, through an outsourced manufacturing model. We also undertake jewellery job-work and trade in silver ornaments, 18K/20K gold jewellery, precious stones, and gold bullion.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARDS OF BSE AND NSE. BSE SHALL BE THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.

• QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 50% OF THE OFFER • NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE OFFER • RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 35% OF THE OFFER

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, PROSPECTIVE INVESTORS MUST ONLY RELY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RHP AND THE TERMS OF THE OFFER, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE OFFER AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THIS PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE OFFER AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS ("BRLMs").

IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE RECOMMENDATION OF THE COMMITTEE OF INDEPENDENT DIRECTORS OF OUR COMPANY, PURSUANT TO THEIR RESOLUTION DATED AUGUST 26, 2026, THE ABOVE PROVIDED PRICE BAND IS JUSTIFIED BASED ON QUANTITATIVE FACTORS/ KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS DISCLOSED IN THE “BASIS FOR THE OFFER PRICE” SECTION ON PAGE 114 OF THE RHP VIS-A-VIS THE WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION (“WACA”) OF PRIMARY AND SECONDARY TRANSACTION(S), AS APPLICABLE, DISCLOSED IN THE “BASIS FOR THE OFFER PRICE” SECTION BEGINNING ON PAGE 114 OF THE RHP AND PROVIDED BELOW IN THIS ADVERTISEMENT.

For details, refer to section titled “Risk Factors” on page 20 of the RHP.

1. **Customer concentration:** Our Company generates a significant portion of its revenue from its top 10 customers. Our top 10 customers accounted for ₹12,460.30 million, ₹8,839.29 million and ₹6,901.89 million representing 64.67%, 63.27% and 67.36% of our revenue from operations, based on our Restated Financial Information for the Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024 respectively. Our Company does not enter into long term contracts with our customers and any decision by these customers to reduce or terminate their business with us could significantly impact our business, financial condition and results of operations. The revenues generated from our top 1, top 5 and top 10 customers in Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, is set out below.

(in ₹ million, except percentage data)

2. **Product revenue concentration risk:** Our revenue from operations is significantly concentrated in certain products. Revenue from operations from the sale of vaddanam and CNC machine cut bangles together accounted for a substantial portion of our revenue from operations during Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024. Any reduction in demand for, cancellation of purchase orders relating to, or inability to sell these products in the quantities or at the prices currently anticipated by us could adversely affect our business, cash flows, financial condition and results of operations. The revenue from operations and corresponding percentage contribution from the sale of vaddanam and CNC machine cut bangles for the relevant periods are set out below:

(in ₹ millions, except percentage data)

* Other products include- gents kada, vanky (armlet), dandpatti (bajuband), gundlamala haaram (traditional neck piece), gundlamala necklace, kangana, earring, mangtiika (forehead pendant), maatil (ear chain), champasaralu (ear to hair chain), jada (braid ornament), rings, precious stones, pearls, flat diamonds, cubic zirconia, gold bullion and precious beads.

3. Revenue concentration (geography wise): A significant portion of our revenue from operations is generated from the South Indian states of Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Kerala. For Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, our revenue from operations generated from Southern India amounted to ₹18,181.87 million, ₹13,738.07 million and ₹10,199.85 million respectively, representing 94.37%, 98.33% and 99.55% of total revenue from operations for the respective periods. Accordingly, our business is highly concentrated in these markets, and any adverse economic, social, political, regulatory or market developments, or changes in consumer preferences, in these regions could adversely affect our business, financial condition, cash flows and results of operations.

- 4. Inventory management risk:** Our results of operations are dependent on our ability to effectively manage our inventory.

- Our inventories as of Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024 were ₹873.62 million, ₹827.87 million and ₹722.56 million, respectively, representing 4.53%, 5.93% and 7.05% of our revenue from operations for the respective periods. Any inability to accurately forecast customer demand, preferences and design trends or maintain optimal inventory levels could result in excess or insufficient inventory, affecting our ability to meet customer demand. Further, if we are unable to sell our inventory, we may be required to recycle it, resulting in material losses and additional manufacturing costs. Any decline in gold prices could also reduce the value of our inventory and adversely affect our business, financial condition, cash flows and results of operations.

5. **Volatility in gold prices and dependence on the availability of gold bullion:** Gold bullion is our key raw material, and our business is dependent on the timely availability of gold bullion of the requisite quality and at commercially acceptable prices. The prices and availability of gold bullion are subject to various factors beyond our control, including general economic conditions, foreign exchange rates, import duties, competition and production levels. Gold prices have remained volatile, with average prices ranging from ₹58,738 to ₹154,039 per 10 grams across Fiscal 2024 to Fiscal 2026. Any significant increase or volatility in gold prices or any disruption in the availability of gold bullion, could increase our procurement costs, adversely affect our margins and cash flows, and have a material adverse effect on our business, financial condition and results of operations.

6. **Supplier concentration:** We depend on certain key suppliers for procurement of gold bullion, which is our key raw material. Our top 10 suppliers accounted for ₹16,021.93 million, ₹10,845.93 million and ₹9,582.83 million representing 91.81%, 82.32% and 96.89% of our total purchase based on our Restated Financial Information for the Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024 respectively. We procure gold bullions from RBI registered bullion bank, independent bullion dealers, exchanges from customers and import through India International Bullion Exchange (IIBX), with whom we do not have any long-term contracts. Any disruption in our relationships with these suppliers, failure by any of them to fulfil their obligations in a timely manner, or any adverse regulatory or policy changes affecting the procurement or import of gold bullion could adversely affect the availability and cost of our key raw material and, consequently, our business, financial condition, cash flows and results of operations.

7. **Dependency on third party karigars:** We are dependent on third party karigars for the production and manufacturing of all our products. We have not entered into formal agreements with some of the karigars. As on June 30, 2026, we have a pool of 41 karigars, out of which, we have entered into formal agreements with 29 karigars. Any discontinuation or interruption of services by these karigars, disruptions at their production or manufacturing facilities, or failure to adhere to applicable quality standards could adversely affects our reputation, business and financial condition.

- 8. Our business and demand for our products are dependent on the performance of our customers:** We supply our products to jewellery retail chains and standalone stores, which sell them to their respective retail customers. Accordingly, demand for our products is dependent on our customers' ability to successfully market and sell their products. Any decline in demand due to increased competition, seasonality, loss of market share, macroeconomic conditions, regulatory actions, litigation, price fluctuations or other factors could reduce orders placed by our customers and adversely affect our business, financial condition, cash flows and results of operations.

9. **We have experienced negative cash flows from operating activities:** Our Company had negative cash flows from its operating activities in the current and previous periods, as per the Restated Financial Information. Net cash (used in) generated from operating activities for Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024 were ₹(147.30) million, ₹(98.64) million and ₹48.45 million, respectively. Negative cash flows may adversely affect our financial condition, results of operations and prospects.

- 10. Indebtedness Risk:** As of July 31, 2026, our total sanctioned and outstanding indebtedness was ₹1,150.00 million and ₹1,274.07 million, respectively. Conditions and restrictions imposed on us by the agreements governing our indebtedness could adversely affect our ability to operate our business.

11. **Past regulatory non-compliances:** Our Company has, in the past, experienced delays in filing certain statutory and regulatory forms with Registrar of Companies. These delays include delayed filings of Form CHG-1 in relation to the creation and modification of charges for Fiscal Years 2017, 2018, 2019 and 2022, as well as delays in filing various forms relating to the appointment and resignation of statutory auditors. Although such filings have been made subsequently, any past or future non-compliance with applicable statutory or regulatory requirements may expose our Company to regulatory proceedings, penalties, fines or other actions, which could adversely affect our business, financial condition and results of operations.

...continued from previous page.

- 12. Dependence on personal guarantees provided by our Promoters for borrowings:** Our Promoters have provided personal guarantees for loan facilities obtained by our Company. Further, our Promoter, Chairman and Managing Director, Ashish Agarwal, in his capacity as a guarantor, has mortgaged his property, being the Registered Office of our Company, in favour of Yes Bank Limited. Any failure or default by our Company to repay such loan facilities in accordance with the terms and conditions of the financing documents could trigger repayment obligations on our Promoters, which may affect their ability to effectively service such obligations. Further any revocation or withdrawal of the personal guarantees by our Promoters could adversely affects our business, operations, financial condition and cash flows.
- 13. Security risks:** We maintain significant quantities of inventory of raw material and finished goods at our Registered Office, sales offices and with karigars, as well as expose such inventory during the transit and delivery of our products to customers. Given the high value and portability of our products, our inventory is exposed to risks of theft, fraud, loss, damage, misappropriation and employee or third-party negligence. Any such incident, particularly during transportation or while our products are in the custody of karigars or other service providers, could result in financial losses, disruption to our operations, claims from customers or other counterparties, and reputational damage, which could adversely affect our business, financial condition, cash flows and results of operations.
- 14. The Price/Earnings ratio based on diluted EPS for the Financial Year 2026 for the Company at the higher end of the price band (i.e., ₹177) is at high as 13.85 as compared to average Price/Earnings ratio of industry peer group is 23.92.**
- 15. Weighted Average Return on Net Worth for past three Fiscal Years i.e March 2026, 2025 and 2024 is 45.26%.**
- 16. Weighted average cost of acquisition of all shares transacted in the three years, 18 months and one year preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus:**

Period	Weighted average cost of acquisition per Equity Share (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'x' times the weighted average cost of acquisition	Range of acquisition price per Equity Share: lowest price – highest price (in ₹)
Last one year preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	Nil ⁽³⁾	Not Applicable	Nil ⁽³⁾ – Nil ⁽³⁾
Last 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	0.00 ⁽¹⁾⁽²⁾	Not Applicable	Nil ⁽³⁾ – 80.00 ⁽¹⁾

Period	Weighted average cost of acquisition per Equity Share (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'x' times the weighted average cost of acquisition	Range of acquisition price per Equity Share: lowest price – highest price (in ₹)
Last three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus	0.00 ⁽¹⁾⁽²⁾	Not Applicable	Nil ⁽³⁾ – 80.00 ⁽¹⁾

As certified by NSVR & Associates LLP, Chartered Accountants, pursuant to their certificate dated August 26, 2026

- Details of number of Equity Shares, weighted average cost of acquisition per equity share and the range of acquisition price per Equity Share has been adjusted for split of Equity Shares.
- Weighted average cost of acquisition has been arrived at by considering only the cost of shares transacted by the Shareholders on account of any further issue, bonus issue or secondary transfers and adjusted for split shares, i.e., the cost paid or received by the Shareholders for transactions in equity shares, divided by the total number of equity shares transacted.
- Nil represents cost of equity shares acquired pursuant to a bonus issue (at no consideration).

- 17. The average cost of acquisition of Equity Shares by Promoter (including the Promoter Selling Shareholders) as on date of the Red Herring Prospectus is given below:**

Name of Promoter	Face Value (in ₹)	Number of Equity Shares held	Average cost per Equity Share of face values of ₹2 (in ₹)
Promoters			
Ashish Agarwal*	2	40,005,000	0.50
Seema Agarwal*	2	40,000,000	0.50
Dev Agarwal	2	1,980,000	0.00

As certified by NSVR & Associates LLP, Chartered Accountants, pursuant to their certificate dated August 25, 2026.

*Also a Promoter-Selling Shareholder.

- 18. Emkay Global Financial Services Limited and Valmiki Leela Capital Private Limited, Book Running Lead Managers associated with the Offer, have handled 4 public issues in past three years, out of which 2 issues closed below issue price on listing date.**

Name of BRLMs	Total issues	Issues closed below IPO price on listing date
Emkay Global Financial Services Limited	4	2
Valmiki Leela Capital Private Limited	Nil	Nil
Total	4	2

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS:

- Our Company has not undertaken pre-IPO placement from the DRHP till date.
- The Promoters or members of the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company from the DRHP till date.
- The aggregate pre-Offer and post-Offer shareholding of our Promoter, members of our Promoter Group and additional top 10 shareholders as a percentage of the pre-Offer and post-Offer paid-up equity share capital of our Company is as on the date of the pre-issue and price band advertisement. Please refer to the section titled **“Capital Structure”** on page 87 of the RHP.



The **“Basis for the Offer Price”** on page 114 of the RHP has been updated with the above Price Band. Please refer to the websites of the BRLMs: www.emkayglobal.com, www.valmikileela.com for the **“Basis for the Offer Price”** updated with the above price band. You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of Emkay Global Financial Services Limited.

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors):		Bid/Offer Period	
Bid/Offer Period (except the Bid/Offer Closing Date)		EVENT	INDICATIVE DATE
Submission and revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST	ANCHOR INVESTOR BID/ OFFER PERIOD OPENS AND CLOSES ON	Monday, August 31, 2026
Bid/Offer Closing Date		BID/ OFFER OPENS ON	Tuesday, September 01, 2026
Submission of electronic applications (online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) for RIBs	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST	BID/ OFFER CLOSSES ON*	Thursday, September 03, 2026
Submission of electronic application (bank ASBA through online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and syndicate ASBA applications through UPI as a payment mechanism where Bid Amount is up to ₹0.50 million)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST	*UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 p.m. on Bid/Offer Closing Date.	
		An indicative timetable in respect of the Offer is set out below:	
		Event	Indicative Date
		Finalisation of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange	On or about Friday, September 04, 2026
		Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors) / unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*	On or about Monday, September 07, 2026
		Credit of the Equity Shares to depository accounts of Allottees	On or about Monday, September 07, 2026
		Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges	On or about Tuesday, September 08, 2026
		*In case of any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBAAccounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date for cancelled / withdrawn / deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date on which the request for cancellation/ withdrawal/ deletion is placed in the Stock Exchanges bidding platform until the date on which the amounts are unblocked (ii) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such multiple amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iii) any blocking of amounts more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iv) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted/partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. The Bidder shall be compensated in the manner specified in the SEBI ICDR Master Circular, which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of the Company with the SCSBs, to the extent applicable. The processing fees for applications made by the UPI Bidders may be released to the remitter banks (SCSBs) only after such banks provide a written confirmation on compliance with SEBI ICDR Master Circular.	
Modification/Revision/cancelled of Bids			
Upward revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders categories ⁴	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date		
Upward or downward revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIBs	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date		
⁴ UPI mandate end time shall be 5:00 p.m. on the Bid/ Offer Closing Date.			
⁴ QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/withdraw their bids.			
On the Bid/ Offer Closing Date, the Bids shall be uploaded until:			
(i) 4.00 p.m. IST in case of Bids by QIBs and NIBs, and			
(ii) until 5.00 p.m. IST, or such extended time as permitted by the Stock Exchanges, in case of Bids by RIBs.			
On Bid/Offer Closing Date, extension of time may be granted by Stock Exchanges only for uploading Bids received RIBs after taking into account the total number of Bids received and as reported by the BRLMs to the Stock Exchanges.			

ASBA* | Simple, Safe, Smart way of Application!!!

*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount ("ASBA") is a better way of applying to offers by simply blocking the fund in the bank account.

For further details, check section on ASBA.

Mandatory in public issues. No cheque will be accepted.



UNITED PAYMENTS INTERFACE

UPI-Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non Institutional Investor applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹ 500,000, applying through Registered Brokers, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. UPI Bidders also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Investors are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 issued by the Central Board of Direct Taxes and the subsequent press releases, including press release dated June 25, 2021 read with press release dated September 17, 2021, and CBDT circular no. 7 of 2022 dated March 30, 2022, read with press release dated March 28, 2023, and any subsequent press release in this regard.

ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors in the Retail Portion; (ii) Non-Institutional Investors with an application size of up to ₹0.50 million in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section **“Offer Procedure”** on page 371 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India (**“AIBI”**) and Stock Exchanges and in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of the Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displayed on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFp=yes&intmid=35 and <https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFp=yes&intmid=43>, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI apps and banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through the SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. HDFC Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited have been appointed as the Sponsor Banks for the Offer, in accordance with the requirements of SEBI circular dated November 1, 2018 as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLMs on their respective email IDs as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail id: ipo.upi@npci.org.in.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF BSE AND NSE.

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/Offer Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days after such revision in the Price Band, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar circumstances, our Company may, in consultation with the BRLMs, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/Offer Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/Offer Period, if applicable, shall be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice/ press release, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the BRLMs and at the terminals of the members of the Syndicate and by intimation to Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Banks, as applicable.

The Offer is being made in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Rules, 1957, as amended (**“SCRR”**) read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations. This Offer is being made through the Book Building Process in accordance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, wherein in terms of Regulation 32(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, not more than 50% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers (**“QIBs”**), and such portion, the **“QIB Portion”**, provided that our Company in consultation with the BRLMs may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis (the **“Anchor Investor Portion”**), out of 40.00% of the Anchor Investor Portion will be reserved for allocation in the following manner: (i) 33.33% to domestic Mutual Funds; and (ii) 6.67% to life insurance companies and pension funds, subject to valid Bids having been received from domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds at or above the price at which Equity Shares has been allocated to Anchor Investors (**“Anchor Investor Allocation Price”**), in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations in the event of an under-subscription in the portion reserved for life insurance companies and pension funds, the allocation shall be made to domestic Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Anchor Investor Allocation Price, in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations. In the event of under-subscription, or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the QIB Portion (other than Anchor Investor Portion) (**“Net QIB Portion”**). Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Mutual Funds only, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation to all QIBs, including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. However, if the aggregate demand from Mutual Funds is less than 5% of the Net QIB Portion, the balance Equity Shares available for allocation in the Mutual Fund Portion will be added to the remaining Net QIB Portion for proportionate allocation to QIBs. Further, not less than 15% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Non-Institutional Bidders out of which (a) one-third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹20 million and up to ₹1.00 million; and (b) two-third of such portion shall be reserved for applicants with application size of more than ₹1.00 million, provided that the unsubscribed portion in either of such sub-categories may be allocated to applicants in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Bidders and not less than 35% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. All potential Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are required to mandatorily use the Application Supported by Blocked Amount (**“ASBA”**) process providing details of their respective ASBA accounts, and UPI ID in case of UPI Bidders, if applicable, in which the corresponding Bid Amounts will be blocked by the SCSBs or by the Sponsor Bank(s) under the UPI Mechanism, as applicable, to the extent of the respective Bid Amounts. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Offer through the ASBA process. For details, see **“Offer Procedure”** on page 371 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN and the Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID available (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other

correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants' sole risk.

Investors must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with the notification issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes notification dated February 13, 2020 and read with press releases dated June 25, 2021, September 17, 2021 and March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as regards its objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, please see **“History and Certain Corporate Matters”** on page 220 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, see **“Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection”** on page 418 of the RHP.

Liability of the members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of share capital of our Company and capital structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorised share capital of our Company is ₹250,000,000 divided into 125,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up Equity share capital of our Company is ₹164,000,000 divided into 82,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹2 each. For more details of the capital structure of the Company, see **“Capital Structure”** beginning on page 87 of the RHP.

Names of the initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company and the Number of Equity Shares Subscribed by them: The initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company are as follows: Ashish Agarwal and Seema Agarwal who had each subscribed to 1,000,000 equity shares of face value of ₹10 each. For more details of the share capital history of our Company please see **“Capital Structure”** beginning on page 87 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares offered through the Red Herring Prospectus, are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received 'in-principle' approvals from BSE and NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to their letters each dated February 27, 2026. For the purposes of the Offer, the Designated Stock Exchange shall be BSE Limited. Assigned copy of the Red Herring Prospectus has been filed with the RoC in accordance with Sections 26(4) and a signed copy of the Prospectus shall be filed with the RoC in accordance with Section 32 of the Companies Act, 2013. For further details of the material contracts and documents available for inspection from the date of this Red Herring Prospectus until the Bid/Offer Closing Date, see **“Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection”** on page 418 of the RHP.

Disclaimer Clause of Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”): SEBI only gives its observations on the offer documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Offer or the specified securities stated in the Offer Documents. The investors are advised to refer to page 352 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of SEBI.

Disclaimer Clause of BSE (the Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Red Herring Prospectus has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Red Herring Prospectus. The investors are advised to refer to the page 354 of the Red Herring Prospectus for the full text of the disclaimer clause of BSE.

Disclaimer Clause of NSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Offer Document has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Offer Document. The investors are advised to refer to page 354 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of NSE.

General Risks: Investments in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Offer unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares in the Offer have not been recommended or approved by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”), nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the Red Herring Prospectus. Specific attention of the investors is invited to **“Risk Factors”** on page 20 of the RHP.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS		REGISTRAR TO THE OFFER	COMPANY SECRETARY AND COMPLIANCE OFFICER
Emkay Global Financial Services Limited Address: The Ruby, 7 th Floor, Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400 028, Maharashtra, India Tel.: +91 22 6612 1212; E-mail: dj.ipo@emkayglobal.com Investor grievance e-mail: ig@emkayglobal.com Website: www.emkayglobal.com Contact person: Vimal Maniayar/ Pooja Sarvankar SEBI registration number: INM000011229	Valmiki Leela Capital Private Limited Address: 401- 402, Ship Salvad, B/s. Sindhu Bhavan, Sindhu Bhavan Road, Bodakdev, Ahmedabad, Ahmedabad City, Gujarat, India, 380054 Telephone: +91 79650 90099; E-mail: deepa.ipo@valmikileela.com Investor grievance e-mail: ig@valmikileela.com Website: www.valmikileela.com Contact Person: Khushi Joshi/ Shrawan Suthar SEBI registration number: INM000013341	Bigshare Services Pvt. Ltd. Bigshare Services Private Limited Address: Office No S6-2, 6th Floor, Pinnacle Business Park, Next to Ahura Centre, Mahakali Caves Road, Andheri (East) Mumbai – 400093 Maharashtra, India Telephone: +91 22 6263 8200; E-mail: ipo@bigshareonline.com Investor grievance e-mail: investor@bigshareonline.com Website: www.bigshareonline.com Contact person: Babu Raphael C. SEBI registration number: INR000001385	Vandana Modani DEEPA JEWELLERS LIMITED Ground floor and first floor, door no. 3-6-343 & 344, Basheerbagh, Himayathnagar, Hyderabad-500029, Telangana, India Telephone: +91 79609 62117 E-mail: cs@deepajewel.com ; Website: www.deepajewel.com Investors can contact the Company Secretary and Compliance Officer or the Registrar to the Offer in case of any pre-Offer or post-Offer related problems, such as non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares of face value ₹2 each in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode, etc. For all Offer-related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP: Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the **“Risk Factors”** beginning on page 20 of the RHP before applying in the Offer. A copy of the RHP will be made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and is available on the websites of the BRLMs, Emkay Global Financial Services Limited at www.emkayglobal.com and Valmiki Leela Capital Private Limited at www.valmikileela.com and at the website of the Company, Deepa Jewellers Limited at www.deepajewel.com and the websites of the Stock Exchanges, for BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and for National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS: A copy of the Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of the Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Offer at: www.deepajewel.com, www.emkayglobal.com, www.valmikileela.com and www.bigshareonline.com, respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORM: Bid cum Application Form can be obtained from the Registered Office of our Company, Deepa Jewellers Limited, Telephone: +91 79609 62117; BRLMs: Emkay Global Financial Services Limited, Tel.: +91 22 6612 1212 and Valmiki Leela Capital Private Limited, Tel.: +91 79650 90099 and Syndicate Member: Emkay Global Financial Services Limited, Tel.: +91 22 6612 1212, Registered Brokers, SCSBs, Designated RTA Locations and Designated CDP Locations for participating in the Offer. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and at all the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

DEEPA JEWELLERS LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, an initial public offer of its Equity Shares and has filed a RHP dated August 25, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP is made available on the website of the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the website of the BRLMs i.e., Emkay Global Financial Services Limited at www.emkayglobal.com and Valmiki Leela Capital Private Limited at www.valmikileela.com, the website of the NSE at www.nseindia.com and the website of the BSE at www.bseindia.com and the website of the Company at www.deepajewel.com. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and should refer to the RHP, including the section titled **“Risk Factors”** beginning on page 20 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP for making any investment decision.

This announcement does not constitute an invitation or offer of securities for sale in any jurisdiction. The Equity Shares each offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act or any state securities laws in the United States, and unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and in accordance with any applicable U.S. state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares being offered and sold outside the United States in 'offshore transactions' as defined in and in reliance on Regulation S and the applicable laws of the jurisdictions where such offers and sales are made.

For DEEPA JEWELLERS LIMITED
On behalf of the Board of Directors

Vandana Modani
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Wednesday, September 2, 2026

mint

— | Think Ahead. Think Growth. | —

mint primer

How 'local' is India's defence manufacturing?

BY SHOUVIK DAS

On 31 August, Tata Advanced Systems signed a deal to make the US's Javelin anti-tank missiles locally, two weeks after the release of sixth Positive Indigenization List seeking to localize over 400 items worth over ₹3,000 crore. *Mint* examines India's defence production push.



AFP

1 Why is the latest PIL important?

The latest PIL is the sixth list issued by the ministry of defence to the country's public sector undertakings (PSU), as well as private defence manufacturers. A note by the department of defence production (DoDP)'s 'Srijaan' local procurement platform said on 18 August that India procured over 15,700 items from local suppliers in five years, generating ₹10,000 crore in revenue for local vendors. The sixth and latest one, incidentally, is the biggest of the lot so far, with over ₹3,000 crore in local sourcing mandates. The size and maturity of the order are what make it important.

PTI

2 What is the extent of defence localization?

The key to this is the country's draft Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP). On 13 February, a 644-page draft DAP framework said that in future defence ministry procurement orders, New Delhi will look for a product's design and patent itself to be locally owned. Further, the policy proposed that in any local orders placed by the Centre, at least 60% of a product's overall components by value must be generated from within the country. The goal is to reduce the risk of falling prey to geopolitical sanctions. The policy, however, has not yet been notified and implemented, though consultations ended in March.

3 Which are the key firms indigenizing defence?

Hindustan Aeronautics is India's largest defence PSU. Most top defence suppliers are PSUs, including Bharat Electronics, Bharat Dynamics and Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders, among others. Private players include Tata Advanced Systems, L&T Precision Engineering & Systems, Mahindra Defence Systems, and Adani Defence & Aerospace.



4 Where do other countries stand?

China is the global leader in domestic defence production and design. A 2023 note by Observer Research Foundation estimated that Beijing had achieved 92% local sourcing for its defence production needs, including components for ballistics, aerospace and electronics. Russia, according to a 12 March Ukrainian foreign intelligence note, had 70% localization of finished defence equipment. The US, the world's largest defence spender at \$921 billion as of 1 January, ranked just lower at 69%.

5 When can India start defence exports?

India already exports defence equipment to strategic markets worldwide, but its exports remain relatively small compared with those of the US, China and Russia. Government data estimated India's defence exports at ₹38,424 crore (\$4 billion) as of 2025-26. In comparison, US aerospace and defence exports hit \$172.7 billion in 2025, with India's defence exports at just over 2% of America's. India, to boost localization and component supply chain, has struck partnerships, of which Tata's tie-up is a key example.

QUICK EDIT

Capital updrive

The hope that India's economy is headed for a comfort zone on overall investment got a boost from Monday's release of economic data. Gross fixed capital formation at current prices rose to 34.3% of GDP in the first quarter of 2026-27, a 2.9 percentage point on-year gain. Across all four quarters of fiscal 2025-26, that proportion was below 32% of GDP. This year, however, the chance of getting within reach of the 'boom' level of 35%, last seen two decades ago (under the old data series), is looking up. That's heartening. The public versus private sector comparison of the pace of this updrive over the past five quarters, though, reveals no break-out of acceleration led by the latter. Such an investment shift is awaited for three reasons. *One*, fiscal space for sustainable capex stimulus has shrunk, as macro stability demands a tighter fisc. *Two*, private investors hold the key to a dream run of investment nearing 40% of GDP, the sort of ratio that led China's emergence. And *three*, it remains a fair bet that private capital tends to get allocated more efficiently from an output point of view, since it's guided by market forces to a greater extent. Investment efficiency does make a difference.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

We should stay committed to taking security as a key goal, and foster an environment of common security. We should pursue coordinated measures to tackle traditional and non-traditional security threats.

XI JINPING
PRESIDENT, CHINA



INSIDE

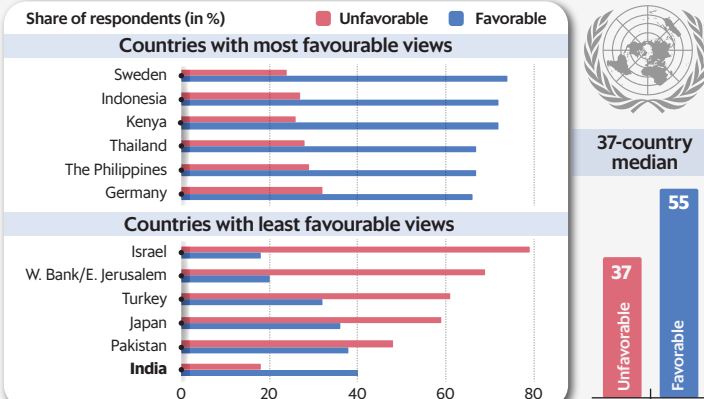
- Mark to Market | OMCs set for recovery in Q2 >P4
- Global | Mass burials in Nepal as toll from flash floods crosses 1,000 >P10
- Money | Retirement rethink: selling property for a simpler life >P11
- Views | Apple has cash: it needs a big leap into the AI pie >P12
- Business of Life | What does a fully AI work suite look like? >P14

mint | DATA BITES

HOW MUCH DOES THE WORLD STILL TRUST THE UN?

Across 37 countries, a median 55% view the United Nations favourably, while 37% view it unfavourably. In India, 40% view it favourably and 18% unfavourably. Sweden viewed the UN most favourably at 74%.

Views of different countries about the United Nations



The survey covered 45,658 people across 37 countries. Data doesn't show percentage of respondents who did not answer. W.Bank/E.Jerusalem: West Bank and East Jerusalem

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan
Graphic: Deepak Mishra

Source: Pew Research Center

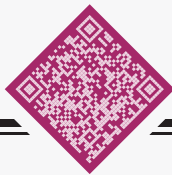
COLUMNS



V. ANANTHA NAGESWARAN
HOW INDIA'S GROWTH RECORD KEEPS ITS DREAM OF DEVELOPMENT ALIVE >P12

Madan Sabnavis
WHY UPI MAY NEVER BE ABLE TO OUTMODE THE USE OF CASH >P12

Rahul Matthan
INDIA IS INNOVATIVE BUT WE MUSTN'T STARVE IDEAS TO DEATH >P13

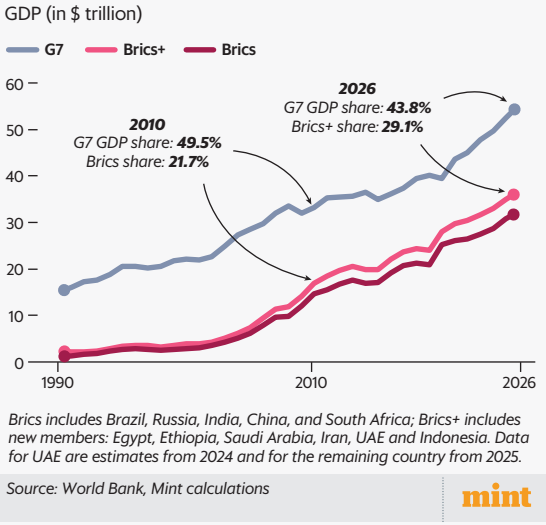


TOP GLOBAL NEWS A MONTHLY WRAP

BY RUPANJAL CHAUHAN & PAYAL BHATTACHARYA

Every month, *Mint's* Plain Facts gives you an update on key global data to help you thread together the biggest developments worth paying attention to. The accompanying analysis and charts explain how each story is creating ripples on the global stage, where it is headed in the coming weeks, and whether it could have an impact on India. New Delhi is set to host the 18th Brics summit this month as the bloc gains global weight, while inflation paths diverge across major economies, signalling different impacts from the conflict in West Asia. Tim Cook exits Apple after 15 years, youth unemployment is rising fastest in South Asia, and AI's impact on jobs remains uneven across low- and high-income countries.

Brics economies have been closing the gap with G7 nations in GDP



BRIC BY BRIC

INDIA IS set to host the Brics summit on 12-13 September as the world grapples with heightened geopolitical uncertainty. The bloc, established as an alternative to the Group of Seven (G7) and a major voice for the Global South, has expanded significantly in the past 15 years.

Brics began with Brazil, Russia, India and China, added South Africa in 2010 and has since expanded to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Indonesia. The enlarged Brics+ has gained a larger share of global GDP even as the G7's share has declined, strengthening the case for a bloc representing the interests of emerging economies.

In 2010, the G7 accounted for 49.5% of global GDP, compared with 21.7% for the original Brics members. By 2026, the G7's share had fallen to 43.8%, while Brics+ accounted for 29.1%. A larger grouping gives these emerging economies a platform to coordinate on trade, investment and finance and seek greater representation in global institutions.

DIVERGING PRICES

INFLATION HAS started moderating across several major economies after rising earlier this year following the outbreak of the West Asia war in March.

China's retail inflation fell to 0.5% in July from 1.2% in April and May, while South Korea's eased to 2.8% from 3.2% in June. Brazil also saw inflation decline to 4.4% in July from 4.7% in May.

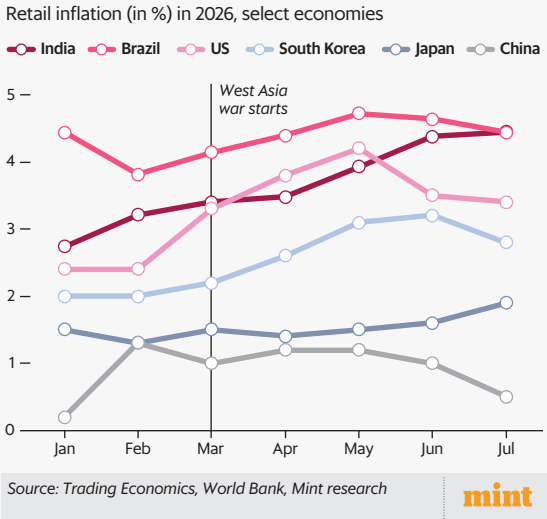
India and Japan, however, have seen prices move higher. India's inflation rose from 2.7% in January to 4.5% in July, while Japan's increased from 1.5% to 1.9%.

The continuous rise in inflation in these two countries keep the room open for rate hikes. India paused earlier this month but monetary policy minutes showed hawkish tilt, signalling rate hikes in near future.

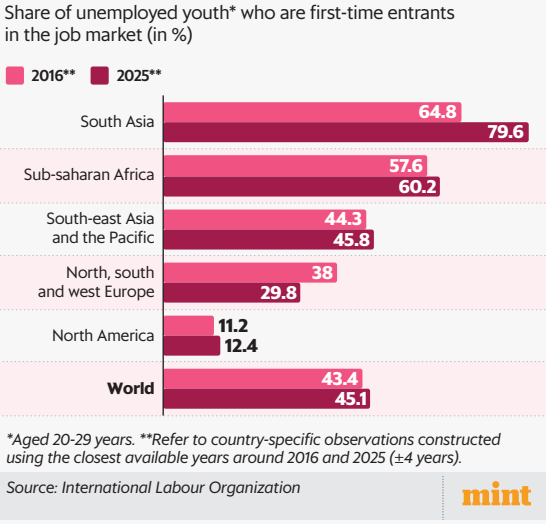
Japan is widely expected to hike rates again this month.

The US presents a different policy dilemma. Even as inflation eased from its recent peak, it was much higher than the 2% aim at 3.4% in July, leaving the Federal Reserve to weigh in on the need to hike rates.

Inflation is charting different paths across economies since the West Asia war



South Asia sees the largest increase in unemployed first-time entrants



ENTRY SQUEEZE

FOR YOUNG jobseekers in South Asia, finding a first job is becoming harder. Nearly eight in 10 unemployed youth in the region were first-time entrants to the labour market in 2025, the highest among major regions, according to the *Global Employment Trends for Youth 2026* report released by the International Labour Organization (ILO).

The share was 45.1% globally, 60.2% in sub-Saharan Africa and 45.8% in Southeast Asia and the Pacific. South Asia's share has risen sharply from 64.8% in 2016 to 79.6% in 2025. This means a growing proportion of unemployed young people are looking for work for the first time, rather than being between jobs.

The trend is important as young people make up a large part of the region's workforce and face consequences of a delayed start to their careers.

Rising tertiary education may be pushing labour-market entry to later ages, but weak job creation can make the transition from education to employment harder.

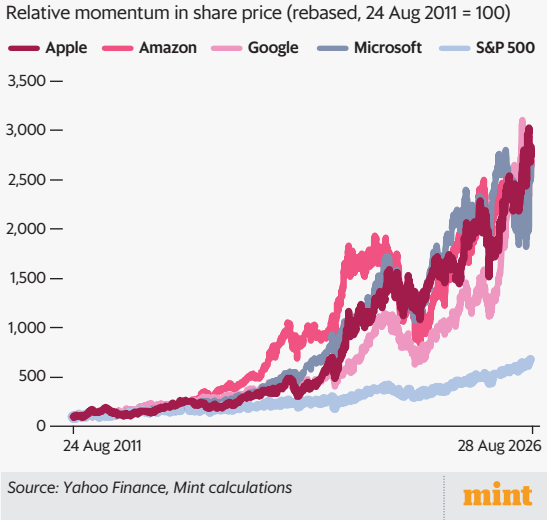
THE COOK ERA

TIM COOK'S departure from Apple marks the end of one of the longest and most consequential leadership tenures in corporate America. He took over as chief executive on 24 August 2011, after six years as Apple's chief operating officer, succeeding co-founder Steve Jobs. Cook led Apple through rapid expansion in smartphones, services and consumer technology.

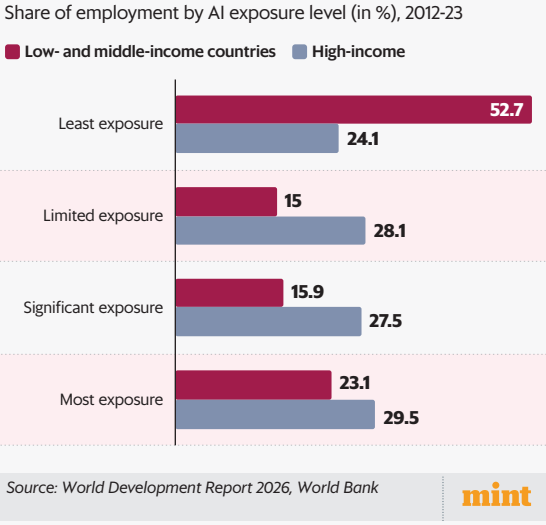
Apple's market value grew alongside the technology boom, making its shares a major beneficiary of the sector's rise. A \$100 investment in Apple on the day Cook took charge would have grown to \$2,841 by 28 August 2026, versus \$655 in the S&P 500.

By benchmark standards, Apple has generated stellar value for its investors. However, this looks less extraordinary when Apple's stock momentum is compared with peers like Amazon, Alphabet and Microsoft, which also delivered similar returns. Among top technology stocks, Nvidia and Tesla were outliers, with an initial \$100 investment delivering 26 times and 7 times more than Apple, respectively.

Apple's stock momentum is not extraordinary for a big tech company



More than half of jobs in low and middle income countries face low AI exposure



AI MEETS JOBS

AI'S IMPACT on jobs is likely to be more limited in developing economies, where a larger share of workers are in jobs with little exposure to the technology.

Data from World Bank's *World Development Report 2026* shows that 52.7% of employment in low- and middle-income countries is in occupations with the least AI exposure, compared with 24.1% in high-income economies. Jobs with the most exposure account for 23.1% of employment in low- and middle-income countries, against 29.5% in high-income economies. This means fewer jobs are at risk of displacement as AI adoption grows.

However, it also means fewer jobs are positioned to benefit from AI. Occupations with significant or most exposure account for 39% of employment in low- and middle-income countries, compared with 57% in high-income economies, the report said. The gap could narrow as AI adoption increases, particularly in sectors such as information and communication technology (ICT) and business services.



The price hike comes after two consecutive price cuts in July and August.

Commercial LPG prices up ₹10 per cylinder; jet fuel up 5.6%

Rituraj Baruah
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NEW DELHI

State-run oil marketing companies on Tuesday raised prices of commercial LPG cylinders by around ₹10 per cylinder across key metro cities. Jet fuel prices for domestic airlines have also been increased by over 5%.

In New Delhi, the price of the 19-kg commercial cylinder has been raised by ₹9.5 to ₹2,747.50 per cylinder. The price of a 5-kg FTL (free trade LPG) cylinder, which comes under the commercial category, has also increased by ₹2 to ₹764. The hike comes after two consecutive price cuts in July and August. In July, prices of 19-kg commercial LPG were reduced by ₹183.50, and in August, it was further cut by ₹192.

In Kolkata, Mumbai and Chennai, commercial LPG prices now stand at ₹2,884, ₹2,701 and ₹2,916.50 per cylinder, up by ₹11.5, ₹9.5 and ₹10.5, respectively.

The increase follows a rise in international LPG prices. Over the past one month, the benchmark Saudi Contract Prices (CP) for LPG increased by \$5 per tonne for propane and \$20 per tonne for butane.

India imports about 65% of its annual LPG requirement of 33 million tonnes (mt), resulting in an import bill of nearly \$11 billion. Domestic LPG prices, however, have been kept unchanged.

Auto fuel windfall tax up

Separately, the government on Tuesday raised the windfall tax on exports of petrol and diesel by ₹1.5 and ₹1 respectively, and reduced it by 50 paise per litre on jet fuel exports for the next fortnight.

Often called a windfall tax, the special additional excise duty (SAED) aims to disincentivize petro-product exports and stabilize domestic supply, as well as capture a share of supernormal profits made by petroleum companies.

With the latest revision, overall export duty on diesel stands at ₹25 per litre and petrol at ₹1.5 per litre. The SAED on the export of ATF will be ₹19 per litre for the next fortnight.

Cos may have to label drugs as synthetic or biological

Move aims to end ambiguity on drugs that can be produced chemically as well as biologically

Priyanka Sharma
priyanka.sharma@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Centre plans to tighten rules for pharmaceutical companies by requiring them to specify whether a drug is synthetically made or biologically derived when applying for a licence and on its packaging, according to two government officials familiar with the discussions and documents reviewed by *Mint*.

The proposed changes to the Drugs Rules, 1945, seek to resolve a regulatory ambiguity around drugs, such as anti-diabetic and anti-obesity drug semaglutide that can be produced through chemical synthesis or biological methods such as recombinant DNA (r-DNA) technology.

The biological process involves combining DNA from different organisms and inserting it into a host such as yeast or bacteria, which then produces the target therapeutic protein.

But the existing framework lacks a statutory definition of biological products, allowing drugmakers to obtain licences under both categories for the same molecule.

To plug the loophole, the Indian government plans to define biological products and mandate manufacturers to declare whether an active ingredient



Existing framework lacks a statutory definition of biological products, allowing drugmakers to obtain licences under both categories for the same molecule.. AFP

is chemically synthesized or biologically derived from human, animal, or microbial sources.

"Form 28 governs licensing for synthetic products, while Form 28D is required for biological products under central oversight. Because the Drugs Rules, 1945, do not define a biological product due to its evolving nature, manufacturers are taking licences under different forms for the same product," said one of the first officials cited above on the condition of anonymity.

This comes against the backdrop of the Central Drugs Standard Control

Organisation (CDSCO) receiving multiple applications from manufacturers seeking permission to produce synthetic and r-DNA formulations at the same manufacturing facility.

While Schedule M of the Drugs Rules permits campaign-based manufacturing subject to cleaning validation and risk-mitigation measures, the substantive provisions do not define biological drugs. The rules also do not specifically address licensing overlaps in which a facility seeks approval under Form 28 for synthetic drugs and under Form 28D for biological products with central oversight, at the same site.

"Therefore, it is proposed that mandatory labelling provisions be introduced to indicate the origin of the drug as 'synthetic origin', 'r-DNA-origin', 'human origin', or 'animal origin', as applicable. Consequential amendments will also update Schedules C and CI to cover biological-origin products across parenteral and non-parenteral dosage forms," stated one of the documents.

The government also proposes to incorporate a definition of "biological products" into the Drugs Rules, 1945, and the New Drugs and Clinical Trials (NDCT) Rules, 2019, aligned with World Health Organization (WHO) standards. The definition would cover vaccines, recombinant therapeutic proteins, monoclonal antibodies, enzymes, hormones, and cell and gene therapy products.

Mint reported on 24 August that the Indian Pharmacopoeia Commission (IPC) was drafting a dedicated monograph for semaglutide, setting official standards for the drug's identity, purity, potency and testing.

India's biologics market is estimated at \$13.3 billion, against an overall pharmaceutical market of about \$60 billion. Demand for semaglutide alone is projected to reach \$347.5 million in India by 2035, according to a CareEdge report.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

\$13.3 bn
Estimated size of India's biologics market

\$60 bn
The size of India's pharmaceuticals market overall

GST collections jump 14.8% in August, refunds surge 68%

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India's gross goods and services tax (GST) collections rose 14.8% to ₹1.99 trillion in August from ₹1.74 trillion a year earlier, with collections from imports contributing significantly to the increase, according to provisional data released by the finance ministry on Tuesday.

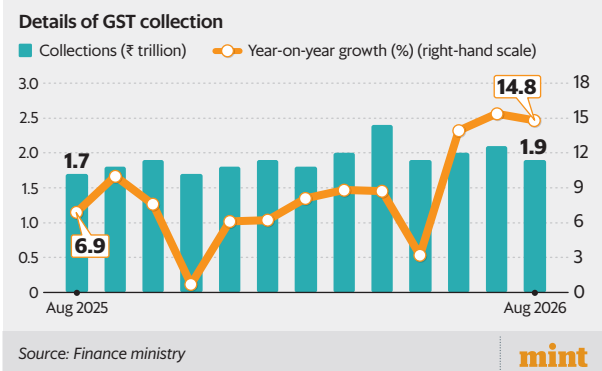
However, August collections were lower than ₹2.11 trillion in July, when GST collections crossed the ₹2 trillion mark for the second time. July's mop-up was the second-highest monthly GST collection since the tax regime was introduced in July 2017, after the record ₹2.43 trillion collected in August 2026.

Gross domestic GST revenue rose 9.3% to ₹1.37 trillion last month from ₹1.25 trillion a year earlier. GST collected on imports increased 29% to ₹62,604 crore from ₹48,546 crore. The gross collections were broadly in line with the ₹1.95 trillion collected in June.

The increase in gross collec-

Behind July

GST mop-up in August was lower than July's, when it had crossed the ₹2 trillion mark for the second time.



tions, was partly offset by a 67.9% rise in refunds to ₹31,795 crore from ₹18,935 crore a year earlier. Domestic refunds rose 72.6% to ₹18,490 crore, while export GST refunds processed through the ICEGATE platform increased 61.8% to ₹13,305 crore, the government data showed.

Domestic refunds are driven largely by inverted duty structures, where input taxes are higher than output taxes.

"It highlights the need for the GST Council to correct the

inverted duty structure, restore competitiveness and reduce working capital stress for businesses," said Vivek Jalan, partner at Tax Connect Advisory Services. "Export refunds are linked to zero-rated exports under GST, where exporters claim back IGST paid on inputs or imports. There is some short-term misalignment and timing gap. I feel, as exports are flat and refunds are rising."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Rural banks see rise in exits of new hires

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Regional rural banks (RRBs) are losing a growing share of newly recruited employees, with attrition among clerical staff rising to 39.2% in 2025 from 23.1% in 2023, according to government data reviewed by *Mint*.

The exits are concentrated among recent hires, with overall attrition across RRBs remaining a modest 3–6% for clerks and 2–3% for officers.

Government officials are examining ways to improve retention, while economists and bank union officials attribute the trend to better career opportunities, including Union and state government jobs, and the timing of RRB recruitment.

RRB hiring has historically concluded before nationalised banks and State Bank of India (SBI) completed their own recruitment, giving fresh recruits an opportunity to move to other jobs soon after joining.

The recruitment gap has widened as vacancies have increased faster than the num-



Attrition among clerical staff at RRBs rose to 39.2% in 2025 from 23.1% in 2023, according to government data.

ber of employees joining. RRBs had 6,299 clerical vacancies in 2023, against which 4,384 employees

joined, while in 2025 vacancies increased further to 8,034, even as only 4,937 employees joined, according to a presentation from the government.

Officer vacancies across Scale I, II, and III stood at 3,659 in 2023, and 5,685 in 2025, while the number of employees joining stood

at 3,160, and 4,503, respectively.

In RRBs, Officer Scale I is the entry-level assistant manager/junior-management grade, Scale II is the manager/middle management grade, and Scale III is the senior manager/middle management grade.

At the Nagaland Rural Bank, every officer hired to fill a new vacancy left the job, resulting in the highest recorded attrition rate

among RRBs. Maharashtra Gramin Bank, Jammu & Kashmir Gramin Bank, Manipur Rural Bank and Odisha Gramin Bank have also seen rates above 45%.

The presentation noted that 17 RRBs were yet to start promotions and four were yet to complete the promotion process.

Charan Singh, chief executive officer (CEO) and founder director of EGROW Foundation, a non-profit public policy organization, said the situation highlights a paradox in the labour market, with young employees having alternative opportunities despite concerns over unemployment.

"This is a very unique situation. On one hand, some pundits say there is very high unemployment in the country. On the other hand, as you can see from the data, in good jobs, young people do not want to stay," Singh said.

Queries emailed to the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD), finance ministry, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and sponsor banks, did not receive a response till going to the press.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

MINT SHORTS

Current account deficit up marginally in April-June: RBI

Mumbai: India's current account deficit widened marginally in the April-to-June quarter from a year ago on the back of higher commodity prices and a wider trade gap, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Tuesday. The gap stood at \$4.2 billion, or 0.5% of GDP, in Q1FY27, compared with a revised deficit of \$3.4 billion, or 0.4% of GDP, in Q1FY26.

DGFT automates export certificates to cut delays

New Delhi: The Directorate General of Foreign Trade

(DGFT) has introduced automated issuance of free sale and commerce certificates on its portal, seeking to reduce processing time and compliance burden for exporters and move the certificate issuance process from manual scrutiny towards a rule-based, system-driven workflow. The facility has been enabled through Trade Notice No. 24/2026-2027 dated 31 August. **HARSH KUMAR**

ITR filings cross 78 million for AY27, setting new record

New Delhi: More than 78 million income-tax returns (ITRs) were filed for assessment year (AY) 2026-27 as of 31 August, the income tax department said on Tuesday. The 31 August milestone is significant because it was the statutory due date for taxpayers with business or professional income whose accounts are not required to be audited for AY27. The latest figure comes amid a sustained growth in ITR filings.

India, Zambia revive talks on copper, critical minerals



New Delhi: India has resumed talks with Zambia to explore investment opportunities in copper and other critical minerals, two persons said, as New Delhi looks increasingly overseas for raw materials to meet rising demand from its rapidly growing economy. Officials from the ministry of mines held preliminary discussions with Zambian officials on 26 August, the people said.

Power consumption rises 13% to 169 billion units in August

New Delhi: India's power consumption grew 12.85% year-on-year to 169.01 billion units (BU) in August, official data showed, as high humidity levels pushed up use of cooling appliances like air conditioners in many parts of the country. The country's total power consumption was 149.76 BU in August 2025.

UPI transactions near record level of ₹29.8 trillion in August

New Delhi: Transactions through Unified Payments Interface (UPI) were at ₹29.8 trillion in August, near the record-high level, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). UPI transactions had touched the record high of ₹29.9 trillion in May and July 2026.

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Mr. Nitin Gadkari, Hon'ble Union Minister of Road Transport & Highways, Government of India

Mr. Anurag Jain, Chief Executive Officer, NITI Aayog, Government of India

Mr. Rajesh Agrawal, Secretary, Department of Commerce, Ministry of Commerce & Industry, Government of India

Mr. Hisashi Takeuchi, Managing Director & CEO, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd.

Mr. Santosh Iyer, Treasurer, SIAM, Managing Director & CEO, Mercedes-Benz India Pvt. Ltd.

Ms. Shivani Govil, Venture Partner, TBP Venture Fund, USA

Mr. H. D. Kumaraswamy, Hon'ble Union Minister of Heavy Industries & Steel, Government of India

Mr. Kamran Rizvi, Secretary, Ministry of Heavy Industries, Government of India

Mr. R. Mukundan, President, CII, Managing Director & CEO, Tata Chemicals Ltd.

Mr. Sriram Viji, President Designate, ACMA, Managing Director, Brakes India Pvt. Ltd.

Mr. R. Velusamy, President, Automotive Business, Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd.

Mr. Shunichi Kawamata, Senior Manager-APJ Lead, Industry Specialists & Solutions, Automotive & Manufacturing, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Japan



Mr. Piyush Goyal, Hon'ble Union Minister of Commerce & Industry, Government of India

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Mr. Shailesh Chandra, President, SIAM, Managing Director & CEO, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicle Ltd.

Mr. Ola Källenius, CEO, Mercedes-Benz Ltd., Germany

Mr. K. N. Radhakrishnan, Director & CEO, TVS Motor Company Ltd.

Mr. Nitesh Gupta, Senior Partner, McKinsey & Company



Mr. Tarun Kapoor, Advisor to Hon'ble Prime Minister, Government of India

Mr. Sudhakar Dalela, Secretary (ER), Ministry of External Affairs, Government of India

Mr. Shenu Agarwal, Vice President, SIAM, Managing Director & CEO, Ashok Leyland Ltd.

Mr. Tarun Mehta, Co-Founder & Chief Executive Officer, Ather Energy Ltd.

Mr. Alexander Will, Partner, McKinsey & Company, Greater China

Mr. Rajesh Menon, Director General, SIAM



MINT SHORTS

Dyson debuts \$499 AI-powered toothbrush with a built-in camera

Dyson Ltd introduced a \$499 toothbrush that uses artificial intelligence (AI) and a built-in camera to give real-time feedback, the latest in a growing subset of gadgets that put AI and video in sometimes unconventional places. Smart toothbrushes are hardly new. Companies such as Oral-B and Philips offer models that work with an app to track coverage, pressure, brushing time and other user data. But Dyson said its new CameraJet model, announced Tuesday, is the first with an integrated camera to narrow in on the gaps in the teeth, where plaque first forms then hardens, and direct a precision jet at them. It is available now for preorder and is being offered in blue and pink. **BLOOMBERG**

Starman Optical to acquire GoPro in \$285 million deal



Action camera maker GoPro said on Tuesday it is being acquired by Starman Optical in an all-cash deal valued at \$285 million. Under the terms of the deal, GoPro shareholders will receive an aggregate cash payment of about \$1.14 per share, while retaining roughly 10% ownership of the combined company. GoPro, which went public in 2014 with an IPO price of \$24 per share and briefly achieved a valuation of nearly \$4 billion on its first day of trading, has struggled in recent years to reignite growth beyond its action-camera business. The deal represents a premium of 29.5% to the stock's last close. Starman Optical designs and builds devices that turn computer data into light signals, sending information at fast speeds through fiber-optic cables. **REUTERS**

Oppex AI raises ₹4.2 cr in pre-seed round from Info Edge Ventures

New Delhi: Bengaluru-based Oppex AI, an artificial intelligence-native platform for production operations, has raised ₹4.2 crore in a pre-seed round from Info Edge Ventures. The fresh capital will be used to expand the team, accelerate product development and scale deployments with early customers, a company statement said. Oppex will also continue to strengthen its agentic platform and expand its capabilities as it works toward making AI-led production operations a reality for enterprise technology teams. **PTI**

India's deeptech boom puts growth investors to the test

Large funding rounds do not necessarily mean a deeptech firm has reached growth stage

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India's deeptech startups are beginning to reach a stage that was largely out of bounds for traditional growth investors: they have established revenue streams, some evidence of unit economics and are starting to grow in a more stable way.

The shift is also showing up in larger cheques and a broader mix of investors entering the sector, according to industry experts, even as growth funds confront the difficulty of evaluating businesses with long development cycles and technical risks.

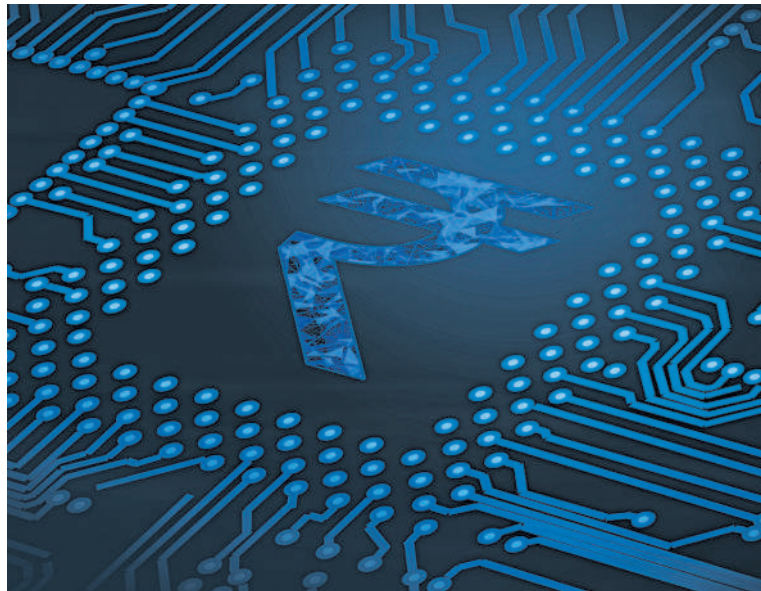
"Today there are more of these businesses that have established revenue streams, showing some unit economics, and are now starting to grow in a more stable way," said Dushyant Singh, managing director at Playbook Partners, a sector-agnostic growth fund.

Playbook joined Skyroot Aerospace's \$60 million round, which made the firm India's first spacecat unicorn at a \$1.1 billion valuation in May.

At least six of the top 10 deeptech deals so far this year were rounds of \$30 million or more from private equity (PE) and venture capital (VC) investors, Venture Intelligence data showed.

Gaja wrote a roughly ₹95 crore (around \$10 million) cheque in the \$74-million second tranche of Sarvam's \$300 million Series B and is actively scouting for deeptech and artificial intelligence (AI) bets. Avataar Ventures led Ethereal Machines' \$29 million round, while Exponent Energy's \$21 million round was led by 360 ONE. The asset manager has raised a ₹1,500 crore fund to back defence, aerospace and frontier-tech companies.

Electric vehicle manufacturer River



Deeptech firms have raised \$2.3 billion across just under 200 deals so far this year, according to Tracxn, compared with \$1.62 billion across 453 deals in 2025. **ISTOCKPHOTO**

Mobility raised \$120 million in equity and debt from Elev8 Venture Partners, Claypond Capital and existing investors. It was the first time the company raised domestic capital.

But a large round does not necessarily mean a deeptech company has

Humba Ventures. Lightspeed's India-specific fund was the only local participant. Founder and chief executive Naman Pushp said Airbound began looking to outside investors only after exhausting all domestic options.

"We were just shuttered between the

UNIT ECONOMICS

THE shift is showing up in larger cheques and a broader mix of investors entering the sector

AT least 6 of the top 10 deeptech deals this year are rounds of \$30 mn or more from PE, VC investors

GEOLOGICAL tensions and supply chain risks are adding to the appeal of homegrown tech

GOVERNMENT is deploying capital via ₹1 trillion Research, Development and Innovation Fund

reached the growth stage.

Last week, Airbound, an unmanned logistics and delivery drone startup, raised \$37 million in a Series A led by Greenoaks, with participation from DoorDash, Physical Intelligence founder Lachy Groom, Lightspeed and

growth and early stage team," he said of conversations with an Indian fund, which he declined to name. "Initially it was the growth team evaluating us because the round size is for the growth team. They realised that they cannot evaluate us via growth metrics, and

moved us to their early-stage team. But for that team, which normally writes cheques for \$10 million and below, writing a \$30 million cheque hurts."

Growth investors typically enter after a company has demonstrated product-market fit, a threshold that deeptech companies can struggle to meet because of their longer science-to-commercialization timelines.

"Given the significant investments being made in this domain in the US, the buzz and fear of missing out on this wave are much stronger," said Rishabh Jain, director, digital, technology & consumer investment banking at Avendus Capital.

Geopolitical tensions and supply chain risks are adding to the appeal of homegrown technologies. This is strengthening the strategic case for sectors such as aerospace, defence, spacecat and semiconductors, particularly as the government deploys capital through mechanisms such as the ₹1 trillion Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund.

But geopolitics is only part of the story. "Don't forget that we're in the middle of a compute super-cycle as well," said Debraj Banerjee, general partner at Fundamentum Frontier Advisors (F2A), a ₹3,000 crore deeptech and consumer AI-focused growth fund. "Homegrown technologies are seeing a sovereignty premium, which is why you're also seeing more growth funds looking to do deeptech."

Deeptech companies have raised \$2.3 billion across just under 200 deals so far this year, according to Tracxn, compared with \$1.62 billion across 453 deals in all of 2025. The numbers point to larger rounds despite lower deal activity.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

Yuma raises \$35mn for battery exchange

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Battery swapping joint venture Yuma Energy has raised \$35 million in its internal Series A round from Magna International, the company announced on Tuesday.

"A majority of the fundraise will be used to add more battery units across our existing geographies," said Muthu Subramanian, managing director and general manager of the company said in an interview with *Mint*. "The rest will go towards adding new nodes in new geographies."

This is the three-year-old startup's first institutional round of funding after automotive supplier Magna and mobility-as-a-service startup Yulu entered into a joint venture to create Yuma Energy. At the time of launch, the two companies cumulatively put in \$77 million to get Yuma going.

The startup's round comes at a time when funding into electric vehicles (EVs) and the ecosystem around it, is seeing investors pump in capital as they turn bullish on energy transition.

Energy storage tech has seen investors put in more money this year, compared to last year. In 2025, the sector raised \$270 million across 74 deals, while so far this year it has raised \$305 million across 37 deals, according to Tracxn data.

Funding into energy storage tech peaked in 2024 when it raised \$429 million across 80 deals.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com.

'Happiest Minds stake sale to ITC arm not driven by AI fears'

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Happiest Minds Technologies Ltd's stake sale to ITC Infotech was not driven by fears over artificial intelligence, the management of the Ashok Soota-led company said on Tuesday, amid concerns about AI's impact on India's IT services industry.

The comments, made at a press conference, came a day after Happiest Minds announced its acquisition by ITC Infotech, the IT arm of cigarette-to-salt conglomerate ITC Ltd. The combined entity would have revenue of about \$740 million as of March 2026. Soota was not present at the press conference, and questions directed towards him were addressed by chief executive Joseph Anantharaju and managing director Venkatarman Narayanan.

The two executives attributed Soota's decision to sell half of his 44% promoter and promoter group stake to his plans to invest in Happiest Health, his healthcare venture, and SCAN, his medical research trust. They dismissed AI-related concerns as a factor. "Mr Soota's intent to pare down his holding, this was said quite a while back about his intent to, you know, raise money. This was even before



Ashok Soota, founding chairman of Happiest Minds Technologies.

the foundation or the AI-related deflation was seen, and all of that," said Narayanan, in response to *Mint*'s questions.

The clarification comes at a time when AI has cast a shadow over the future of the country's \$300 billion IT sector, as clients look to shrink

Happiest Minds shares have fallen more than 21% so far this year, including an 11% decline on Tuesday

their outsourcing costs by deploying AI agents.

Meanwhile, Soota's decision to sell his stake came under scrutiny because the transactions were announced alongside the ITC

Infotech deal. He will sell an 11% stake in the first tranche at ₹390 per share and another 11% at ₹400 per share, valuing the two tranches at about ₹1,330 crore. Both prices are lower than Happiest Minds' closing price of ₹407 on the bourses on Monday, when the acquisition was announced.

The company's shares have fallen more than 21% so far this year, including an 11% decline on Tuesday. However, the management rejected a bleak future as a reason for Soota's stake sale.

"Does the ₹405 discount that the future is very bleak, given that AI is going to come? This is not correct," said Anantharaju. "Not because I think the future is bleak and I'm selling it at ₹400. Otherwise, if the future was better, I would have sold it at ₹600. That I think that is the logic which I understand from, you know, a holding standpoint, but the reality is it's a fair value."

The management added that Soota's receiving ₹390 and ₹400 in cash consideration is a relatively fair value, and that this value already takes into account the "next five or six years or 10 years of business."

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com.

AdvaRisk eyes \$25 mn from Fundamentum, others

Nabodita Ganguly & Priyamnada C

NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

CICI Bank-backed startup AdvaRisk, which helps banks and financial institutions detect fraud and assess borrower risk, is in talks to raise \$20-25 million, or about ₹190-237.5 crore, from investors including Fundamentum, according to two people aware of the matter.

The deal is still in the early

stages and could change as the company is also in discussions with other investors, the people added. AdvaRisk and Fundamentum did not respond to *Mint*'s emails sent on Monday.

Fundamentum is a venture capital firm backed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani, venture capitalist Sanjeev Aggarwal and Ashish Kumar. Its portfolio includes KukuFM, Wishlink, AppsForBharat and FlexiLoans.

The potential investment comes after Fundamentum

launched its third fund, Fundamentum Frontier Advisors (F2A), in May. The ₹3,000-crore fund, headed by Fundamentum co-founder and general partner Ashish Kumar, will focus on growth-stage artificial intelligence, consumer technology and frontier technology startups in India.

The fundraise discussions come as banks contend with increasingly sophisticated fraud and a growing need to track and recover stressed assets. On 29 May, *Mint*

reported that bank fraud cases fell sharply to 10,114 in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), from 23,722 in FY25 and 35,800 in FY24. However, the amount involved rose to ₹48,021 crore in FY26, from ₹32,803 crore in FY25 and ₹11,013 crore in FY24, according to the Reserve Bank of India's annual report released in May.

In a separate report on 20 May, *Mint* said India's largest banks were strengthening cyber defences, hiring specialised talent and expanding

insurance coverage amid concerns that sophisticated artificial intelligence tools could enable faster and harder-to-contain cyberattacks. Banks are also stepping up efforts to track and recover stressed assets. State Bank of India, for instance, has begun digitizing its stressed-asset tracking systems to improve recovery processes and oversight.

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CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE
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76,957.27	76,994.11	24,080.40	24,077.55	23,450.35	23,429.65	73,759.70	73,462.40	25,235.05	25,213.55	17,295.96	17,371.03	7,225.58	7,249.64
HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW
77,231.87	76,656.12	24,143.15	23,952.55	23,435.65	23,243.25	73,480.20	72,550.00	25,251.35	25,048.95	17,372.02	17,113.88	7,257.00	7,190.43

OMCs set for recovery in Q2

Ashish Agrawal
feedback@livemint.com

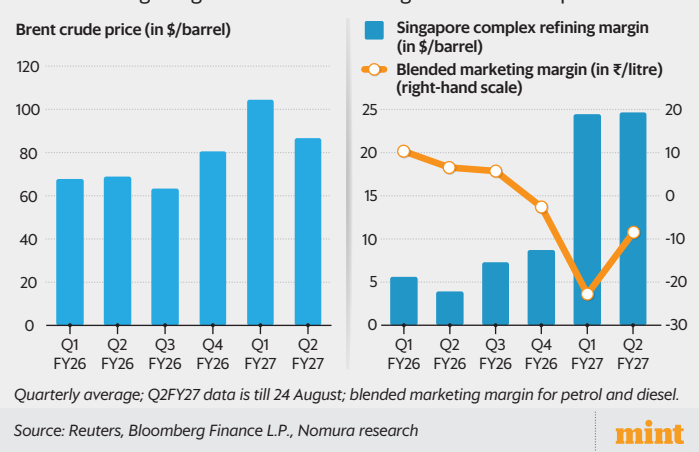
Growth prospects for oil marketing companies (OMCs) remain rocky amid the prolonged West Asia tension and Donald Trump's recent call for sanctions against entities doing business with Iran. While the immediate market reaction was muted given that Iran exports only 0.5% of global oil output, the move adds to uncertainty in the oil market.

Still, with Brent crude oil prices down 12% from the June quarter (Q1FY27) average, OMCs—Indian Oil Corp. Ltd (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corp. Ltd (BPCL), and Hindustan Petroleum Corp. Ltd (HPCL)—are expected to post strong Q2 results. Also, the International Energy Agency has projected a surplus in oil supplies in 2027, improving the medium-term outlook for OMCs.

Brent crude softened to \$72 per barrel in early July after US and Iran signed a memorandum of understanding on 17 June. But with hostilities resuming, Brent now trades at

Gaining ground

Oil marketing companies' Q2FY27 earnings should get a boost due to robust refining margin and lower marketing losses as crude prices ease.



Quarterly average; Q2FY27 data is till 24 August; blended marketing margin for petrol and diesel.

Source: Reuters, Bloomberg Finance L.P., Nomura research

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

over \$90 per barrel. While this is higher than the average of \$69 per barrel in Q2FY26, it is lower than Q1's \$105 per barrel. Also, the market is adequately supplied, considering the special Strait of Hormuz permission given to Iraq and the increase in ship-to-ship transfer of crude oil, reducing the risk of abrupt market shortages.

Ship-to-ship transfer shifts risk from the shipping company to oil-producing nations. Besides, the drawdown in inventories by US and China is helping to stabilize the market.

India's imports also improved to 5.1 million barrels per day (mbpd) in July, as per Petroleum Planning &

Analysis Cell, up from 4.8 mbpd in June but marginally lower than 5.3 mbpd in February. At current prices, integrated margins for IOC, BPCL, and HPCL have improved to \$11.70, \$13.30 and \$8.30 per barrel, as per a 25 August Nomura Global Markets Research report. In contrast, Q1 figures were \$7.30, \$5.50 and negative \$4.50 per barrel. Integrated margin includes refining plus marketing margin, LPG under-recoveries and windfall tax benefits.

"We believe OMCs offer the strongest earnings recovery within our coverage once Hormuz reopens, as lower crude and easing freight and insurance costs should support a swift recovery and likely compensate for Q1FY27 losses," Antique Stock Broking said on 26 August. OMCs faced stress in Q1 with HPCL and BPCL reporting Ebitda losses of ₹16,100 crore and ₹4,100 crore, against profits of ₹7,600 crore and ₹9,700 crore, a year ago.

HPCL suffered more as inadequate refining capacity led to market purchases at higher cost but expects to reduce third-party fuel purchases by end-FY27. IOC reported an Ebitda of ₹1,950 crore, though it fell 85% year-on-year. IOC's earnings could get a boost from its refining capacity expansion slated to come online by December.

Refining margins are receiving support from lower throughput with several refineries damaged by the conflict, China's exports curbs and the longer lead time required for refineries to scale up, even if crude prices stabilize at lower levels. OMC shares have declined 17-27% since the West Asia conflict began

on 28 February. HPCL looks expensive at an enterprise value of 16.3 times FY27 estimated Ebitda, while IOC and BPCL trade at 7.4x and 10.4x, as per *Bloomberg*. The stocks will take further cues from geopolitical developments and how crude prices behave.

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Zee founder's repayment plan stayed by NCLT bench

Earlier order can't take effect as it lacked NCLT's majority view, the five-member bench said

Krishna Yadav & Yash Tiwari
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has stayed an earlier order approving Zee founder Subhash Chandra's ₹6.5 crore repayment plan, reopening a challenge to a proposal opposed by several lenders.

A five-member special bench of the NCLT led by president Justice Anupinder Singh Grewal clarified that the order of member Nitesh Sharma, delivered on 25 August, could not be given effect because it did not constitute the majority view of the tribunal.

The bench, comprising Justice Grewal, judicial members Bachu Venkat Balaram Das and Mahendra Khan-delwal Das and technical members Atul Chaturvedi and Ravindra Chaturvedi, on Tuesday restrained Chandra from selling or transferring property held by him, directly or indirectly, during the pendency of the matter. The direction came after solicitor general Tushar Mehta appeared for the creditors and sought protection of Chandra's assets.

The NCLT issued notices to the parties and said it will hear them at length before taking a decision on the repayment plan. The next hearing is scheduled for 23 September. The outcome will determine the future of Chandra's proposal, which seeks to settle claims linked to personal guarantees he provided for corporate borrowings. "We have complete faith and confidence in our judicial system," Chandra's office said in response to *Mint*'s query.

The issue is whether the repayment plan is binding on creditors who opposed it. Chandra's plan proposed payment of ₹6.5 crore, of which ₹6.25 crore will go to creditors

Subhash Chandra: insolvency timeline



and ₹25 lakh towards insolvency process costs. It received 80.81% support from creditors by value. Sharma said the plan would be binding on dissenting creditors.

The creditors voting against the plan included LIC Housing Finance, IDBI

The NCLT had clarified on Monday evening that there was no majority view on the repayment plan.

According to insolvency lawyers, the setting up of such a large special bench is unprecedented in the NCLT's history. "This is the first time in NCLT's

Somdutta Bhattacharyya, a partner at Argus Partners, said the development was unusual, although there was no legal difficulty in the tribunal reconsidering the matter.

"There has been a lot of public discourse and hype around the matter, which may have prompted the NCLT to constitute a five-member bench," Bhattacharyya said.

According to Akshaya Bhansali, managing partner at Rajani Associates, the case shows that the commercial value of a repayment plan cannot substitute for a legally sound process, which must ultimately produce a clear and reasoned majority view.

The creditors simultaneously challenged the repayment plan before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT). Minutes after the NCLT special bench proceedings ended, Mehta appeared before the NCLAT for creditors including LIC Housing Finance, HDFC Bank and Union Bank of India.

Mehta asked the NCLAT to consider whether its intervention was needed now that the NCLT had stayed the earlier order. The NCLAT listed the matter for Wednesday.

Bhattacharyya from Argus Partners said the outcome of the matter before the tribunals would be watched closely, especially by the dissenting creditors. "The best outcome would be to get clarity on the position of dissenting creditors in personal insolvency cases," he said. "If you dissent against a repayment plan, what is your ultimate remedy? Can you pursue a separate recovery proceeding?" He also said the case could lead to greater scrutiny of personal guarantors.

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Meesho's growth bet: turning small sellers into D2C brands

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Meesho is redesigning its seller ecosystem as its marketplace expands beyond experienced online merchants to a much larger pool of small businesses that may know how to make or source a product but have little experience selling online, chief business officer Milan Partani told *Mint*.

The shift comes as Meesho's seller base crosses 1 million. Annual transacting sellers rose 87% year-on-year to 961,000 in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), from 515,000 a year earlier, according to its FY26 annual report. In the June quarter (Q1FY27), the base reached 1.04 million, up 81% from a year earlier, Partani said.

The tools include artificial intelligence (AI)-powered image processing that can extract product attributes, classify listings and help sellers create catalogues, alongside automation for product discovery and demand intelligence. Meesho said these seller-focused product changes helped drive the increase in annual transacting sellers.

The expansion is feeding into Meesho's growth. Consolidated net loss narrowed to ₹132 crore in Q1FY27 from ₹290 crore a year ago, while revenue from operations rose 48% to ₹3,713 crore. Net merchandise value (NMV) rose 34% to ₹11,614 crore.

"Q1FY27 results reinforce our constructive medium-term view on Meesho, with user-led scale-up and continued expansion of the seller ecosystem driving strong underlying growth," broker-



Meesho's seller base crossed 1 million, with annual transacting sellers rising 87% to 961,000 during 2025-26. REUTERS

age Choice Institutional Equities said in a note on 24 July.

The redesign has not eliminated every friction point. Karan Jain, founder of Bengaluru-based sarees seller Mohan's, said Meesho's dashboard is easier to use than those of some competing platforms, but advertising remains difficult to navigate. "Meesho is easier for me to use than some of the other platforms because the dashboard is simpler and easier to understand. I'm still trying to figure out the advertising side, though. I don't understand how to use the different ad options or what gives me the best returns," Jain told *Mint*.

Meesho is also trying to move sellers beyond unbranded goods through Meesho Mall, its separate section for slightly premium products offered by established names such as Hindustan Unilever Ltd and Philips.

Partani said sellers that previously operated in the unbranded segment are upgrading product quality and packaging in response to demand on Meesho Mall, with some going on to build direct-

to-consumer brands.

"When you look closely at what Mall is unlocking, it's a large base of sellers who were previously in non-branded categories. With the demand they see on Meesho, they're upgrading their products and packaging, and many are now trying to build D2C brands of their own," Partani noted.

The opportunity is particularly relevant in FMCG, grocery, personal care, footwear and innerwear, where "users find value in brands", he said.

Mall crossed 1,200 brands in Q1FY27, while Mall transacting consumers grew 88% year-on-year and Mall NMV rose about 93%, according to the company's Q1 FY27 disclosures. That compares with 34% growth in overall NMV.

But Meesho does not see Mall as a move away from its value proposition. Partani said consumers in smaller towns already buy brands, but often in smaller packs and at price points suited to their budgets.

"We are not serving a different consumer or a different need. We are serving our existing consumer and adding a need that we weren't serving before. So it's an addition, not a replacement," said Partani.

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Sun Pharma signs US drug pricing deal

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Drug major Sun Pharmaceutical Industries has signed a deal with the US government to lower prices of its innovative drugs in the US, in line with the lowest prices paid by other developed nations, under the most favoured nation (MFN) pricing framework. It has also committed to applying MFN pricing to future innovative medicine launches, the company said on Tuesday.

Under the agreement, Sun Pharma will also avoid tariffs on innovative pharmaceutical products for more than two years. The drugmaker signed the deal with the US government on 31 August, along with eight other mid-sized pharmaceutical companies, to extend MFN pricing for innovative drugs to state Medicaid programmes. Other terms of the agreements are confidential.

Sun Pharma shares fell following the news, closing 2.9% lower at ₹1,927.20 apiece on the National Stock Exchange on Tuesday.

Sun Pharma and eight other drugmakers, including Teva



Sun Pharma will lower prices of innovative drugs in the US under the MFN framework, including for future launches.. MINT

Pharmaceuticals, BeOne Medicines and BridgeBio, will collectively invest at least \$19.6 billion in US manufacturing in the near term, showed a White House fact sheet.

They will also contribute active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs) to Strategic Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients Reserve (SAPIR) in the US. Sun Pharma will contribute 71.4 tonnes of ceftriaxone and 6.75 tons of doxycycline, both antibiotics used to treat bacterial infections.

The deal is part of President

Donald Trump's MFN pricing drive to reduce drug costs for US patients. The US government has so far reached deals with 26 pharmaceutical manufacturers, such as Pfizer, AstraZeneca, Eli Lilly and Novo Nordisk, covering 89% of branded drug market.

In April, the US imposed a 100% tariff on branded drugs, with firms signing agreements exempted from the levy. The government said in July that it would impose 100% tariffs on generics from 2028, a move that

could affect Indian drugmakers more heavily and raise costs for US patients.

"The United States is a key area of investment and expansion for Sun Pharma across clinical development, sales and marketing, and both API and finished products manufacturing," said Rick Ascroft, North America CEO, Sun Pharma, who represented the company at the White House. "We are proud to play our part in delivering the medicines that millions of American patients count on every day."

Sun Pharma initially built its US presence on a foundation of high-quality generics followed by increasing emphasis on innovative and specialty medicines. The firm ranks second by prescriptions in US dermatology and continues to expand across dermatology and immunology, cutaneous oncology, and ophthalmology.

Sun Pharma's innovative product portfolio continues to outpace its US generics sales, with global innovative medicines sales growing 12.8% year-on-year to \$351 million in the first quarter of FY27, accounting for 21.9% of total sales.

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Parle appoints former PepsiCo exec George Kovoor as CEO

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PO-bound Parle Products, maker of iconic brands such as Parle-G biscuits and Melody chocolates, has appointed fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) veteran George Kovoor as its chief executive officer.

Kovoor spent over 30 years at PepsiCo across geographies, including China and the US, before serving as senior vice president and general manager of its India beverages business. He began his career with Brooke Bond India, owned by Hindustan Unilever Ltd.

After retiring from PepsiCo in March 2025, Kovoor founded an independent leadership firm, Ask GeKo Advisors LLP.

With his appointment, Parle Products now has a seven-member management team to steer the company as it prepares for a public issue worth over \$1 billion, according to a report by Moneycontrol. Alongside Kovoor as



The FMCG firm is preparing for a \$1 billion-plus IPO.

CEO, the team features longtime Parle Products executives, including chief marketing officer Mayank Shah and chief technology officer Sanjay Joshi.

"We welcome George and look forward to working closely with him to build on Parle's strong foundation, strengthen our capabilities, and open new opportunities for sustainable growth. As our business continues to evolve with the changing needs of Indian consumers, his ability to drive results, develop talent, and navigate

complex markets will be invaluable. The company looks forward to his leadership and contribution to its next phase of growth," Ajay Chauhan, managing director and a member of the promoter family, said in a press statement.

Parle Products has long been managed by the Chauhan family, headed by chairman Vijay Chauhan, whose son Ajay Chauhan serves as managing director. The family also has three executive directors on the board: Arup Chauhan, Samar Sharad Chauhan, and Ambika Chauhan Aibara.

Parle Products reported revenues of ₹18,209.2 crore for FY25, up 7% year-on-year, while profits fell by a third to ₹1,182 crore. The company has yet to report its FY26 financial results. In recent years, Parle has expanded into new product categories, launching branded atta in 2021 and partnering with ice-cream maker Vadilal this past June to roll out frozen desserts under the Melody brand.

JioHotstar has a new slate for UK, Canada, Singapore

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JioHotstar, created by merging Disney+ Hotstar and JioCinema, has launched in the UK, Canada and Singapore as it expands its reach among the South Asian diaspora and a wider global audience. The platform will add over 30,000 hours of content annually, with its app available on the App Store and Google Play Store in all three markets, the firm said in a statement.

JioHotstar will air new originals, including *AI Baba Aur Chaddis Bhoat*, *Prince of Mollywood*, *Part Timers* and *The Court*, and new seasons of reality show *Bigg Boss* in six languages. Audiences will be able to vote live for every edition of *Bigg Boss* across Singapore, Canada and the UK. Canada viewers will also be able to watch *Bigg Boss Hindi* seven days ahead of its TV broadcast.

India Ka Top 1 Percent, a new format that tests contestants' logic and reasoning, hosted by actor Anil Kapoor, will be aired in Canada and Singapore.

Viewers can also access JioStar TV channels—Star Plus, Colors, Star Vijay, Asianet, Star Jalsha and Star Pravah. Subscribers in Canada and Singapore access to shows like *Anupama* and *Yeh Rishita Kya Keh-lata Hai*, while UK audiences can watch shows alongside TV. It will offer subtitles/dubs in 12-plus languages such as Hindi, Malayalam, Gujarati, Kannada and Marathi. "South Asian audiences have a deep connection with Indian entertainment across languages, generations and households," Amit Malhotra, head, international business, JioStar, said.

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WeWork inks managed office lease deal with Cognizant in Chennai

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Flexible workspace operator WeWork India has signed a 141,392 sq ft managed office deal with Cognizant Technology Solutions India Pvt. Ltd in Chennai, marking its maiden lease transaction with the information technology (IT) services major, said two people familiar with the development.

The office space has been leased to Cognizant across two floors at Embassy Splendid TechZone, an office park, on Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam Road, which can accommodate 2,605 seats. The lease

tenure is 24 months. Cognizant will be paying around ₹14,000 per seat per month at the WeWork India centre.

Earlier this year, US-headquartered Cognizant pre-leased about 650,000 sq ft at the same property from Embassy Office Parks REIT to set up a global capability centre (GCC) for its client, US Bancorp, on a build-operate-transfer (BOT) basis. Under the BOT model, a company typically builds and operates a facility for a client and then transfers it to the latter after a period of time. In a pre-lease transaction, the agreement to rent the property is made before it is constructed.

"The Cognizant-WeWork



WeWork signed its first deal with Cognizant for a 141,392 sq ft, 2,605-seat managed office at ₹14,000 per seat a month. MINT

transaction indicates the growing preference for flexible, incubation spaces. There are a number of deals where a large company takes up a man-

aged office or a flexible workspace to operate from before moving to a larger, more permanent office space," said the first person mentioned above,

who did not wish to be named. Spokespersons from Cognizant and WeWork India did not respond to *Mint*'s queries.

Cognizant is recalibrating and consolidating real estate footprint in India over the last couple of years. Last year, the technology firm sold a property spread in Chennai to prominent commercial office developer Bagmane Constructions for over ₹600 crore. It is likely to be developed into an office park in the future.

Simultaneously, Cognizant

has been taking up space on lease for clients and renewing existing office leases.

WeWork India entered Chennai in 2024, and currently has three operational centres in the city. One of the largest flex office operators in the country, it has 79 spanning 9.1 million sq ft, with around 113,400 members. It is majority-owned and promoted by property developer

FLEX DEMAND
COGNIZANT had earlier pre-leased 650,000 sq ft at the property for a US Bancorp GCC

THE deal reflects growing demand for flexible spaces before firms move to permanent offices

Embassy Group, and operates as a separate business. India's commercial office

market defied the West Asia war and its global impact with strong leasing in the January-June period across the top cities, propelled by global capability centres (GCCs) and flexible workspace operators.

The sector recorded gross leasing of 45.5 million sq ft in the first half of 2026, the highest ever recorded in any half-year period, up from 41.5 million sq ft last year, according to CBRE South Asia Pvt. Ltd. GCCs anchored demand, accounting for 43% of total office space taken up during the period, with leasing by these centres reaching an all-time high of 19.6 million sq ft.

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Eureka Forbes fined as consumer complaints top 5k

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The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) flagged 5,008 consumer grievances against Eureka Forbes Ltd, owned by private-equity firm Advent International, relating to its water purifiers and after-sales service. It fined the company ₹5 lakh.

In its order, reviewed by *Mint*, the CCPA found several claims on annual maintenance contracts (AMCs), while warranty benefits and refund policies were misleading or inadequately disclosed.

Consequently, the watchdog imposed a ₹5 lakh penalty on Eureka Forbes and directed it to strengthen disclosures, provide do-it-yourself videos for minor repairs, ensure availability of genuine spare parts and periodically review the way it addresses grievances.

As per the 5 August order, CCPA took suo motu cognisance of complaints registered on the National Consumer Helpline between 1 April 2023 and 27 June 2024. "Of the 5,008 complaints, 2,161



CCPA imposed a ₹5 lakh fine on Eureka Forbes. ISTOCKPHOTO

alleged fraud.

Eureka Forbes has around 40% market share in India's water-purifier segment, as per Crisil Ratings. In QIFY27, the company's water-purifier business recorded high-teens revenue growth. Overall revenue rose 15.3% year-on-year to ₹700.8 crore in the quarter.

Queries emailed to spokespersons for the department of consumer affairs, Eureka Forbes and its chief executive officer Pratik Pota remained unanswered.

CCPA flagged consumer grievances relating to Eureka's water purifiers and after-sales service

The CCPA found some consumers were given details of products and services that differed from the actual AMC terms.

The regulator flagged misleading ads on lifetime free re-installation and uninstallation, 30 days money-back guarantee and a "no-questions-asked" return policy.

India's water-purifier market is likely to grow from \$3.95 billion in 2026 to \$7.50 billion by 2034, as per Imarc Group.

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Moody's sees meagre GDP gain from data centre boom

Report also projects barely 0.02% rise in data centre jobs in India over the next four years

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Despite billions of dollars being invested in data centres, the industry may add just 0.13% to India's gross domestic product (GDP) by 2030, when a sizeable share of planned capacity is expected to be operational.

In a report published on Tuesday, global credit ratings agency Moody's said data centres would have an even smaller impact on employment, projecting a meagre 0.02% increase in jobs in India over the next four years.

India would trail Malaysia, Singapore and Thailand, all of which are expected to get a greater economic boost from data centres.

To be sure, India is expected to become the world's third-largest economy by 2030, with a projected GDP of \$7.3 trillion, according to government estimates. At that scale, even a rapidly expanding data-centre industry could remain economically small. A back-of-the-envelope calculation suggests that a 0.13% contribution would amount to roughly \$9.5 billion in annual GDP.

Over the past 12 months, domestic conglomerates, global Big Tech giants and smaller independent firms have together announced more than \$250 billion in investments, betting on the sector's growth. These include Google and Adani's \$15-billion, 1-gigawatt (GW) data-centre project in Visakhapatnam and Tata Consultancy Services' \$7-billion, similarly sized HyperVault project, announced in October 2025.

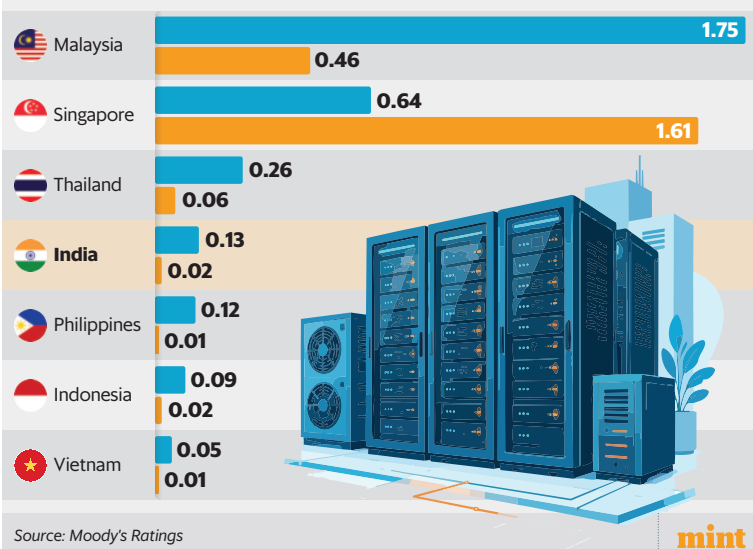
On 27 July, independent research firm Wood Mackenzie projected that India's net active data-centre capacity

Over-inflated?

Data centres may add just 0.13% to India's GDP by 2030.

Impact of data centres in each country

■ GDP contribution (%) ■ Job contribution (%)



would reach 12GW by 2030.

The investor optimism around data centres has even drawn the Centre into the push. On 1 February, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman announced a complete tax holiday

Each of India's top conglomerates, including Tata Sons, Reliance Industries, Adani Enterprises, Larsen & Toubro and Airtel's parent Bharti Enterprises, have ventured into the sector, drawn by the prospect of large

NOT ADDING UP

INDIA is pegged to become the third largest economy by 2030, with projected GDP of \$7.3 trillion

AT that scale, even a rapidly expanding data-centre industry could remain economically small

A calculation suggests that a 0.13% contribution would amount to roughly \$9.5 bn in yearly GDP

INDIA is likely to see data centres account for less than 5% of its net national power consumption by '30

until 2047 for foreign cloud service providers that use Indian data centres to host data or run workloads.

Data centres are modern-day factories that store, process and transfer vast tranches of data, the currency of modern-day artificial intelligence.

orders to store and run data in the country.

Yet, relative to the size of India's economy, Moody's said that the sector will remain small. "India's planned investment and construction employment are substantial in absolute terms

but small relative to the size of the economy. The investment is strategically and locally important, but is not yet large enough to materially change the national growth profile," the report by analysts Deborah Tan and others read.

Moody's also added that the country is likely to see data centres account for less than 5% of its net national power consumption by 2030, indicating a smaller impact on resources than previously projected.

Industry stakeholders labelled the assessment fair, noting that revenue from data centres may not be commensurate with committed investments.

"The large capital investment does not translate into equally large domestic value addition. A significant share of spending goes into imported servers, graphics processing units (GPUs) and other specialized equipment, while the domestic contribution is concentrated in construction, power, connectivity and hosting revenues," said Kashyap Kompella, chief executive of technology consultancy firm, RPA2AI Research.

Concerns around infrastructure are emerging. On 3 August, *Mint* reported that shortages of transmission lines and substation capacity are emerging as critical bottlenecks that could slow the country's data-centre expansion.

A bigger question, as Moody's report raised, is whether India can turn the massive capacity build-out into a larger economic opportunity.

"The immediate priority is utilization. Data-centre operators need enough sustained demand from hyperscalers, enterprises and cloud providers to keep expensive capacity occupied and generate recurring returns," Kompella added.



Maruti Suzuki reported a 21.3% increase in total sales in August to 219,220 units. PTI

Automobile dispatches rise in Aug; Maruti sees 21.3% jump

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Indian automakers' sales to dealers advanced in August from a year earlier as demand in Asia's third-largest economy stayed strong heading into the festive season, data showed on Tuesday.

The year-over-year lift was also in part as buyers had held back purchases in August 2025 before New Delhi's tax cuts took effect.

Maruti Suzuki, India's top automaker by sales, reported a 21.3% increase in total sales in August to 219,220 units. Sales dropped 9.2% sequentially, which the firm attributed to fewer working days.

Rivals Mahindra & Mahindra, Hyundai Motor India and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles saw sales rise 42%, 8.8%, and 56%, respectively, from a year earlier.

Data released on Monday showed India's economy expanded by a steeper-than-expected 7.8% in the April-June quarter as an investment boom and manufacturing strength added to already-solid consumer demand.

The upbeat auto sales come despite elevated fuel prices. India is one of the economies most exposed to oil supply disruptions emanating from the Iran war.

Going ahead, auto sales growth is expected to moderate in the second half of the fiscal year as the "favourable base effect" wanes, according to industry experts.

"This year will be a year of two halves, much like last year. H1 and H2 will have different growth rates," Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer for marketing and sales at Maruti Suzuki, said during a briefing.

Yash Agrawal, an auto analyst at Nirmal Bang, agreed, but said the moderation in demand would be because of the high base rather than "any weakness in overall consumer optimism."

He added that consumers were advancing vehicle purchases amid concerns that automakers could raise prices further if commodity costs remained elevated. Auto firms like Maruti, Mahindra, Tata and Hyundai have rolled out multiple price hikes this year to pass on rising costs to buyers.

Vincent K.A., a senior research analyst at Geojit Investments, said that "margin pressure remains a concern" for Maruti and the trajectory of exports will be a key factor to watch in the near term.

Wipro's output tracker to curb idle time FPIs are back, but a market breakout may have to wait

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PowerPoint, Outlook, Chrome, or other work-related tools on a Wipro-issued device.

If no activity is reported on the laptops, a leave may be triggered, linking lack of digital activity to employee leave. They can, however, contest inaccurately depicted leaves.

Attendance systems may trigger notifications if no device login is detected on a scheduled working day, prompting timely updates such as leave or TMS corrections to maintain compliance," read the company's FAQ memo. The internal missive detailed that leaves may be deducted when records indicate there was no login activity on a Wipro-issued device, no approved leave, no swipe records at a company office location and no client-site visit recorded for the date.

Wipro, however, clarified it does not track personal activity, keystrokes or record screen content. The move on the activity tracker saw a mixed response from employees.

"Our timesheet may show that we were logged in for a certain amount of time, but Time-Scope shows another data point altogether. We have to



Wipro clarified it does not track any personal activity. REUTERS

raise these issues time and again," said an employee on the condition of anonymity.

Wipro has differentiated regular attendance with the time logged in through Time-Scope, and said the latter will track employee effort. "Time-Scope reflects only Wipro-issued device-based digital activity time.

Timesheets capture total work hours and remain the final record for effort reporting," read the memo.

A second employee

in-charge of planning the tool rollout said the move came on the request of clients and to ensure employees don't slack.

"There were two key reasons why we had to roll this out. Firstly, many employees used to login to their work IDs from their phones and they would be on vacation then rather than actually working on their projects.

Secondly, many clients wanted to track employee productivity, which is why this is being rolled out," said the second employee on the condition of anonymity.

Wipro is installing TimeScope on laptops in order to help employees track the time spent on websites

At least one analyst attributed Wipro's move to better tracking of productivity ahead of the rise in automation tools and rising outcome-based projects. "Earlier, billing was done based on punch-in hours. Now, as companies are moving towards AI implementation, outcomes are now tracked where billing is done on milestones rather than time spent at the office. For this, IT firms and their clients need employees to work more efficiently, which is why IT firms are doubling down on tracking productivity," said Amit Chandra, vice-president at HDFC Securities.

Another analyst said such tools are being used to track returns of AI on investments. "Providers need evidence that AI investments are translating into reduced effort and improved delivery economics, rather than simply adding another layer of tech expenditure," said Phil Fersht, chief executive of HFS Research. "If AI and automation allow an IT services provider to deliver a \$100 million contract with 700 people instead of 1,000, the economics of that contract changes dramatically."

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

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stages since May," said Rohit Bhayana, co-founder and chief executive of Oister Global.

The demand for such scaled, category-leading businesses has been strong, he said, even as secondary-market sentiment remained subdued amid the West Asia war.

On 26 August, block deals of over ₹10,300 crore were executed across Billionbrains Garage Ventures (Groww), PhysicsWallah and Lenskart, among others, said Kanchan. "Large domestic mutual funds, insurers and pension money such as NPS Trust bought into the Lenskart block, while select foreign investors like Goldman Sachs also participated in the PhysicsWallah deal."

Companies also raised ₹22,406 crore through IPOs and ₹5,450 crore through QIPs in August, according to data from Prime Database. Together, those offerings accounted for almost 40% of the ₹29,361 crore that FPIs net-invested in Indian equities last month, *Mint's* analysis showed.

In July, IPOs worth ₹29,648



Firms raised ₹22,406 crore through IPOs in August. REUTERS

crore and QIPs worth ₹25,114 crore added to the supply of shares, alongside ₹48,454 crore of bulk and block deals. More than two-thirds of FPI investments went into the primary market, the analysis showed.

"That means the FPI flow is absorbing supply rather than necessarily pushing secondary-market prices higher," said Piyush Mehta, smallcase manager and chief investment officer at Caprice Investment.

FPIs have net invested ₹45,711 crore in India's primary markets so far in 2026, even as they have pulled out

nearly ₹2.7 trillion from the secondary markets, the analysis showed.

Bhayana of Oister Global attributes that divergence to a combination of timing, valuations and allocation. The shift coincided with a global realization that investors may have over-invested in artificial intelligence (AI) and data centres, prompting a search for other markets, he said.

With few emerging-market alternatives, India was an obvious destination as valuations became more reasonable, while the expiry of lock-ins opened up fresh supply, Bhayana said. "It was an opportune moment when supply just found its demand."

A deliberate effort by investment banks and IPO book-runners to bring high-quality foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) back to India through primary allocations also helped, according to Bhayana. "There is an obvious incentive to give them (FPIs) meaningful allocations in good IPOs at favourable valuations."

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

United Breweries sees premium beer growing 3x faster than market

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NEW DELHI

United Breweries Ltd (UBL) expects its premium beer business to grow 20-25% annually over the next three to five years, nearly three times the pace of India's broader beer market, as the brewer steps up investment in premium brands and expands its canning capacity.

Premium products, including Heineken, Heineken Silver, Ultra, Ultra Max, account for about 10% of UBL's total business and are growing at more than 20% in volume, managing director and chief executive Vivek Gupta told

Mint.

UBL, which sells Kingfisher Strong, Kingfisher Premium, Heineken, Amstel and other brands, in an exchange filing on Tuesday, announced a ₹110 crore investment in a new canning facility at its Ellora brewery in Maharashtra, its second such investment this year after a canning line announced at its Nizam brewery in Telangana in July.

The Ellora line is expected to start production by the end of September and will initially make cans of Kingfisher Strong, Kingfisher Premium, Bullet Strong and London Pilsner.

UBL currently gets about 20% of its sales nationally from cans, with the rest coming

from bottles, Gupta said. Cans are growing faster than bottles in some states, helped by both premiumization and affordability. "A smaller can can offer a lower price point than a larger bottle, while also being easier to chill, store and carry," he said.

The shift towards cans, however, is not simply a packaging change. Bottles remain more profitable because they can be collected and reused five or six times, while cans become relatively more attractive in markets where returnable bottles are difficult to collect, Gupta said.

Bottles account for close to 80% of UBL's business, with cans making up the balance.



Vivek Gupta, managing director and chief executive officer of United Breweries.

The mix swings hard by state, though in a market like Uttar Pradesh, cans are 70-80% of the business.

Cans are also growing faster

than bottles in several states, driven by both premiumization and affordability, since a 500 ml can is a cheaper entry point than a large bottle. "With

the new can lines in Telangana and Maharashtra, we expect the national can share to move up to 22-23%."

The company is also dealing with higher aluminium costs, which have increased 10-15% amid the West Asia crisis, according to Gupta.

In the June quarter earnings call on 5 August, UBL said price increases across most states and its internal cost-recovery programme had begun to offset some of the pressure.

It also said premium vol-

umes rose about 17%, excluding deliberate cuts in some markets to protect profitability amid higher costs.

The bigger question for brewers is whether India's beer market can move beyond its relatively modest growth rate. Industry estimates peg the market for beer in India at 440-460 million cases a year, with UBL accounting for about half of the market. The company expects the category to grow 7-8% annually.

Karnataka's beer category is

growing at more than 35-40% following changes to its tax structure and retail model, he said. Maharashtra has grown more than 20% over the past two years, while other states have also seen stronger growth following policy changes.

Maharashtra is an important market for UBL, with more than 20% of the state's alcohol retail outlets located there, Gupta said. Some outlets are also dedicated to beer and wine. The company expects demand to continue growing as new consumers reach the legal drinking age, provided the reforms remain in place.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



Indian airlines cut overseas flights; foreign carriers gain

Foreign airlines' share rose to 60.3% from 54% a year ago; Indian carriers' share fell to 39.7%

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Foreign carriers flew more passengers out of India in the first six months of 2026 compared to the same period last year. Meanwhile, home-grown carriers, including Air India and IndiGo, flew fewer planes on international routes and lost market share after facing higher costs from the Pakistan airspace closure and increased jet fuel prices amid the West Asia war.

Domestic airlines accounted for 39.7% of passengers flying out of India in January-June 2026, down from 46% a year ago, data from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) show. Foreign airlines, meanwhile, increased their share to 60.3% from 54%, even as the overall outbound international market contracted.

Simply put, foreign airlines flew about 450,000 more passengers out of India in the first six months of the year, even as Indian carriers lost 1.76 million. As a result, domestic airlines bore the brunt of the market drop and scaled back their flights. The five Indian carriers that have international operations are IndiGo, Air India, Air India Express, Akasa and SpiceJet. There are 78 foreign carriers with operations in India, the largest being Emirates, Etihad and Singapore Airlines.

This shift occurred as Indian airlines scaled back international capacity. Domestic carriers operated 87,768 international departures from India in the first half of 2026—a 19% drop (or 20,114 fewer flights) compared to 107,882 in the same period last year.

Consequently, international passengers flying out of India fell 7% year-on-year, from 19.71 million to 18.40 million. Indian airlines carried 7.3 million passengers from India in January-June,



Foreign carriers flew about 450,000 more passengers from India, while Indian airlines carried 1.76 million fewer passengers in January-June 2026.

REUTERS

down 19.4% from 9.06 million a year earlier. Foreign carriers, in contrast, carried 11.1 million passengers, up 4.2% from 10.65 million. The DGCA does not share departures by foreign carriers from India.

India and low-cost carrier Air India Express, saw combined international departures fall 26% to 39,136 during January-June 2026 from 53,487 a year earlier. Their passenger numbers fell 27% to 3.30 million from 4.54 million a

losses surged past ₹22,000 crore. It expects to start restoring these rationalized routes from September onward. IndiGo's international departures fell 10% to 43,353 in the first half 2026 from 48,082 a year ago, while international departures declined 9% to 3.64 million passengers from 3.98 million a year earlier. Although a smaller capacity cut leaves IndiGo better positioned than some rivals, the airline is still grappling with higher international flying costs driven by longer flight paths.

Akasa's international departures increased about 38% to 2,675 in the first half of 2026, from 1,936 a year earlier. Its international passenger numbers increased to 190,000 from 150,000 a year earlier. International players stepped in to absorb the demand, and market gains were not limited to Gulf carriers. Outbound passenger data from India reveals that several major foreign airlines maintained or expanded their passenger traffic.

Emirates, the largest foreign carrier in India, held broadly stable, carrying 1.40 million passengers from India in January-June 2026 compared with 1.44 million a year earlier. Etihad carried 830,000 (up from 800,000), while Singapore Airlines grew to 680,000 (from 640,000). Lufthansa increased its traffic to 400,000 from 380,000 million, while Cathay Pacific rose sharply to 330,000 from 270,000. Swiss and KLM also saw their India traffic rise to 100,000 and 180,000, respectively, from 80,000 and 160,000.

Together, the seven airlines carried about 3.92 million passengers from India in the first six months of 2026, a 4% increase from 3.77 million a year earlier. The resilience of these major foreign airlines contrasts sharply with the roughly 19% drop in traffic suffered by Indian carriers.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Small creators are in demand but payment delays persist

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NEW DELHI

Small and independent creators, who make up a major chunk of India's creator base, continue to struggle with payment delays and inconsistent work despite brands increasingly turning to them for regional outreach and festive campaigns.

According to a recent report by the Indian School of Business, Hyderabad and Hash-Hash, a brand-creator network platform, more than half of non-metro creators in 2025 were nano creators, defined as those with 1,000 to 10,000 followers. Another 28% were micro creators, with 10,000 to 100,000 followers. Together, they accounted for over 80% of the non-metro creator base.

Industry experts say payment delays can be particularly challenging for regional language, micro and nano creators who may not have established processes around contracts, invoicing and payment follow-ups. Delays are often caused by brand approvals, procurement cycles, invoicing, documentation or changes in campaign timelines rather than an intentional withholding of payment.

For emerging creators, even a small delay can have a larger impact because they may depend heavily on individual collaborations. Income can also swing sharply from month to month as campaigns are irregular and tied to brand budgets and cycles.

"This happens more often in the creator ecosystem than people realize. From the outside, people see the campaigns and the content, but what they



Small creators face irregular payments and uneven work, despite growing demand from brands for campaigns.

ISTOCKPHOTO

don't always see is how unpredictable the flow of money can be," said Shivani Gulhane, a beauty and lifestyle creator.

"A creator often completes the entire process—understanding the brief, planning, shooting, editing, revisions and delivering the content before receiving the payment. Yet payments can sometimes take far longer than expected because of long payment cycles, internal approvals, invoice issues or multiple parties being involved between the brand and creator," Gulhane said, adding that for smaller creators, this can be particularly challenging.

"Unlike a regular job where you know when your salary is coming, creators don't always have that certainty," she pointed out. Himadri Patel, a YouTuber, beauty and lifestyle creator and founder of women's wear brand DRRI by Himadri, agreed that late or delayed payments is one of the biggest operational challenges, particularly for micro and nano-creators. Larger creators may have talent managers, legal support or stronger negotiating power, while smaller creators often

manage follow-ups themselves. Payments can stretch well beyond the originally agreed timeline, she added.

Many brands and agencies operate on 60- or 90-day payment cycles, while creators may have already paid editors, photographers, studios, travel and other production costs upfront. This can create significant cash-flow pressure.

Smaller campaigns are also sometimes finalized over WhatsApp, email or DMs without detailed contracts covering payment timelines, deliverables and other commercial terms.

"A creator may earn ₹1-1.5 lakh in one month and then have very little paid work the next month. Campaigns can get postponed, budgets can change or approvals can take longer than expected. For example, a creator may have three campaigns lined up worth ₹30,000 each, but if two are pushed to the following month, their expected ₹90,000 income suddenly becomes ₹30,000. Their costs, however, such as editors, equipment, travel and production, continue," said Sanya Bajaj, co-founder at Crack'd, an influencer marketing agency.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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**NIT FOR PURCHASE OF POWER TE(P)-01/301
DATED 31.08.26.**

MPPMCL intends to invite bids for procurement of up to 800 MW Power in different time slots for the period from 20th Nov 2026 to 31st Mar 2027 from various Power Trading licensees/generators/state utilities/CPPS/Distribution licensees/SEBs. The due date for submission of bid is 15.09.2026 up to 11:00 Hour. Details can be sought from website www.mppmcl.com and www.mstcecommerce.com. Further any corrigendum or other information may be sought from websites on time to time. M.P. Madhyam/127820/2026 **ED (PM)**

MADHYA PRADESH POWER TRANSMISSION COMPANY LIMITED
Block No.3, Shakti Bhawan, Rampur, Jabalpur-482 008
Ph. : (0761)270-2197,2181,2192,2264, procurement@mptransco.nic.in

Online Tenders are invited against TR-24/2026 for Construction of Various Transmission facilities on Turnkey Basis (on 2025-26 SOR rate basis) & TR-27/2026 for Procurement of 220/132/33kV, 200MVA Power Transformer with oil, erection, testing and commissioning with supply of essential maintenance/mandatory spares/equipment's. For further details please visit website <https://www.mstcecommerce.com>, <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> & <https://www.mpttransco.in>

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CHHATRAPATI SAMBHAJINAGAR MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
Address: Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar Municipal Corporation
Town Hall, Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar (MS) 431001.

Outward/CSMC/DMC-1/2026/151 Date: 31/08/2026

Tender Notice

"I" Time

An e-tender for the appointment of a private agency to conduct a survey of all properties within the Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar Municipal Corporation limits and to prepare a new assessment register in accordance with Rule 21 Of MMC Act has been published on the website <https://mahaetenders.gov.in> (Tender ID: 2026_AMCA_1326391_2). Interested bidders are requested to submit their tenders online, along with the necessary documents, on the said website within the prescribed timeframe.

Sd/-
Amol Jananath Yedage (I.A.S.)
Commissioner, Municipal Corporation
Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar

DELHI METRO RAIL CORPORATION LTD.
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INVITATION FOR BIDS

Delhi Metro Rail Corporation Ltd. invites online open e-tenders from eligible Bidders for the design, execution and completion of "Contract D2C-04: Part Design & Construction of Elevated Viaduct, Integrated Double-Deck Structure (including Ramp) between UER-II and Bawana Industrial Area Sec-1,2 Station and Ten Elevated Stations viz Rohini Sector-25, Rohini Sector-26, Rohini Sector-31, Rohini Sector-28, Rohini Sector-29, 30, Rohini Sector-35, Barwala, Rohini Sector-34, Bawana Industrial Area Sector-3,4, Bawana Industrial Area Sector-1,2 (Including) (Civil Works excluding Pre-Engineered Building Roof Structure works and Architectural Finishes) from Chhainage-0 m to 11299.093 m of Rithala-Kundli corridor of Phase-IV of Delhi MRTS."

International Competitive Bidding will be conducted in accordance with Japan International Cooperation Agency's "Single-Stage Two-Envelope" Bidding Procedure.

For detailed information log on to www.delhimetrorail.com or e-tendering website <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.

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Auction of Government of India Dated Securities for ₹32,000 crore on September 04, 2026

Government of India has announced the sale (issue / re-issue) of following dated securities:

Sr. No	Nomenclature	Notified amount Nominal (in ₹Crore)	Earmarked for Retail Investors (in ₹Crore)
1	New GS 2031	21,000	1,050
2	7.71% GS 2066	11,000	550

The securities will be sold through Reserve Bank of India, Mumbai Office, Fort, Mumbai - 400001, as per the terms and conditions spelt out in the General Notification F.No.4(2)-B(W&M)/2018, dated March 26, 2025 and the Specific Notification issued in this regard.

The auction will be conducted using **multiple price method** on **September 04, 2026 (Friday)**. The result will be announced on the same day and payment by successful bidders will have to be made on **September 07, 2026 (Monday)**.

Retail investors can participate in the auction on a non-competitive basis as per the Scheme for non-competitive bidding facility. Individual investors can also place bids through the Retail Direct portal (<https://rbiretaildirect.org.in>).

For further details, please see press release dated **August 31, 2026** on RBI website (www.rbi.org.in).

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GIFT GUJARAT INTERNATIONAL FINANCE TEC-CITY COMPANY LIMITED (GIFTCL)

E-Tender Notice for Invitation to Bid for Selection of Contractor for Work on EPC Basis

Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited invite bids from reputed, qualified, experienced and financially sound Contractor for the following Work:

Name of Work	Estimated Cost	Online availability of Bid Document	Last Date of Online & Physical submission of Bid
Development of North Entry SEZ Gate, South Entry SEZ Gate & Customs office at GIFT City on EPC basis (Re-tender) (Bid Reference No.: GIFT/ENG/CW/WC/2026/10)	Rs.3,91 Cr (Excluding GST)	01st September 2026 to 14th September 2026 up to 12:00 hrs	14th September 2026 up to 15:00 hrs

Bid document may be downloaded online from website at <https://tender.nprocure.com>

Tender fee of Bid document is Rs.10,000/- payable in the form of Demand Draft / Banker's Cheque / Pay Order in favor of "Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited" payable at Ahmedabad. For further details and updates please log on to our Website Website www.giftgujarat.in and <https://tender.nprocure.com>

Contact Person:
General Manager (P&C)
Tel: 079-61708300 E-mail: contract@giftgujarat.in

Sd/-
Managing Director & Group CEO
Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited (GIFTCL)
GIFT House, Block-12, Road 1-D, Zone-I, GIFT City, Gandhinagar Gujarat-382050., INDIA.
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Sub- Providing 08 (Eight) labour & Supporting staff at Shahaji Nagar (cheeta camp) Maternity Home, M/E ward on Contract Basis.

Shahaji Nagar (Cheeta Camp) Maternity Home under M/E ward invited proposal from authorized Local NGO'S register in M/E ward experience of providing experienced 08 (Eight) Labour (Hamal, Sweeper) & supporting staff in maternity home on Contract Basis for 06 months. Interested NGO'S may submit application from along with all necessary documents with application fees Rs. 3993/- + 18% GST 720/- total 4713/- from Dt. 02.09.2026 To Dt. 11.09.2026 From 10:30 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. of official working days excluding holiday on below mention address. This application forms will be opened as lottery system in the chamber on Medical Officer Shahaji nagar (Cheeta Camp) Maternity Home.

Address- Medical Officer Shahaji nagar (Cheeta Camp) Maternity Home, 2nd Floor, Cheeta Camp, Trombay, Mumbai-400088

Sd/-
Medical Officer
Shahaji Nagar (Cheeta Camp) Maternity Mankhurd.

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BRIHAN MUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
e-Tender Notice

Department	Chief Engineer (Sewerage Operation)
Division	Executive Engineer Mechanical (Sew.) W. S.
Tender Reference Number	2026_MCGM_1333596_1
Subject	Transportation of grit removed from Versova WWTF and Malad WWTF to private dumping ground outside the BMC limit.
Sale of Tender	From 02.09.2026 Time 11:00 Hrs. To 09.09.2026 Time 16:00 Hrs.
Website	https://mahatenders.gov.in Henceforth Any Corrigendum or Addendum will be publish on BMC portal/ Mahatender Portal Link site only
Communicating Officer:	
A) Name	Shri. Krishna Patil
C) Mobile No.	9820048895
D) E-mail Address	eemechsws.so@mcgm.gov.in
Sd/-	E. E. Mech. (Sew.) W.S.

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OpenAI hits back at Apple lawsuit claiming it stole trade secrets

ChatGPT-maker says suit is 'a mess of Apple's own making'

Rolfe Winkler
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OpenAI hit back at Apple after the iPhone-maker accused it of trade secret theft. In a late-night legal filing, OpenAI asserted that Apple filed a baseless lawsuit in an attempt to hamper its ability to recruit new employees and ultimately stall its effort to develop competing technology. Many of the accusations boil down to poor off-boarding procedures inside the iPhone maker, according to OpenAI.

"This dispute is a mess of Apple's own making, and it is trying to blame everyone else," OpenAI said in the filing, published Monday. "Apple blames employees who left the company for taking their personal accounts with them—even though Apple encouraged them to use personal accounts for work."

Apple's suit, filed in the Northern District of California, accuses OpenAI's chief hardware officer, Tang Tan, and Chang Liu, a member of its technical staff, of taking Apple's confidential information by various means. Both are former Apple employees who went to work for OpenAI.

OpenAI said Tan only emailed himself nonconfidential files, personal notes, and a widely accessible manager's checklist to prepare for his exit from the company. Responding to an accusation that Tan encouraged Apple employees to bring "actual parts" to OpenAI interviews for "show and tell," OpenAI said any parts they brought were old or publicly available components used as "demonstrative aids," which is common practice in engineering interviews.



In its filing, OpenAI cited 400 employees who have defected from Apple to join its ranks.

REUTERS

In defense of Liu, OpenAI said Apple staff reached out to him after he left, asking for help to locate files they still needed and that he obliged.

Apple didn't respond to requests for comment.

The lawsuit shows how the relationship between the two companies has rapidly deteriorated since 2024, when they signed a deal to have OpenAI's ChatGPT work with Apple's Siri chatbot. Apple's new Siri AI, announced in June, is powered by Google's Gemini technology.

OpenAI has emerged as a dangerous potential competitor to Apple. The company hopes to develop AI-driven devices that could compete with

Apple's hero product, the iPhone, on which Apple has so far failed to deliver compelling AI experiences.

In the suit, OpenAI says its "first expected hardware product is a new type of consumer device that differs materially from known Apple products."

Tan spent 24 years at Apple, rising to become a senior executive on its product design team. He worked closely with Jony Ive, Apple's former head of industrial design. Tan left Apple to join Ive's AI device startup to Products, which subsequently merged with OpenAI.

The lawsuit doesn't name Ive, who is known to be close to Laurene Powell Jobs, the widow of Apple's co-founder, Steve Jobs.

Steve Jobs.

OpenAI took potshots at Apple in its filing, citing 400 employees who have defected from the iPhone-maker to join its ranks.

"Apple cannot stop the next 400 employees from leaving by filing baseless lawsuits," the suit says. "They can leave a company like Apple that has struggled to adopt AI and move to an exciting startup that builds innovative products. Apple may not like those choices. But it cannot claim those choices are unlawful."

The Wall Street Journal's parent company, News Corp, has a content deal with OpenAI as well as a commercial agreement to supply news through Apple services.

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Motilal Oswal expects record public market fundraising

Mansi Verma
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MUMBAI

India's public market fundraising window has opened up sharply as initial public offerings (IPOs), qualified institutional placements (QIPs), and block deals pick up simultaneously—a rare combination, according to Amit Ramchandani, head of investment banking at Motilal Oswal. He added that overall fundraising is projected to rise to a record ₹6-6.5 trillion in fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

"Unlike earlier cycles, market participation today is genuinely broad-based across market capitalizations and deal sizes," dealmaker Ramchandani told *Mint* in an interview on Wednesday. He joined the Motilal Oswal Group as the chief executive officer (CEO) of investment banking after previously leading the same division at JM Financial.

This pickup follows a months-long lull, with several IPOs—including Milky Mist, Shiprocket, and Gaja Capital—

hitting the market, alongside new block deals in Billionbrains Garage Ventures, Physicswallah, Rubicon Research, Welspan Corp, and Viyash Scientific.

Block deals are also increasingly being executed close to prevailing market prices rather than at steep discounts, Ramchandani said. "Institutional investors are increasingly focused on securing meaningful allocations rather than fine-tuning entry prices, fueling immense momentum in the block window," he said.

Ramchandani expects this momentum to accelerate through the second half of



Public market fundraising is projected to rise to a record ₹6-6.5 trillion in FY27, according to the company.

MINT

FY27, with at least 20 IPOs in September alone. He anticipates FY27 will comfortably surpass FY26 in both the volume and value of IPOs.

"Following the 112 IPOs last fiscal, we anticipate a 20-25% uptick this year," he said. In value terms, IPO fundraising could rise to ₹2.75-3 trillion in FY27, from around ₹1.7 trillion in FY26, he added. He noted that despite a slow start in the first half of the year, strong second-half volume should easily push the full-year figures past these levels.

QIP fundraising is also expected to roughly double to ₹1.25-1.5 trillion in FY27 from ₹60,000-62,000 crore last year.

"Both put together we should be anywhere between ₹4.5 trillion to ₹5 trillion, which should be the highest that the industry has ever seen," Ramchandani said. He added that block and bulk deal volumes are also set to expand to ₹1.5 trillion in FY27, taking total public market fundraising to ₹6-6.5 trillion.

Over the past few months, Motilal Oswal was among the banks involved in SBI Funds Management \$1 billion IPO,

ICICI Prudential asset management \$1.2 billion IPO, and Raajmarg InVIT \$650 million IPO, among others.

In an interview on Wednesday, BofA Securities' head of India corporate and investment banking Mandar Donde also told *Mint* that India's IPO market is poised for a busier second half, with large deals in the pipeline and more multinational corporations looking to list their local subsidiaries.

Beyond total issuance volume, public offering strategies and pricing dynamics are also shifting. Companies are increasingly accepting lower initial IPO valuations and floating smaller offerings. The goal is to establish a public market benchmark first, enabling issuers to sell larger, secondary stakes through block deals later once trading normalizes. "Once the stock gets listed then they are able to find their benchmark and subsequent to that you see a lot of blocks coming," Ramchandani said.

New-age companies like Lenskart and Urban Company adopted this approach by launching IPOs at more reasonable valuations, which allowed the public market to smoothly absorb their shares.

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How Irdai wants to build a digital insurance backbone

Samridhi Mahar

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has outlined a much wider role for its proposed Public Insurance Registry (PIR), envisaging an infrastructure that could connect insurance data with credit information, lending, identity systems and public databases.

Irdai first brought the idea into the public domain on 17 March through an industry discussion. A consultation paper released on Tuesday provides the first detailed view of how the regulator envisages the infrastructure working.

Mint explains what Irdai has proposed.

What is the Public Insurance Registry and why is Irdai proposing it?

Irdai has proposed PIR as a population-scale digital public infrastructure for the insurance sector. Subject to consent and other safeguards, the platform could bring together standardized information from across the insurance ecosystem and serve insurers, policyholders, financial institutions, reinsurers, government agencies and researchers.

Indian insurers had 3.35 billion policies on their books in fiscal year 2025 (FY25), across 74 insurers, according to Irdai's annual report for FY25.

What could PIR mean for policyholders—and insurers?

The registry could change how customers access and manage their insurance policies. Irdai envisages a consent-based, consolidated view of all policies held by an individual across insurers. This could include coverage, policy status, benefits, premiums and renewal dates, claims history and nominee details.

As of 28 February, ₹8,973.89 crore in unclaimed insurance funds was lying with insurers, according to infor-



A consultation paper released on Tuesday provides the first detailed view of how Irdai envisages the infrastructure working. *MINT*

mation shared by the government in Parliament in March.

The consultation paper also envisages easier health insurance portability and a common digital backbone for filing and tracking grievances across insurers and public grievance platforms.

For insurers, PIR could create a common pool of anonymised information on losses, claims and risk concentrations, helping them identify emerging trends and improve underwriting and pricing.

"PIR could be India's UPI moment—replacing fragmented information with ver-

ified, real time information accessible to each vertical of the insurance life cycle which enables insurance to be a transparent financial product," said Shivangi Sharma Talwar, partner at law firm JSA.

Could insurance data become part of the wider financial system?

The proposed registry could bring insurance policies closer to the broader financial system. Banks and non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) could use PIR to verify ownership of life insurance policies and, where permitted, access information such as surrender and maturity values.

How far could PIR extend beyond insurance?

The registry could create an

industry-wide record of the conduct and performance of insurance intermediaries, sales personnel and agents.

Earlier, *Mint* reported that Irdai chairman Ajay Seth wanted every policy traced to the agent or salesperson who sold it to improve accountability and curb mis-selling. The consultation paper now sets out how this could work.

What does PIR mean for Irdai—and what happens next?

The registry could significantly expand Irdai's ability to monitor the insurance sector. It could consolidate information on complaints, mis-selling, policy discontinuance and distributor conduct, while giving the regulator a clearer view of claims patterns, risk concentrations and emerging problems.

Aggregated insurance data could also help government agencies identify protection gaps, assess public programmes and support policymaking in areas such as agriculture, health, transport and disaster management.

Irdai has sought comments on the data PIR should hold, its identity architecture, privacy and consent safeguards, commercial confidentiality, governance and the transition of insurance records to common standards. Comments are due by 30 September.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

GIC Re faces competition from GIFT City firms

Samridhi Mahar
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MUMBAI

General Insurance Corporation of India (GIC Re) has flagged the influx of new reinsurers into GIFT City as a challenge, even as it remains optimistic about the long-term growth of India's insurance market.

"The outlook for the insurance and reinsurance industry remains positive, although the operating environment will continue to require careful navigation and risk discipline," Hitesh Joshi said in his maiden annual report address as the firm's chairman. The insurer's FY26 annual report was released on Monday.

The chairman and managing director said this was particularly relevant given the influx of new reinsurance players into GIFT City.

GIC Re's domestic business remains its mainstay, contributing around 75% of its ₹44,006.74 crore gross premium income in FY26. However, the business has come under pressure on profitability and is undergoing a change in its composition.

GIC Re's domestic combined ratio, a financial metric used by insurers to assess underwriting profitability, rose to 107% in the June quarter, up from 102% in FY26. A figure above 100 means the reinsurer paid out more than it earned in premiums on that book. On a consolidated basis, the combined ratio for FY26 was 106.02%, compared with 108.81% in FY25. The share of obligatory cessions, business that general insurers must pass on to GIC Re, also fell to 33% of the domestic book in the quarter from 42% in FY26, as the reinsurer seeks to raise its non-obligatory business.

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NEWS
NUMBERS

13.1%

THE RATE of credit growth in metropolitan centres, up from 8.2% a year earlier, but lower than non-metro centres, which grew at above 21%, per RBI data.

\$200 mn

THE AMOUNT edtech company upGrad, led by Ronnie Screwvala, paid to acquire Unacademy, at a fraction of its \$3.44 billion peak valuation.

52.8

THE HSBC India Manufacturing PMI for August, marking the sector's weakest growth in over five years due to a sharp moderation in output and new orders.

2,500

THE NUMBER of employees Indian Bank plans to add this year to manage its growing business and replace retiring staff, as it expands its branch network by 100.

\$2.4 bn

THE AMOUNT lost to cyber fraud in India in 2025, according to government data, as scammers increasingly target the country's digital payments boom.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Ujjivan SFB CEO steps down

Ujjivan Small Finance Bank (SFB) said on Tuesday that chief executive officer (CEO) Sanjeev Nautiyal has stepped down from his role with immediate effect due to health issues and would retire from the bank at the end of November.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) approved the appointment of executive director Carol Furtado as interim CEO from 1 September, the company said late Tuesday.

Ujjivan said Nautiyal, who served as CEO since July 2024, had submitted his request for early retirement on 31 August with a three-month notice period, which was approved by the bank's board. Nautiyal will remain on leave until 30 November, when he will retire from the bank. The board will begin the process of identifying a permanent successor and submit its recommendation to RBI in due course, it said.

REUTERS



CIL's total coal supplies during the first five months of fiscal year 2027 grew 6.7%.

AFP

Coal supplies by CIL rise 5.5% in August

Coal supplies by state-owned Coal India Ltd (CIL) rose 5.5% to 60.60 million tonnes (mt) in August compared with 57.40 mt in the year-ago period.

Coal supplies to the non-regulated sector registered robust growth, increasing by 9.6% to 12.12 mt in August from 11.06 mt in the same month last year, the company said in a statement.

CIL's total coal supplies during the first five months of fiscal year 2027, till August, reached 322.90 mt, compared with 302.60 mt during the corresponding period of the previous year, registering a growth of 6.7%.

The higher supplies also enabled CIL to liquidate around 55 mt of pithead coal stocks during the first five months of the current fiscal.

With approximately 76 mt of coal currently available at its pitheads, CIL has sufficient inventory to support power generation requirements in the coming months. As the intense rainy spells gradually recede and drier months approach, the company is preparing itself to ramp up both production and supplies.

CIL accounts for more than 80% of domestic coal output.

PTI

Auto parts maker Victura said to weigh India IPO

Auto parts maker Victura Technologies Pvt. Ltd has begun discussions with investment banks about a potential initial public offering (IPO) in India, according to people familiar with the matter.

The Faridabad-based company, formerly known as Victora Auto, has held preliminary talks with bankers and is expected to appoint advisers soon, the people said, asking not to be identified because the deliberations are private. The offering could raise as much as \$300 million through a mix of new shares and a sale by existing investors, they said.

Discussions are at an early stage and details including the size, structure and timing of the offering could still change, the people said.

BLOOMBERG

Bank unions to go on nationwide strike on 11 Sep

The United Forum of Bank Unions (UFB) has decided to go on a nationwide strike on 11 September over the delay in implementing five-day banking, differences over the performance-linked incentive scheme and several pending demands, including pension-related issues.

If the strike materializes, banking services, especially in public sector banks, would be impacted for four days in many parts of the country—11 September is a Friday, the subsequent two days are bank holidays, and 14 September is a holiday in some states for Ganesh Chaturthi.

UFB, an umbrella body of seven bank employees' and officers' unions, has also threatened a three-day subsequent nationwide strike beginning 28 September, coinciding with the half-yearly closure.

They have also decided to go on an indefinite strike from 26 October onwards if their demands fall on deaf ears of the government and bank management.

PTI

Reliance enters ice cream market

Billionaire Mukesh Ambani's consumer goods business has launched an ice cream brand with products starting at ₹10, entering a market that includes major global brands such as Magnum and Baskin-Robbins as it deepens its push into packaged goods.

Asia's richest person disrupted India's telecom market 10 years ago with cutthroat pricing to make Reliance the leading player in the industry before relaunching Campa, a soft drink brand that triggered a price war in the competitive cola market.

The new ice cream brand, called Bombay Creamery, will offer cones, cups, tubs, bars and sticks, Reliance Consumer Products said on Tuesday.

Bombay Creamery ice creams are available in western India and will soon be rolled out across the country, the consumer goods arm of Reliance Industries said.

REUTERS

Confront terror-peddling nations: Modi at SCO meet

Dialogue, diplomacy only way forward to resolve global conflicts, says PM

PTI
feedback@livemint.com
BISHKEK, KYRGYZSTAN

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday urged the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) to confront countries using terrorism as an instrument of state policy and reject "double standards" to combat the menace, even as he asserted that dialogue and diplomacy are the only way forward to resolve global conflicts.

In the presence of Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Chinese President Xi Jinping and many other global leaders, Modi said that "we cannot remain confined to an action-reaction approach" in the fight against terrorism, in remarks widely viewed as a direct swipe at Pakistan.

Calling for decisive action within the SCO, the Prime Minister advocated for the comprehensive dismantling of terrorist ecosystems, including funding networks, recruitment pipelines, and territorial sanctuaries. He further affirmed that states utilising terrorism as a policy tool must be warned that terrorism can never be a "strategic asset for anyone".

Modi, expressing concerns over the West Asia crisis, said India has consistently called for all tensions and conflicts to be resolved not on the battlefield, but through dialogue and diplomacy.

The prime minister, in an apparent refer-



Connectivity projects should respect sovereignty and territorial integrity, Modi said.

PTI

ence to China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), said that connectivity projects should respect the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all countries.

The Bishkek Declaration adopted at the close of the summit expressed deep concern at developments in the Middle East and reiterated the SCO's condemnation of military strikes on Iran.

'Avoid foreign travel, gold purchase'

In a video message on Instagram, Prime Minister Modi repeated his call to avoid foreign holidays, overseas weddings, and buying gold unless necessary. Instead, he asked people to go for "Weddings in India." The prime minister also congratulated citizens for India's 7.8% GDP growth. "It has been possible due to their collective resolve and efforts," Modi said.

Singapore beckons as family offices eye global push OVL in talks with PDVSA for \$500 million dividend payout

FROM PAGE 1

man Junaid, founder and chief researcher at Hurun India, a research firm focusing on wealth creation, startups, philanthropy and family businesses.

Family offices can use multiple routes to invest overseas, including setting up branches in offshore financial hubs and investing across global public and private markets, international deals, co-investment platforms, alternatives and multi-currency portfolios.

Baldota Family Office evaluated GIFT City, Dubai and Singapore before deciding to set up an offshore entity in Singapore. The Baldota Group is a mining and metals conglomerate in Karnataka.

Other large family offices including Premji Invest, Munjal Family Office, Patni Family Office and Kothari Family Office have set up or are exploring Singapore entities as investments in technologically advanced sectors overseas become a growing area of interest, at least three people aware of the development told *Mint*.

Premji Invest is the investment arm of the Premji family, founded by Wipro's Azim Premji, and manages over \$18 billion. The Munjal Family Office belongs to the founders of the Hero Group, the world's largest two-wheeler manufacturer. The Patni Family Office is of the Patni brothers, pioneers



Tax sops are one of the factors that drive family offices to explore regulatorily stable jurisdictions such as Singapore.

BLOOMBERG

of India's early IT-services industry through Patni Computer Systems. The Kothari Family Office belongs to Hemendra Kothari, former chairman of the DSP Group, a prominent financial-services group in India.

"Structurally, if India wants to say that it has arrived as a global economy, we have to get much better at allowing capital to move in and out of the country," said Nitesh Aggarwal, chief investment officer for Baldota Family Office. "Indian wealth is becoming much more global, and people will naturally want to diversify some of their wealth outside India. Over time, we need to make that process much easier and more seamless."

Premji Invest declined to comment on its plans. Queries

sent to other family offices did not elicit a response.

Thermax Family Office, which manages the wealth of the Aga and Pudumjee families, promoters of the Thermax Group, predominantly invests in global public markets and also has a relatively smaller private market exposure. It has established a Singapore set-up to invest globally.

"Apart from geographical diversification, a global office helps us access some of the products and strategies that are not available in India, especially hedge funds. There are plenty of strategies that we can access with this global exposure and effectively manage risk in the portfolio," said Anol Sathe, chief investment officer of Thermax Family Office.

Tax incentives too are one of

the factors that drive family offices to explore regulatorily stable jurisdictions such as Singapore, Sathe added.

Indian family offices are becoming larger and more institutional in the way they invest. According to the Julius Baer-EY Indian Family Office Playbook published in August, mid- and large-sized Indian family offices managed about ₹70,000 crore (\$7.33 billion) in assets as of 2024, with assets projected to grow at a 14% CAGR over three years.

The report said family offices have evolved from primarily preserving wealth to investing across start-ups, infrastructure, private credit, alternatives and global markets. The LRS, introduced in 2004, allows individuals, including minors, to freely remit up to \$250,000 per financial year.

Globalization of families and wealth is driving demand for sophisticated cross-border planning, including offshore holding structures, the Julius Baer-EY report said. It added that offshore family offices in Singapore, the UAE and other hubs provide deeper access to global markets and greater regulatory flexibility.

"Singapore and UAE are both more natural jurisdic-

tions for this because they already have a deep ecosystem of family offices and investment managers and it provides a platform for deploying capital globally," Junaid of Hurun India told *Mint*.

Singapore has also built a sizable family-office ecosystem. The number of single-family offices in the city-state crossed 2,000 by end-2024, up 43% from 1,400 in 2023, according to the report.

The report described Singapore as a "gateway for regional

investment" connected to global markets, with a professional ecosystem spanning wealth management, trust structures and succession planning.

For some Indian families, the attraction is also access to investments that may be difficult to pursue from India.

"Whether they are sophisticated combinations of underlying stocks or indices that are used to create fixed coupon notes or unique ideas like life settlement funds, some things can only be explored if you have money sitting outside India," said an investment officer at a large family office, requesting anonymity.

mansiverma@live-mint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

FROM PAGE 1

also being negotiated whether it would be paid in cash or in terms of oil supplies. This should be resolved by the time the framework is prepared," one of the two officials cited above said.

OVL holds 40% stake in Venezuela's San Cristobal oil project and 11% in the Carabobo project, both in partnership with PDVSA. A successful dividend repatriation will be a major relief for the company whose efforts to repatriate dividends have so far failed.

Addressing reporters on Monday after ONGC's annual general meeting, Rajarshi Gupta, managing director of OVL, said the framework for further operations may be complete within three months.

To be sure, this is not the first time OVL's hopes have been raised. The company was set to get the dividends during the six-month US sanctions waiver on Venezuela starting October 2023. However, it failed to receive the cargo during this period, and when sanctions returned, the plan ground to a halt.

Venezuela, which has the world's largest oil reserve, has been under US sanctions since 2015. On 3 January 2026, the US captured President Nicolás Maduro and his wife from Car-



Dividend payout may either be in cash or crude oil.

REUTERS

acas and flew them to the US. Sanctions on Venezuela were lifted shortly afterwards, reopening oil flows. In August, Venezuela became India's fourth-largest supplier of crude at 383,000 barrels per day.

"At a time when the US plans to further tighten Russian supplies and Iranian oil is already sanctioned, Venezuelan oil is key for India. Already from April, supplies from Venezuela have increased. And with American backing now, global investments in the exploration and production space, there may also see a boost," said Sankalp Gurjar, assistant professor (geopolitics and geopolitics), Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics.

As earlier reported by *Mint*,

government-to-government level talks were underway earlier this year over the stuck dividends, and a PDVSA team had visited India in January.

On growing imports from Venezuela and the US, Sumit Ritolia, senior manager, modelling at commodity tracking firm Kpler said: "If U.S. and Venezuelan crude are combined, the Americas are becoming more important to India's crude basket, but the recent increase is predominantly being driven by Venezuela rather than by a major ramp-up in U.S. crude."

Crude supplies and global prices are key for the Indian economy as India is the world's third-largest oil consumer importing nearly 90% of its crude requirement, accounting for about a quarter of the import bill.

Queries mailed to ONGC, OVL, PDVSA, ministries of petroleum and external affairs and the Venezuelan embassy remained unanswered.

On Monday, the White House said that Venezuelan interim authorities have granted US-backed North American Blue Energy Partners, or NABEP, 100-year concessions for 17 oil fields, with proven reserves of about 65 billion barrels.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



Federal Reserve chairman Kevin Warsh has doubled down on his vow to finally tame inflation.

Global bond selloff pushes yields to highest since 2008

Bloomberg
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Global bond yields climbed back to the highest level in almost two decades as rising oil prices fuelled inflation concerns and investors ramped up expectations for interest-rate hikes.

The move started on Friday after Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh doubled down on his vow to finally tame inflation, and was extended this week as energy prices rose on renewed conflicts in the Middle East.

The rate on 10-year Japanese government notes touched 3% for the first time since 1996, UK 30-year yields reached the highest since 1998 and the 10-year Treasury rate hit levels last seen January last year. The yield on a Bloomberg gauge of global sovereign bonds advanced for a fourth straight session on Monday, rising to 3.72%, the highest since mid-2008.

"Markets are pricing in a higher path for short rates in the US, but also globally," Idanna Appio, a portfolio manager and senior research analyst at First Eagle Investments, said on Bloomberg TV. "Investors are beginning to reassess what neutral policy rates look like and there has been a gradual increase in those."

Global bonds have been under pressure for months, with worries over elevated government spending in markets like Japan, the UK and the US prompting investors to seek higher compensation to own longer-maturity debt. At the same time, a surge in borrowing by US technology firms to fund artificial intelligence is potentially crowding out demand for sovereign bonds.

Meanwhile, fresh hostilities between the US and Iran have raised concerns about prolonged disruptions to energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, sending oil prices higher. Several current and former officials have said they expect the Middle East conflict to drag on for months.

"The direction of travel is

going to be higher yields from here," said Laura Cooper, global investment strategist at Nuveen. "Term premium likely has to be higher to compensate for this confluence of risks."

Traders are currently pricing an almost 70% chance that the Federal Reserve hikes rates by a quarter-point at its meeting this month, an increase from the European Central Bank is fully priced in for next week, while they're all but certain the Bank of Japan will hike later this month.

"G-10 fixed-income traders are paying closer attention to JGBs, with Australian bonds increasingly taking their cue from Japanese debt as much as from Treasuries. The near-term backdrop is toxic: sticky inflation combined with wide fiscal deficits across the US, Japan, the UK and France."

Against this backdrop, the Bloomberg gauge of global debt has slipped 0.9% so far this year, following a 6.8% gain in 2025. An auction of 10-year Japanese bonds on Tuesday saw demand in-line with the

For months global bonds have been under pressure, with worries over elevated government spending

12-month average, while in Australia, the yield on similar-maturity debt surged to levels last seen in 2011. Economists at Barclays Plc and Societe Generale SA changed their

forecasts following Warsh's speech on Friday, predicting rate hikes this year that they previously had not anticipated. The bond selloff poses a fresh challenge for Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who last month unleashed more measures to keep yields contained, as well as for President Donald Trump, with higher borrowing costs threatening to weigh on the economy heading into the November midterms.

The yield on 30-year US bonds is almost back to the levels seen before Bessent jolted markets last month with a decision to at least double the size of the Treasury department's bond buybacks. Surging yields also threaten to dent the appeal of equities, putting a global, artificial intelligence-led rally at risk. Pressure on bonds is unlikely to ease, if seasonality is any guide.

Mass burials in Nepal as toll from flash floods over 1,000

Rescuers, aided by search dogs, searched gaps among rocks and debris for signs of life; 11,814 rescued so far

AP
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KATHMANDU, NEPAL

Rescue teams with search dogs continued to search through mud, rocks and debris on Tuesday on the border with Nepal and China for thousands of people still missing following the catastrophic floods that tore through communities across the Himalayas, leaving more than 1,000 dead.

As police in Kathmandu buried dozens of bodies in multiple trenches, Nepal's disaster agency said that 1,003 deaths had been counted there, with 3,916 people missing, including 583 foreign nationals. In its latest update, China reported 16 deaths and 546 missing, including 261 foreigners.

The scale of the 26 August disaster is hampering rescue efforts in both countries, with landslides, destroyed roads and widespread damage cutting off remote areas. Crews faced challenging conditions as they searched unstable terrain and piles of debris, raising fears the death toll could rise as rescuers reach isolated communities.

Rescuers are racing to reach hundreds of workers believed to be trapped inside tunnels at hydropower projects in Nepal damaged by the floods. About 900 workers are missing from 12 projects, with roughly 500 believed to be trapped in tunnels, according to local authorities.

Brig. Gen. Raja Ram Basnet, Nepal's army spokesperson, said teams assisted by foreign experts were working at several hydropower projects. Images released by the army showed rescue teams entering debris-filled tunnels and wading



Efforts are being stepped up to provide assistance to survivors in areas where roads had been damaged or cut off.

through mud and water in the search for signs of life.

On the Chinese side, rescue crews scoured areas hit by mudslides, particularly around the Gyirong Port border crossing, which was destroyed.

Some rescuers, aided by search dogs, searched gaps among rocks and debris for signs of life. Other teams used heavy machinery to clear a major highway leading to Gyirong Port, hoping to clear the way for equipment, personnel and supplies to reach the disaster zone, according to China's state-run Global

Times newspaper.

In Kathmandu, police worked in heavy rain on Tuesday to bury dozens of bodies in multiple trenches next to a forested area.

Barbed wire was erected around the site, while blue numbered markers identified the graves of people whose names were not yet known. Authorities in Nepal have been burying bodies in temporary graves until

they can be identified. They are preserving DNA samples, photographing distinguishing facial features and recording other identifying details.

Each body is assigned a reference number to help families identify and claim the remains later.

At least 11,814 people have been rescued so far, according to Nepalese authorities. Emergency crews used helicopters and other aircraft to reach stranded communities in areas where roads and bridges have been destroyed by the flooding and landslides.

Efforts are being stepped up to provide assistance to survivors in areas where roads and other transportation routes had been damaged or cut off.

China's Foreign Ministry spokesperson, Guo Jiakun, said a second batch of relief supplies was being sent to Nepal, including drones, DNA test-

ing and water purification equipment. Chinese DNA testing experts will also help Nepal identify bodies, he said.

Bimal Sharma, a helicopter pilot who has been flying rescue and relief missions, said he was shocked to see the devastation in Timure, a border town close to Tibet that he has known for years.

"It felt like I was flying over an entirely different landscape," said Sharma, adding that he has had little opportunity to speak with the people he rescued. "I can see the pain in their eyes. It's heartbreaking," he said.

The disaster began in the Himalayas when a glacial collapse sent large amounts of rock, ice and meltwater into valleys below, triggering powerful floods downstream.

Scientists studying satellite imagery said the collapse appears to have involved the failure of bedrock beneath a glacier in the Himalayan region. The rockfall was powerful enough to register as a magnitude 5.2 seismic event.

The resulting surge of water and debris entered rivers that flow through valleys in Tibet and Nepal, causing them to rise rapidly. Floodwaters swept away homes, buildings, roads and bridges and carried mud and rocks downstream.

Nepal's Prime Minister Balendra Shah said that the disaster highlighted the need for action to combat climate change.

"This incident has indicated that the risks we face in the Himalayan region are increasing with climate change," Shah said in a social media post Monday night. "Therefore, this region must be alert, and at the same time, it is time for us to strongly raise the issue of disasters caused by climate change before the international community."

Iran tells US to uphold deal after Trump threatens further strikes

Reuters
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DUBAI

Iran said on Tuesday it would reciprocate if the US honoured its commitments under a June interim deal on halting the conflict, but tensions remained high after US President Donald Trump threatened Tehran with further strikes.

Oil prices rose after the first exchange of direct attacks since late July, and following reports of two tankers coming under fire leaving the Strait of Hormuz, the global oil supply waterway that Iran has effectively closed to shipping.

The six-month-old conflict had shifted into an economic standoff before a US attack on Iran's Larak Island on Sunday, which Iran responded to by launching missiles overnight at two US air bases in Jordan.

"We're going to hit them

hard ... There will be a response," a Fox News reporter quoted Trump as telling the channel on Monday, although the president separately told reporters that the renewed strikes did not signal a return to full-scale war.

A senior Iranian source told Reuters the exchanges of fire were a "limited and contained confrontation" but said Tehran would deliver a harsh response if attacked again.

While neither side appears to want a return to an all-out war, their pledges to respond to further attacks highlight how quickly a conflict that has increasingly been fought through sanctions, blockades and economic pressure could spill back into military action.

Tehran has repeatedly said it will allow free navigation through the Strait of Hormuz only if Washington implements the terms of the memorandum of understanding



Both Iran and US do not want a return to an all-out war.

(MoU) that was signed by both sides in June but quickly unravelled. The MoU declared an end to fighting but deferred many of the most difficult issues and paved the way for a broader 60-day negotiation period, which passed without further agreement.

"I am stating clearly that if the US returns to its commitments under the Memorandum of Understanding, the

Islamic Republic of Iran will immediately reciprocate," Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said.

He was speaking in Bishkek, capital of Kyrgyzstan, during a summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, whose members also include Russia, China, India and Pakistan.

He had also said on Monday that war was in no one's interest and that Tehran was still open to a negotiated solution.

But there has been no sign of a breakthrough and the heightened tensions this week have renewed fears of oil supply disruptions from the world's key crude-producing region, with Brent futures rising another 1.3% on Tuesday.

"The tit-for-tat missile exchanges between the US and

Iran bring validation to those who believe that even if not a 'forever war', this conflict will run and run," said PVM analyst John Evans.

Highlighting such concerns, two supertankers carrying Saudi oil were struck by unknown projectiles within

minutes of each other while transiting outbound through the Strait of Hormuz late on Monday, according to data from shipping intelligence and tracking firms Marisks and Kpler.

Thousands have been killed in the conflict, mainly in Iran and Lebanon, since the strikes on Iran began on 28 February

flict.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has warned that countries doing business with Iran could face U.S. sanctions and said secondary sanctions are likely to be unveiled weekly in the effort to pressure Iran, with an initial focus on banks.

Iran's central bank governor, Abdolnaser Hemmati, said on Tuesday that Tehran had sufficient foreign currency reserves. The central bank was ready to inject up to \$2 billion into the foreign exchange market to calm recent volatility, Hemmati was quoted as saying by the semi-official Tasnim news agency.

"I am telling the president of the United States: Iran has (foreign) currency and it has enough," he said. His comments appeared partly aimed at reassuring markets after Iranian officials, including Pezeshkian, pointed to growing difficulties for Iran's economy.

Apple's 2,275% gain under Cook is a tough act for Ternus to follow

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Apple Inc.'s Tim Cook handed over the reins to John Ternus on Tuesday, capping a tenure as chief executive officer that cemented the company as an iconic global brand and turned its stock into one of the most reliable bets.

The shares have soared 2,275% since Cook took over from legendary founder Steve Jobs on 24 August 2011. Cook inherited a company with a market capitalization of less than \$350 billion and built the maker of iPhones and Mac computers into a diverse \$4.6 trillion business that also sells watches, AirPods and financial services.

"Steve Jobs left huge shoes to fill, but Cook is also leaving big shoes, albeit of a different type, given his very different approach to expanding the company's growth engines," said Chris Brigati, chief invest-

ment officer at SWBC. "He's certainly done amazing things as CEO, and every shareholder has benefited, probably more than was expected when he took over."

Ternus will face an early test at a critical event next week, when he's expected to unveil a foldable version of the iPhone, along with other product updates.

"The ideal for Ternus will be to blend the Jobs and Cook approaches," Brigati said, citing Cook's steady, positive reign against "the otherworldly innovation and massively impressive growth of the Jobs era."

Apple's stock gains under Cook are even more impressive when accounting for dividends. During his time as CEO, the shares climbed a whopping 2,736% on a total-return basis. Over the same period, the S&P 500 Index was up 769%, including dividends, and the tech-heavy Nasdaq 100 Index jumped 1,512%.

The gain puts Apple among the 40 best performers in the S&P 500 over that stretch, but well behind Nvidia Corp., by far the biggest gainer with a more than 72,000% surge. Several other Big Tech stocks outperformed Apple in the Cook era, including Tesla Inc. and Broadcom Inc.

"Cook's legacy will be that he was a steady hand on the wheel over not just a long period of time, but a period of time that featured huge changes in the technology landscape," said Allen Bond, managing director and portfolio manager at Jensen Investment Management, which owns Apple shares.

While several companies tied to artificial intelligence infrastructure—including Micron Technology Inc. and Seagate Technology Holdings Plc—have outpaced Apple, the stock has benefited from its image as an anti-AI play during periods of angst over the technology. Its 40-day correlation



John Ternus will face an early test at a critical event next week, when he's expected to unveil a foldable version of the iPhone.

to the S&P 500 recently turned negative for the first time in more than a decade.

"Under Tim Cook, Apple has created market cap growth at a rate of roughly \$32 million an hour, every hour, for nearly 15 years," Bank of America analyst Wamsi Mohan wrote in a 20 August report. It was the first firm to top \$3 trillion in market value and has

repeatedly attained the status of the world's largest company.

The stock accounts for 7.1% of the S&P 500, up from less than 3.3% in 2011. Its weighting peaked at nearly 7.9% last month.

Cook oversaw a steady rise in revenue, with sales going from \$157 billion in Apple's fiscal 2012—his first full year as

CEO—to \$416 billion in the most recent period. When Apple's 2026 fiscal year closes at the end of September, revenue is expected to reach \$477 billion.

A key driver of revenue growth has been Apple Services. In fiscal 2025, the company generated more than \$109 billion from the business, more than a quarter of its total sales, according to data compiled by Bloomberg. In fiscal 2013, the earliest year for which data are available, services were just \$16 billion, or 9.4% of Apple's total.

Cook did oversee successful product launches, such as AirPods and the Apple Watch. But others, like the Vision Pro headset and a failed foray into self-driving cars, fell flat, feeding into criticism that Apple lost its innovative edge. To

some investors, the company's underwhelming AI offerings have been a missed opportunity.

"The push into services is perhaps the most successful thing Cook did, since it is high margin and recurring revenue that is among Apple's fastest-growing categories," Bond said. "His biggest flaw is probably AI. It's hard to not notice that they're bringing in someone with an engineering and products background to replace him."

One of the biggest legacies of Cook's tenure has been his focus on stock buybacks, which have reduced Apple's outstanding share count by nearly 45% since a 2012 peak, taking it to its lowest since 1998.

Apple has spent more than \$840 billion on buybacks since fiscal 2012, according to com-

pany data through the first quarter of 2026. In 2014, billionaire activist investor Carl Icahn urged the company to accelerate its buybacks, saying the stock was undervalued.

Under Ternus, the company's risk appetite could change, according to Bank of America's Mohan. Apple has moved away from a net cash neutral objective, which "could signal a period of higher investment in R&D, Capex, and larger M&A," he wrote. "The latter two have not been emphasized in the Tim Cook era but AI could require Apple to move with a higher rate of change."

While Cook has many fans, Wall Street is less effusive about the company. Of the 58 analysts tracked by Bloomberg who follow the stock, 34 have buy ratings. By contrast, roughly 95% of the analysts covering megacap peers Microsoft Corp., Nvidia and Amazon are bullish on those stocks.



Retirement rethink: selling property for a simpler life

Holding too much realty can be a burden if wealth is tied up in homes children may not need

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At 83, S. Jagannatha S. no longer owns a house. After his wife died, Rao found himself living alone in Bhopal in a three-bedroom house while his two sons were in Bengaluru. The property needed upkeep, and there was little reason to live so far from his children. Buying a house near his sons was expensive, so Rao chose to rent. He sold the Bhopal house and invested the proceeds in Section 54EC capital gains bonds, government securities and fixed deposits. He also sold an ancestral property in Andhra Pradesh.

"I was emotionally attached to my ancestral property in Anantapur. After weighing the pros and cons and discussing it with my sons, I realized it was far more prudent to sell it during my lifetime," he said.

Selling the properties simplified his life. "Having my net worth in liquid instruments rather than physical real estate brings immense peace of mind. Had something happened to me, managing and selling the properties remotely would have been a significant administrative burden for my sons," he said.

A new calculus
Rao's experience reflects a broader shift in retirement planning. India's 60-plus population is projected to reach 347 million by 2050, according to the United Nations Population Fund. At the same time, children are increasingly moving to other cities or countries, and elder care is becoming less centred on multigenerational households.

Homes accumulated for the next generation may have little practical use if children are settled elsewhere, while maintaining and selling those properties can burden heirs, said Kalpesh Ashar, CFP and Sebi-registered investment advisor.

Some retirees are, therefore, selling secondary real estate and moving the proceeds into financial assets that are easier to manage and divide.

Too big for two

As large family homes are left to elderly, some seniors are downsizing to managed or gated housing.

A 67-year-old Noida resident, who did not wish to be named, sold his independent bungalow and moved to an apartment in a gated complex.

"It was my family home...Eventually, however, the children moved out and I was left there with my wife and elderly father," he said. The house had become a burden. It needed major repairs, while security was a concern. "My children suggested selling it and buying an apartment. It took me a year to make up my mind as I was emotionally attached to the house. Seeing a friend make a similar move helped me understand the economics better," he said.

He spent about one-fourth of the sale proceeds on the new apartment and placed the balance in fixed deposits. The society provides security, power backup, water and maintenance.

Selling a property rather than renting it out can make sense financially and mentally, said Ajay Pruthi, founder of PLNR and a Sebi-registered investment advisor. "Rental yields are typically 2-3% of the property value before society charges, property tax and repairs. Moreover, chasing tenants in

How retirees are rethinking real estate

Changing family structures are making retirees rethink real estate. More seniors are selling, downsizing or redeveloping to unlock wealth, reduce upkeep and simplify inheritance.

S. Jagannatha Rao (83)
Bengaluru



Parvathi Mahadevan, Padma Mahadevan (daughter)
Chennai



What changed

- ▶ Sold post-retirement house in Bhopal after wife's death
- ▶ Also sold ancestral property in Andhra Pradesh
- ▶ Redeveloped family home with a developer into apartments as upkeep became difficult
- ▶ Retained 2 apartments

Where they moved

- ▶ Rented a home closer to his sons in Bengaluru
- ▶ Moved into one apartment; the other was passed on to Padma

Where the money went

- ▶ 54EC bonds, G-secs and FDs
- ▶ Received two flats + cash

Key benefits

- ▶ Less upkeep, liquid wealth, easier succession
- ▶ Easy to maintain, more money in retirement and simpler succession for her 2 children

"Having my net worth in liquid assets brings peace of mind. I no longer have the stress of property upkeep, and my sons won't have the burden of managing and selling the properties remotely."

"The value unlocked from the property made my parents financially better off in retirement. They started taking holidays and could afford a more comfortable lifestyle."
- Padma

Why multiple properties can become a burden in retirement

Low rental yield

- ▶ Residential rental yields are typically 2-3%

Poor liquidity

- ▶ A property cannot be sold in parts when money is needed for healthcare or other expenses

Maintenance burden

- ▶ Repairs, tenants and vacant properties require time and attention that can become harder with age

Children may not want them

- ▶ Children settled elsewhere may have little use for inherited property and face hassles selling it remotely

Succession is harder

- ▶ Unlike financial assets, a property cannot be divided as easily among heirs

Opportunity cost

- ▶ Multiple properties can leave retirees asset-rich but short of liquid funds that they can use in retirement



Advisor's thumb rule: Retain the primary residence; review additional residential properties based on their returns, utility and whether the next generation will use them

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your 70s-80s is not easy. An empty property, meanwhile, generates expenses without income," said Pruthi. Pruthi's broad rule is to retain the house a retiree lives in and reconsider additional properties unless they generate sufficiently attractive returns.

Ashar said the previous generation's preference for accumulating residential property reflected investment choices available to them.

Unlocking value

Redevelopment can suit retirees who want to stay in the same location without the upkeep of an independent house.

That is what Padma Mahadevan's parents did with their family property in Chennai. Her father built a house on inherited land in 1984. As he and his brother, who lived next door, grew older, maintenance became difficult. The brothers eventually handed their adjoining properties to a developer. Mahadevan's father and uncle received two flats each, along with cash. For her parents, redevelopment allowed them to stay in the same locality while moving into easier-to-

Selling or redeveloping property can unlock wealth, improve liquidity and simplify inheritance

maintain homes and unlocking wealth from land.

"The surplus changed my parents' lives in retirement. They started going on holidays and financially upgraded into a completely different bracket," Mahadevan said.

It also simplified succession. One flat has already been given to Mahadevan, while the other, where her parents lived, will go to her brother, who lives in London. Her father died in April and her mother has since moved to a senior living community in Coimbatore. She is renting for now but has enough to buy a home there if she chooses to.

Redevelopment worked for Mahadevan's family because it unlocked land value while allowing them to retain homes in the same location. But when the next generation lives elsewhere, holding multiple properties can become a burden.

Plan first

Deciding how to deploy the proceeds is as important as the sale itself, said Pruthi. He recommends setting

aside the capital gains tax liability first and assessing whether Section 54EC bonds make sense. "Buy capital gains bonds only if the tax you save is bigger than what you lose by locking money at 5.25% for five years," he said.

The balance should be divided by when the money will be needed, with a separate corpus for medical emergencies and old-age care. Senior Citizens' Savings Scheme, Post Office Monthly Income Scheme and fixed deposits of different maturities can provide regular income, while longer-term money can be invested in growth assets based on the retiree's risk profile.

"Split the money into buckets and don't dump it into one big FD," he said. Ashar cautions retirees against giving away sale proceeds or assets too early simply to simplify succession. They should first ensure they retain enough to fund the rest of their lives.



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Trust residency: what India's Income Tax Act and Fema say

Rohit Jain & Keshav Singhania

Does the appointment of a non-resident trustee make a trust non-resident? More broadly, how is the residential status of a trust determined under the Income-tax Act and Fema?
—Name withheld on request

Under the Indian income-tax law, a trust's residential status defines income taxable in India—broadly, worldwide income for a resident trust and India-sourced income for a non-resident trust. Indian tax law has no separate residence test for trusts. A trust therefore falls under the residuary rule, which treats every other person as resident in India unless control and management of its affairs is wholly outside India.

A trust would qualify as non-resident only where its control and management, as exercised by its trustees, is wholly outside India. If even part of that control and management is exercised from India, the trust would ordinarily be regarded as resident. This makes the question one of substance rather than form. The analysis is factual and turns on where the trust's key decisions are taken and, more fundamentally, where its affairs are



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ESTATE PLAN

administered and managed. The mix of resident and non-resident trustees may also be relevant, particularly where it affects effective decision-making and control. Accordingly, the mere appointment of a non-resident trustee would not, without more, render the trust non-resident. Non-resident status follows only where the trust is wholly controlled and managed outside India.

The position under exchange control law is less straightforward. The Foreign Exchange Management Act (Fema) does not contain specific provisions dealing with the creation or operation of trusts, nor do the extant foreign exchange regulations

prescribe a separate test for determining the residential status of a trust. Further, a trust is not expressly included within the definition of a 'person'. Accordingly, a separate residential status is not ordinarily assigned to the trust itself for Fema purposes.

The cross-border analysis therefore shifts to the parties connected with the trust, including the settlor, trustees and beneficiaries, as well as the nature and situs, or legal location, of the underlying assets and the transactions undertaken in relation to them.

Ultimately, under Fema, the overarching principle is that what cannot be done directly cannot be achieved indirectly through the interposition of a trust. Conversely, where a transaction is permissible between the relevant settlor, trustee and/or beneficiary, the use of a trust should not, by itself, alter that position.

Rohit Jain is the managing partner and Keshav Singhania is the head of Private Client at Singhania & Co.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare bank FD rates

Bank fixed deposits (FDs) continue to be popular investment products not just among senior citizens, who are looking for guaranteed income, but also among investors who can't stomach risk. But overexposure to FDs is not good, and you need to assess your asset allocation and goals to decide how much money you should park in them. For instance, saving for your child's higher education that's 15 years away through FDs may not be effective as the post-tax interest rate of an FD may not give you a real return (return that's above the rate of inflation). But if you plan to take a holiday in two years, an FD can help. Before choosing an FD, you should compare the interest rates on offer. Here is a list of banks that offer the highest FD rates for deposits up to ₹1 crore over various tenures.



Interest rates (%) for fixed deposits up to ₹1 crore					
	6 months to < 1 year	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.00-6.50	6.90-7.10	6.90-7.50	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	5.50-6.00	6.55-6.60	6.75-7.05	6.80	6.85
YES Bank	4.75-6.50	6.65-7.25	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	4.75-6.05	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.30-6.50	6.60-7.25	7.00	6.70	6.70
IndusInd Bank	5.75-6.25	6.75-6.90	7.00	6.65-7.00	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	5.25-7.00	6.25-7.10	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.25	6.50-6.60
Axis Bank	5.50-5.75	6.25-6.50	6.50	6.50	6.50
ICICI Bank	4.50-5.50	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Federal Bank	4.50-6.00	6.25-6.65	6.40-6.50	6.40-6.70	6.40
Karur Vysya Bank	6.00-7.00	6.55-7.20	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	5.00-6.00	6.35-6.55	6.80	6.40	6.25
Canara Bank	5.25-5.50	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
City Union Bank	5.75-6.25	6.65-7.25	6.50	6.25-6.50	6.25
HDFC Bank	4.25-5.75	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	4.50-5.50	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 31 August 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

Source: www.Bankbazaar.com

A HIGH PAYOUT CAN MISLEAD. HERE'S WHAT INCOME INVESTORS SHOULD WATCH FOR



POWER
POINT

HARSIMRAN SANDHU & ABHINAV JINDAL

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

Indian investors seeking regular income have traditionally relied on bank deposits, bonds and dividend-paying stocks. But the landscape is widening, with listed options such as dividend-paying companies, Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) and Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs).

High payouts are attractive but misleading. Ask: Where does the money come from? How reliable is it? Can it grow? What happens to the original investment? For instance, a high dividend yield may reflect a falling share price or a one-time payout. Sustainable dividends ultimately depend on profits, cash generation and management's willingness to share them with shareholders.

Income backed by assets

REITs offer a different route to income. Instead of buying an office building or shopping centre yourself, a REIT allows you to own a small interest in a portfolio of income-generating properties. Rental cash flows from these assets support distributions to

investors. India now has six listed REITs, following the May listing of Bagmane Prime Office REIT. REITs can benefit when property rents rise. But they are not fixed deposits. Investors need to consider occupancy, rental growth, property quality, borrowing costs and the remaining lease period. A large payout is useful only if the underlying rental income is healthy and sustainable.

A technical term often used with REITs is "distributable cash flow". Simply put, this is the cash a REIT has available to distribute to investors after relevant expenses and adjustments. REITs are required to distribute at least 90% of this amount. For investors, the key point is that the payout is ultimately linked to the cash generated by the underlying properties.

InvITs follow a similar model, but invest in infrastructure not real estate. They give access to assets such as roads and transmission networks without owning or operating them directly. Some offer attractive payouts, but investors should ask how long the underlying assets can generate cash. This matters especially for infrastructure operating under fixed concessions or contracts. A toll road, for instance, may generate strong cash flows today but have a limited operating life before its concession expires.

Look beyond the payout

A distribution may not be the same as profit or pure income. A portion of an InvIT's payout can represent a return of some of the investor's original capital. Therefore, a 12% or 15% payout should not automatically be compared with a 6% dividend or bond coupon. Investors need to understand what they are actually receiving. The more relevant measure is "total return": the



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cash received during the investment period plus any increase or decrease in the investment's value.

The sponsor's quality also matters for REITs and InvITs. Typically, the sponsor establishes the trust and contributes or transfers its initial portfolio of real estate or infrastructure assets. A strong institutional or government-linked sponsor can offer greater comfort on governance, asset quality and operating capability, though it cannot guarantee future cash flows. A simple framework can help compare these investments. Ask five questions: Where does the cash come from? Is it sustainable? Can the

payout grow? How much borrowing supports it? And, after tax, what return am I likely to earn?

Dividend-paying shares can offer both regular income and the potential for capital appreciation. REITs can provide income backed by rental cash flows from real estate assets. InvITs can offer cash flows linked to infrastructure projects, but investors should also consider the remaining asset life and the nature and sustainability of the distributions.

Finally, look beyond the headline yield. Inflation erodes purchasing power, while taxes reduce what investors actually keep. REIT and InvIT payouts may also have different tax treatment depending on their components. The meaningful measure is therefore post-tax total return, not simply the stated "yield". Yield should be the starting point, not the destination.

Beyond safer income options, understand the extra risk taken for a higher yield. The better investment is one most likely to keep paying, grow those payments and preserve the capital generating the income.

The objective is durable income, capital preservation and sustainable returns. One principle matters most: income is valuable only when it can last.

Harsimran Sandhu is professor of finance at IMT Ghaziabad. Abhinav Jindal is a senior faculty at NTPC's Power Management Institute (PMI), Noida.

OUR VIEW



Apple has cash: it needs a big leap into the AI pie

Its robust finances and mass-market presence grant Apple's new CEO John Ternus plenty of strategic space to get its act together on AI. The company's innovative core faces a big test

John Ternus, who has taken charge of Apple Inc as CEO, inherits a mixed bag of fortune. The company, worth some \$4.6 trillion, has more than 2.5 billion active devices in people's hands and an enviable cash pile, but is widely seen as an artificial intelligence (AI) laggard. The iPhone marketer was late to Generative AI, has yet to wow users with Agentic AI, and earned eyerolls with its first attempt at AI-run Siri assistance. For its AI services, it mostly relies on Google's Gemini. Apple Intelligence, its own version of this technology marvel, has been thinking different. While Microsoft, Meta, Alphabet and Amazon invest big capital in data centres and AI infrastructure, a capex race that some investors fear has overheated, the *Financial Times* estimates that only about \$51 billion of Apple's \$383 billion in assets are fixed. This levity sets it apart from the balance sheets of other Big Tech majors.

Apple's financial heft offers Ternus plenty of space to manoeuvre. It generated \$109.4 billion in revenue in its June quarter, up 16% year-on-year. Gross margins have hovered around 46-50% over the past year, while its net cash is placed above \$62 billion. This gives investors the comfort that Apple can fund its AI game without quick returns from this hot frontier of technology. It has begun filling AI gaps. It snapped up Canadian AI company DarwinAI, which rejigged neural networks for model-use efficiency. It bought French startup Datakalab, a specialist in on-device AI and computer vision. This year, it paid nearly \$2 billion for Israeli AI startup Q.ai, even as it explored acquisitions of AI-chip firms for its server processors. Apple's gadget wins have stemmed from its mastery of design and user

interfaces. Co-founder Steve Jobs sought novel fusions of hardware and software. Tim Cook gave the business an industrial boost, turning its supply chain, custom silicon and installed base into a mega profit spinner. While Cook will stay on as executive chairman, Ternus is likely to reshape the product portfolio.

In terms of market addressal, Apple has an edge granted by access to iPhone users, among others. Instead of chasing OpenAI or Google, it can push intelligence deeper into its range of devices. Its new Siri AI hints of it. Q.ai's tech could go into AirPods or Vision Pro. On the flip side, the smartphone-upgrade cycle has grown weary and the company faces global antitrust scrutiny for what it charges apps in need of market access, even as reliance on others for AI would risk its gadgets losing appeal should a wave of AI-gizmo rivalry arise. Its commitment to privacy is seen to constrain its speed in this race, although its launch of agentic tools in Xcode gave it a bump-up in developer esteem. Last but not least, if its bet on custom chips and edge models fails to deliver truly transformative AI, Apple could find itself selling pricey hardware in a market defined by cloud-based intelligence. From India's point of view, with about a quarter of its iPhones made in factories here, we need a larger bite of its global value chain. From Ternus's perspective, Apple must get its outlays right. It has lifted its R&D spend to a bit over 10% of revenue. As an engineer who oversaw the success of its A- and M-series of custom processors, Ternus need not make a "dent in the universe," but must still show investors how Apple's new AI chips, products and services can churn out profits without letting the capital discipline slacken that has made Apple so valuable.

GUEST VIEW

India Inc is on a growth-buying spree with an upsurge of M&As

Integration is where real value gets created when companies seek acquisitions to scale up speedily



SUBODH RAI
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For much of corporate India's recent history, mergers and acquisitions (M&As) have been viewed as an occasional growth lever, deployed selectively when opportunities aligned. That is changing. Increasingly, M&As are being used as a core strategic tool to pursue scale, capabilities and market leadership in an environment where speed can be as important as strategy. Annual M&A volumes have more than doubled since 2016-17, reflecting a growing conviction among corporate leaders that these can speed up growth, provide entry to new markets and acquire capabilities that would take years to build organically. In many cases, an acquisition is a competitive necessity more than an option.

What makes the current cycle interesting is the strength of the financial foundation underpinning it. Corporate balance sheets today are considerably healthier than they were a decade ago. Over the years, India Inc has navigated a succession of disruptions, from economic shocks and supply-chain disruptions to geopolitical uncertainty. Yet, rather than getting weakened, many companies have become more resilient.

Revenue growth and profitability have held up through periods of volatility and balance sheets have strengthened materially. The median net debt-to-operating profits ratio for corporates rated by Crisil Ratings declined to about

1.3 times in 2025-26 from 2.4 times in 2016-17. This improvement has created financial flexibility, enabling companies to pursue strategic acquisitions.

At the same time, the approach to organic expansion has become more measured. In an environment shaped by geopolitical complexity and uncertain demand conditions, managements are becoming selective about where and how they allocate capital. This discipline is a sign of maturity.

As a result, Indian companies are increasingly using M&As to complement organic growth strategies. Healthy capacity utilization levels and lower leverage have preserved balance-sheet headroom, allowing businesses to act decisively when opportunities arise.

The motivations vary across sectors. In pharmaceuticals, healthcare, enterprise technology, artificial intelligence and consumer businesses, acquisitions are often about gaining access to technology, talent and intellectual property. In cement and metals, the rationale differs. Acquisitions offer a faster path to capacity expansion, compressing project timelines from several years to as little as one to three years.

Yet, while the strategic logic of a buy-out may be compelling, execution ultimately determines outcomes. A Crisil Ratings analysis of 100 large debt-funded transactions offers an important lesson. Roughly two-thirds of the deals broadly met expectations. Successful acquisitions delivered meaningful scale expansion within one-two years, broadened geographic reach or improved profitability as synergies began to materialize.

The remaining one-third tell a different story. Integration challenges accounted for about half of the underperforming deals, while regulatory delays and cross-border execution complexities were also significant contributors. These experiences reinforce a fundamental reality: announcing an acquisition is often the easiest part of the process. Too often, organizations

assume that a strong strategic rationale alone guarantees success. In reality, value creation depends on what happens after the transaction closes. Disciplined integration, effective change management, timely synergy capture and rigorous oversight of leverage are what separate successful acquirers from those that fall short.

This is especially important from a credit perspective. Encouragingly, acquisitions have generally translated into stable or positive credit outcomes. Around three-fourths of ratings were reaffirmed or upgraded following acquisitions, while a majority of these acquirers reduced leverage on or ahead of plan within two years. The benefits of greater scale, improved diversification and operational synergies often offset the temporary increase in debt associated with their acquisitions.

Where outcomes have been weaker, the key factors were elevated leverage, industry cycles turning unfavourable, growth taking longer to materialize and regulatory hurdles delaying execution. These are risks that can be managed with planning and strong governance.

India's corporate leaders face an important balancing act. M&As will continue to play a critical role in accelerating growth, building competitive advantage and responding to rapidly evolving markets. However, acquisitions cannot become a substitute for investing in core capabilities.

For success, companies should not just pursue inorganic growth, but also strengthen innovation, technology, talent and operational excellence. They must view acquisitions not as an end but as one component of a broader value-creation strategy.

The M&A opportunity for India Inc is significant. But long-term success will depend on how effectively acquisition deals are executed. Disciplined capital allocation, strong integration capabilities and sustained investment in organic strengths will remain the true determinants of durable value creation.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

We're here to put a dent in the universe. Otherwise why else even be here?

STEVE JOBS

THEIR VIEW

Why UPI may never be able to outmode the use of cash

MADAN SABNAVIS



is chief economist, Bank of Baroda, and author of 'Corporate Quirks: The Darker Side of the Sun'

India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI) has completed 10 years of operations and has been a phenomenal success. It is now an integral part of our financial ecosystem and used by individuals irrespective of income class for making payments. The system has matured enough for the regulator to talk about making someone pay for its use. A question often asked is this: If even a ₹10 transaction with a hawk can be done using UPI, does it mean regular paper currency is becoming redundant?

Data from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) throws up interesting trends. The currency in circulation was around ₹42.46 trillion in August and is increasing at a good pace. In fact, 2025-26 recorded an increase of ₹4.38 trillion, the largest after demonetization in 2016. In 2017-18, it increased by almost ₹5 trillion after a decline in 2016-17. During 2020-21, there was an increase of ₹4.14 trillion, the second most, amid covid as people accumulated cash as a safety buffer. On average, we witness an increment of ₹2-3 trillion

every year. Before demonetization too, there were similar increments, implying that people at large still prefer the same level of cash. This also means that from the central bank's perspective, it may not yet be time to slow down the printing of currency notes.

So, what is driving this uptrend in India's demand for paper currency? There are two sets of reasons. The first relates to the advantage of anonymity and the second to a fear of digital transactions.

An anonymity preference is apparent in five use-cases. The first are payments for property transactions. Sellers often insist on cash payments in part for the sale of homes and land. Even developers do it, as they may need to pay cash bribes to get clearances for their projects (land certificates, water and power connections, etc) and fend off local land sharks. Several layers of authorities being involved leads medium and small developers to use speed money to keep their projects on track and reduce cost overruns. While state-wise Real Estate Regulation Authorities have helped make the system more transparent, there are still challenges. The cash component in realty deals can go up to 30-40% if it is a resale or 10-15% in the case of a primary sale. If it is a patch of land, the cash ratio could be even higher.

Second, cash is still used widely for buying gold ornaments. There is a limit of ₹2 lakh for purchases with cash payments. Beyond this level, one needs to provide a PAN number. So, buyers try to avoid leaving an audit trail by making cash purchases. While corporate jewellery retailers follow the rule, a multitude of smaller establishments in the unorganized sector tend to accept large cash payments. Often, the amount is split into multiple bills to accommodate the customer. Otherwise, doing business would be harder.

Third, wads of cash are accumulated by various political parties for use during elections. Large sums are spent on various campaign expenses or given as gifts to voters.

While this is illegal, such transactions are hard to track. Given that we have elections in some states or municipalities every year and the cost of wooing the electorate is rising, this demand for currency doesn't flag.

Fourth, cash is often used to settle bills for expensive functions like marriages. This

helps keep such transactions anonymous and avoid tax burdens. In some places, it can yield substantial savings on hotels, halls, banquets and bands. The amounts involved can range from a few lakhs to crores. Further, marriage gifts often involve cash. Ironically, the tracking of credit-card payments made by taxpayers incentivizes the use of cash.

Notably, several small-time vendors have stopped accepting UPI payments and are now insisting on cash to avoid an audit trail. UPI-record revelations of several hawkers having earned large sums by selling foodstuff during the last Kumbh Mela attracted the taxman's interest. These stories have led some users to revert to cash. While the individual amounts would be small in relative terms, taken together, they would amount to a considerable sum.

On the other side, instances of digital fraud have irked people, especially the older generation of folks who are not savvy with technology. The momentum of UPI adoption was anyway weaker among the elderly

and complex app designs are a deterrent as well. However, with online fraud on the rise and India's redressal system still a work-in-progress, many individuals have withdrawn from the digital payments system.

Lastly, the precautionary motive has grown after covid, with people keeping cash at home for emergencies. During the pandemic, there were several instances of hospitals and nursing homes insisting on cash payments for admission amid uncertainty over reimbursements from insurers, given the surge in hospitalization. That experience stoked the habitual holding of cash among Indian households, with some keeping a handy stash upwards of ₹50,000.

Cash is also used by anonymous donors who do not wish to be identified by recipients or their peers. Migrating everyone to digital transactions and away from cash seems almost impossible. The age factor alone would make a compulsory shift unfair. The fact that many commercial practices remain opaque and involve speed money will always make cash a useful tool for expediting processes. And if the state keeps a tighter watch on transactions made by individuals, it may push them to rely even more on paper money to eschew identification.

These are the author's personal views.

There exist too many use-cases of trail-free paper money that digital payments can't supplant



| THEIR VIEW

How India's growth record keeps its dream of development alive

Contrary to claims based on miscalculations, India's economic trajectory needs only a slight pick-up to achieve its 2047 target



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On 30 August, *Bloomberg* published a long article (tinyurl.com/jc75r5hk) arguing that India's ambition to become a developed nation clashes with its growth gap. The argument rests on a comparison that does not hold. It sets a growth requirement, measured in dollars, against India's achieved growth, measured at constant prices. Those are two different quantities. Once they are placed on the same footing, the gap shrinks to a fraction of what the article describes.

Start with India's recent record. The country reported real growth of 7.8% year-on-year in the first quarter of 2026-27. In nominal terms, growth was 10.3%. The reading is consistent with several high-frequency indicators: purchasing managers' indices, GST collections, sales of two-wheelers and passenger vehicles, bank credit and export growth.

India has held annual growth above 7% since the pandemic, which few nations have managed. It has done so while bringing the average inflation rate down and keeping its public finances in order. India's debt-to-GDP ratio has fallen by about 7 percentage points since 2020-21, among the sharpest reductions in the G-20.

Real growth has been harder to come by everywhere since the pandemic. Manufacturing competition has intensified, supply chains have been weaponized and trade restrictions have proliferated. Tariff and non-tariff barriers have been erected, and interest rates have risen. There have been two energy shocks, one in 2022 and another in 2026. The boom in artificial intelligence has been shared by only a handful of nations. For the rest, it has brought uncertainty and steeply higher prices for electronic goods.

It is easier to grow when the global backdrop is benign. It is more creditable to grow when the backdrop is uncertain and at times hostile. India's post-pandemic performance belongs to the second category. In that light, it deserves credit rather than criticism.

Now to the measurement problem at the heart of the *Bloomberg* article. Economic size, for the purpose of international comparison, is denominated in a common currency, usually the US dollar. For any country other than the United States of America, the growth rate of dollar GDP is the sum of its nominal GDP growth and the change in its exchange rate against the dollar.

When institutions such as the International Monetary Fund project future growth, they have to make an assumption about the exchange rate. They are not in the business of forecasting currencies. So they assume that relative purchasing power parity holds. Under that assumption, the rupee depreciates by the difference between



Indian and American inflation if the latter is lower, as it usually is. Dollar GDP growth is thus nominal growth less that difference, which reduces to India's real growth rate plus the US inflation rate.

Take the period from 2000 to 2024. The article says India's GDP grew at 6.3% a year over those years. In real terms, that is right. In dollar terms, India's GDP grew at 8.8% a year. Exchange rates do not always follow inflation differentials. The rupee's performance against the dollar in 2024-25 and 2025-26 is proof of that. The inflation gap narrowed, yet the rupee weakened. Over long stretches, though, currency movements and inflation differentials tend to converge.

The article's own numbers show what the correct comparison looks like. It cites India's per capita income at \$2,813 in 2025 and a 'high-income' threshold of about \$18,000 dollars by 2047. That is a rise of roughly 6.4 times over 22 years, or about 8.8% a year in dollars per head. Add half a percentage point for population growth, and the requirement works out at about 9.3% growth in dollar GDP. That is close to the 9.25% figure quoted in the article, and it is a dollar-denominated requirement. Set beside 6.3%, a constant-price number, the shortfall looks like three percentage points. Measured properly, against the 8.8% dollar growth India actually recorded, the shortfall is about half a percentage point.

The arithmetic ahead does not call for heroic assumptions either. India's GDP stood at \$3.91 tril-

lion in March 2026. If real growth averages about 7% over the coming decade and American inflation averages 3%, dollar GDP will grow at 10% a year. That takes India to just over \$10 trillion by March 2036. Assume the pace then slows to 7% in dollar terms as the base widens. By 2046, GDP would be a shade under \$20 trillion.

The article points to India's net FDI flows, youth employment and its savings and investment rates. These are real constraints that are worth taking seriously. It is worth remembering, though, that India reached 7% real growth while bound by them. They describe headroom rather than a ceiling. As they are addressed, they leave space to do better rather than worse.

There is also a question of what we are measuring. A country's development status is better judged by the quality of its growth and the standard of living it delivers than by a single measure of economic size. Some countries have reached impressive numbers on that measure by borrowing heavily. The bill falls due long after the headlines have moved on.

The global environment over the next 20 years will be harder for India than it was for the countries that moved from the third world to the first after World War II. India has its task cut out.

That is a fair thing to say. It is not fair to say that India has already failed or has little chance of success. That's a preconception masquerading as a forecast.

These are the author's personal views.

| MINT CURATOR

AI secrecy mustn't leave us in the dark about its real impact

Its closet use could spring surprises if there's no way to research it



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The AI industry must let others analyse this technology's usage patterns. ISTOCKPHOTO

Do you have any artificial intelligence (AI) secrets? Maybe the better question is: Would it concern you if your most intimate chatbot queries were shared with your family, colleagues or bosses?

For all the hype, AI still carries a stigma. I have been tracking the mounting backlash for a while. It has become deeply uncool to admit that you used AI to help you with your art, not to mention that it will be judged more harshly. And trust in Big Tech leaders, often for valid reasons, is abysmal. Bashing AI on the internet gets a lot more applause than defending it. So perhaps it should not be surprising that a don't-ask-don't-tell economy now seems to be driving the next tech revolution. That should make us all wary of what happens in the dark.

A global KPMG-University of Melbourne study last year found that 57% of employees across 47 countries admitted that they have used AI in non-transparent ways, including presenting machine-generated content as their own or avoiding revealing when they used the technology to complete work tasks. The same report found that rates of non-transparency among students rose to roughly two-thirds and I can't imagine how that could be over-reported. A survey last November in Japan, where adoption remains relatively low, found that 59% of young professionals never or almost never disclose AI assistance when submitting work.

Part of the reason for this secrecy is that even as business leaders encourage adoption, research shows that it's still ostracized in the workplace. More Americans now talk openly about their AI use with managers and colleagues, a June study from Atlassian found, yet doing so carries a "steep penalty." Even when the output itself was identical, participants rated hypothetical peers who disclosed using AI as 10 times "lazier" and were 24 percentage points less likely to recommend them for a high-visibility project. No wonder employees are unlikely to shout their prompts from the rooftops.

This may also start to explain one of AI's ongoing economic conundrums. Productivity gains not visible in macro data may be accrued by individual workers who have little incentive to reveal them.

But this culture of secrecy can create other risks for businesses, whether it's data leaking to unapproved tools, or a lack of knowledge-sharing across teams. The obvious first step is a clear, accessible policy spelling out when AI can be used and when it must be disclosed. Managers should also encourage prompt-sharing, tips and open conversations about experiments.

There are other consequences to a tech shift unfurling in the shadows that extend well beyond the office. Ask friends how they use chatbots when no one is watching, and the answers might make you gasp. A digital archive project dubbed 'What We Tell AI' is already collecting anonymous confessions via boxes placed in public spaces across the US. They offer a glimpse at the increasingly intimate ways this technology is being embraced. People are using AI to compose birthday messages to relatives or cheat on homework and the *New York Times* Spelling Bee game. Others admit they are in love with ChatGPT, or view it as a best friend. They are not the use-cases that dominate earnings calls.

AI firms publish reports on how people are adopting their products, but some researchers say this is necessarily selective. Firms preparing for major public offerings or defending enormous spending may be incentivized to highlight productivity gains and have less reason to dwell on other uses. That leaves policymakers with an incomplete picture of a technology proliferating rapidly in people's jobs, relationships and private lives, including children's. Regulators hoping to not repeat past mistakes should demand greater transparency from tech companies to let external researchers study how their products are actually being utilized and what effects they are having.

The secrecy also reveals a larger problem for the industry. They are still left hoping that eventually its value will be stronger than the shame of turning to their services. That contradiction is especially stark among youth. Young adults in the US are the most likely to think AI will have a negative effect on society, but they are also the group that says they use chatbots the most, according to a June Pew survey.

The AI revolution is not being televised; it may be too disjointed for that. The message that this technology could put us all out of work, or at worst kill us all, is hard to dismiss as paranoia. But it is not stopping people from asking for dating advice either. That may tell us more about AI's future impact on society than another survey on how many minutes it saves on digital coding tasks. What people are unwilling to admit matters more than what the AI industry is willing to measure. ©BLOOMBERG

| MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

India is innovative but we mustn't starve ideas to death

RAHUL MATTHAN



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The Simputer was the first genuinely original computer that India built. As the legal advisor to the project, I was lucky to own one of its first colour units off the production line, and I had hours of fun with its truly novel interface and advanced features.

For those who have never heard of it, the Simputer was a palm-sized touchscreen device designed in Bangalore at the turn of the millennium, years before Apple turned its attention in this direction. In 2001, *Time* magazine called it one of the best and most innovative portable technologies to bridge the digital divide in the developing world, but you will not see any in production today because it died a premature death.

For years, I attributed the demise of the Simputer to unfortunate timing. I convinced myself that we had built a product before the world was ready for it, and that was the reason why it did not take off. With the benefit of hindsight, I think I was being too kind. Not only is the Simputer not the only example of

Indian innovation that hasn't scaled, it's not even the only technology product I have advised that hasn't.

At around the same time, another Indian entrepreneur, Chetan Maini, was developing India's first fully electric car—the Reva. By the late 2000s, with about 3,000-4,000 units on the road across more than 24 countries, the Reva was the most-sold electric vehicle (EV) on the planet—well before Tesla made EVs desirable. This was yet another example of world-class Indian innovation creating a new product category well before global majors. But as good as the Reva was, it too eventually ran out of road and became a footnote in history.

It is frequently suggested that Indians are incapable of coming up with new and innovative products. But we do that all the time—often years in advance of the rest of the world. What we seem to lack is the ability to take those ideas and turn them into commercial successes.

All inventions, no matter how cutting-edge, require investment to make them production-ready. Compaq invested \$50 million in the production of its iPaq series of computers at around the same time as the Simputer, but all the Simputer team needed to take the project across the finish line was

₹50 crore—an amount that it could have secured from a single government order of 50,000 units. That order never came, and despite their best efforts, the team only ended up raising ₹4.5 crore of angel funding and debt.

This is the kind of order that governments around the world have typically issued to support the development of new industrial capabilities in the national interest. The early American semiconductor business survived precisely because the Apollo mission and the Minuteman missile programme bought almost everything that early chip-makers could produce. This not only gave them a guaranteed market needed to support the fledgling industry until economies of scale kicked in, it also allowed them to develop the process knowledge required to manufacture chips at scale. All of which drove costs down to the point where the technology finally made sense for the consumer market.

More recently, it was a series of Nasa con-

tracts that kept SpaceX alive long enough to remake the economics of spaceflight. A committed public buyer can do what no private investor will—absorb the risk of being first.

Are we not willing to make the level of investment required to take innovations to market? After all, what really distinguishes

Apple and Tesla from their peers is their willingness to subsidize their visionary products, often at a loss for several years, until they dominate the market they set out to create. This is how technological prowess is built. Invention is cheap. That is not where market leadership is established. That is only won by those who build the capacity needed to deliver at scale.

At the same time, it is incorrect to say we have never made large technology bets. After all, Reliance Industries invested more than \$20 billion in a nationwide 4G network and then offered the service free for months to win its first 400 million mobile subscribers. This was how Jio came to dominate the telecom space with such speed. Where it counts, we

lack neither the capital nor the courage to make bold technology investments.

Indian capital is not timid. We are more than willing to stake a fortune on new paths to proven outcomes. Yet, as significant as it was, Jio was an audacious wager on distribution rather than invention. We could not find ₹50 crore to bring a device we invented into production, but 15 years later, we invested 3,000 times as much in deploying 4G technology that someone else invented.

A country can only ever become an engine of innovation when three things work in tandem: procurement that gives untested products an early market, capital patient enough to absorb years of losses and the courage to commit to something the world does not yet believe is possible. We have all three, but tend not to deploy them on the unproven. Our capital prefers safe bets to risky bets, and our procurement system is all but built to avoid the audit trail of a failure rather than take a chance on being first.

The next Simputer has already been invented. We need to find it, nurture it and feed it the capital it needs to become everything the Simputer could not be. Whether it thrives or dies, as that ahead-of-the-curve device did, will depend on where we decide to put our money.



What does a fully AI work suite look like?

Solo entrepreneurs and small teams use multiple AI programs in their processes. What do they do while they wait for the results?

Shalaka Kulkarni
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Every morning, Madhu Karuthedath, 42, the Bengaluru-based solo founder of the employer-brand consultancy The Quick Brown Fox Co., opens what looks like a small control room on his laptop. Several tools gather news, Claude turns the previous day's work into a prioritised checklist, ChatGPT helps him brainstorm and structure ideas, and runs them through Gemini for critique, and then hands the clearer brief back to Claude for implementation. While the engines work, does he take a break? No. He is waiting for one tool to share the output, checking another, and briefing a third.

In the sitcom *How I Met Your Mother*, the character Barney Stinson made a catchphrase out of suspense, inserting "wait-for-it" into everything, and most famously "legen-wait-for-it-dary". Today, between the AI prompt and the output sits a new kind of "wait-for-it". It lasts a few seconds or several minutes, but is rarely empty: An email is answered, an errand is run, a social media post is crafted, or another task is assigned.

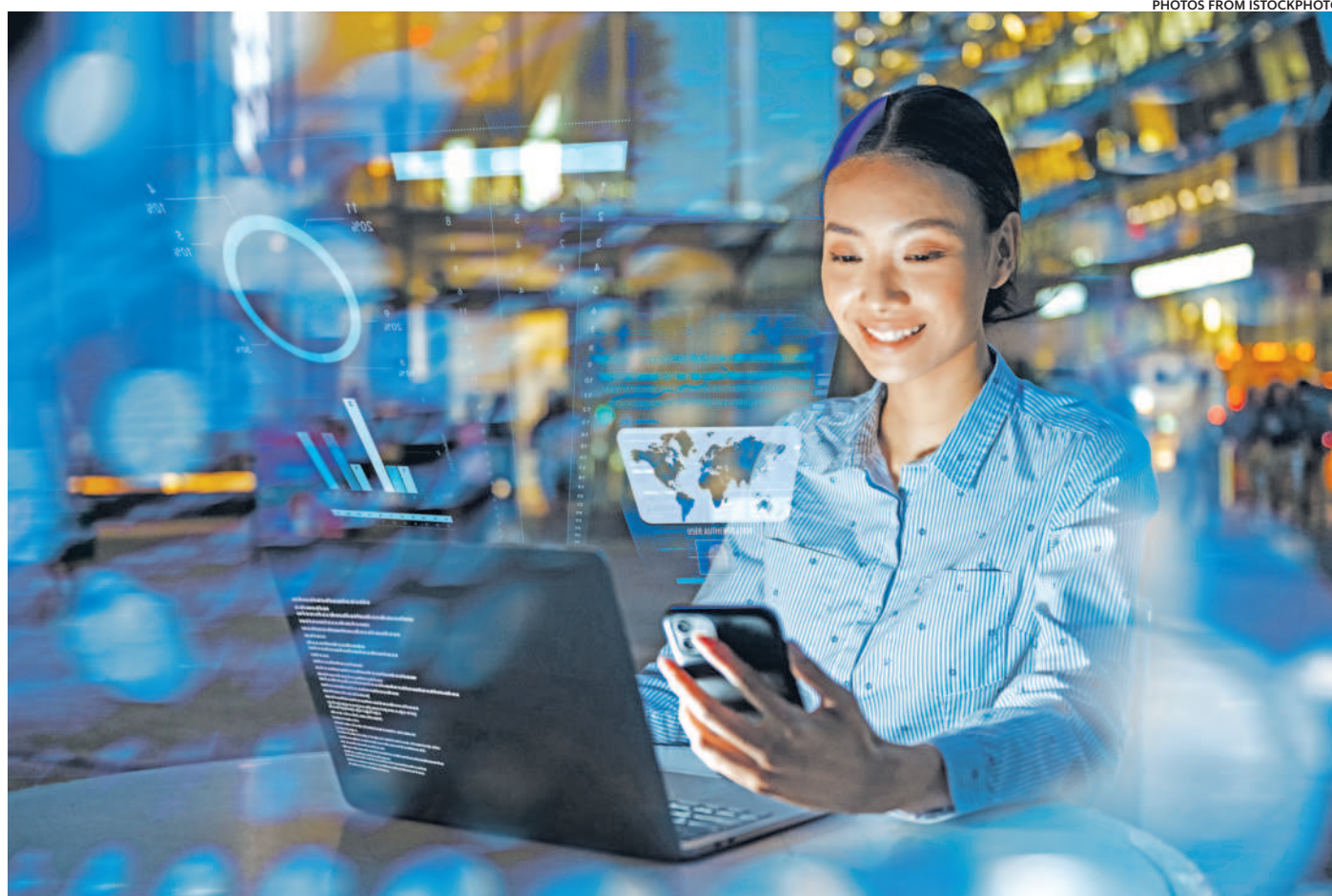
HUMMING IN THE BACKGROUND

For solo entrepreneurs and small teams, several AI assistants can be working in the background simultaneously, while one person briefs, supervises and reviews them. AI has shortened individual tasks, but the gaps are filled with more work, as editing other AI content, context-switching, and verifications have become jobs in themselves. And with AI companies beginning to make generated output identifiable through watermarks, these pauses also make us wonder: Where does AI's work end, and the human's begin?

Aditya Malani, 28, an engineer and solo-founder building Speedy Squirrel (a Shopify development company) in Bengaluru, usually has two agents working simultaneously. One fixes or builds a product feature from a previously scoped product requirements document; the other researches a new feature or domain. Meanwhile, Malani reads online or replies to customer-support tickets. He describes the agents as junior developers who require specific instructions. "The challenge right now feels like reviewing AI output and deciding what goes in," he says.

Then there are those who do not consider AI agents as members of their "team". To Phalgun Guduthur, 36, an independent product builder, AI is just a computer doing what it is told to. Cursor and Claude build features and analyse marketing while he browses X (formerly Twitter), cooks, or reads about what to do next. "I vehemently say it has made me cram more things into the same number of hours. I actually work a lot more now, as parked ideas move into the

For solo entrepreneurs and small teams, several AI assistants might be working in the background simultaneously



PHOTOS FROM ISTOCKPHOTO

time saved," he says. Akhilesh Bhamburkar, a 33-year-old tech solo-prenuer in Nagpur, agrees: "I slog for a minimum of ten hours a day, more than in my previous corporate job."

AI has also created an abundance problem. Through vibe coding, almost every idea now feels buildable. But there's also a price to pay for building the wrong thing. The productivity gain is showcased as a business's capacity, but when execution speeds up, the slowest part of the system can become the human in the middle, deciding what happens next.

"I have become my own bottleneck," says Sankalp Sinha, 33, the Bengaluru-based founder of NextDoor.Company, a startup for map-based recruitment. Faster execution

means he must review completed tasks and keep supplying direction. "AI can drive the car, but the human in the loop must hold the steering," he adds. Earlier, a developer stuck on a problem

might search Stack Overflow (a massively popular online community for programmers), notice whether a solution had been accepted or upvoted, remain sceptical and test it. AI output often arrives at speed, but without that social scaffolding and filter, and therefore needs verification. "Thank God for some of the need to verify. Otherwise, there would be a lot more AI slop out there than there is today," Bhamburkar says.

PERPETUALLY WORKING

Priyanka Iyer, a 32-year-old principal engineer in Chicago, tries to remain in "work mode", all the time. She likens the experience to watching someone work continuously in front of you until their

effort tires you out. Guduthur often has three or four tasks running inside the same tool; his concern is that he may be moving too quickly to think through his decisions. Yet he is reluctant to blame AI alone. He feels short-form content and doomscrolling are to blame for the damage to his attention span.

The boundary between assistance and authorship is also now more easily traceable. Last month, Anthropic announced that future Claude models would place an imperceptible watermark in generated text globally to comply with the EU AI Act. Google DeepMind has used a somewhat similar system, SynthID, for text in the Gemini app and web browser since 2024, alongside watermarks for AI-generated images, audio and video.

Bhamburkar worries that this may discourage responsible users too. A writer might develop an original idea, ask AI to rephrase parts of it and then edit the result heavily, without knowing whether the watermark remains. Malani is less concerned. Tested code is judged by whether it works and he claims that he rewrites his blogs and content in his authentic voice, because asking people to read it means asking for their time. For Iyer's team, watermarking would change little because organizational gov-

ernance already defines where AI can and cannot be used. Each developer still owns their code, with shared responsibility for the final product.

WAITING FOR AI

The technology recognises some of this distinction. Anthropic says lightly proof-read human writing may contain too little model-generated language to register, while code offers fewer arbitrary choices and therefore carries less watermarking. A watermark can suggest that Claude was likely involved, but it cannot measure the human judgement that followed.

Sinha draws the line at using AI in the context of experiences that require time. He would not ask AI to read an e-book for him, because understanding flows from the act of reading. "AI is a reactive tool. It can only react in the moment and not after that. But we as humans can," he says. Context and judgment, in this case, take the cake.

Machines may not daydream, but their loading screens have developed quite an imagination. ChatGPT tells us it is thinking or searching, while Claude Code might be "Crystallizing", "Sleuthing", "Canoodling", "Moonwalking" or "Flibbertigibbetting". Claude Code users can even customise these spinner verbs by choosing the whimsical vocabulary of the machine's apparent inner monologue.

In the pre-AI era, one used to wait for a work outcome. There would be anticipation and impatience, perhaps dread. There was a sense of possibility, and time for the mind to wander. The AI waiting room has no such vacancy: every pause arrives with another prompt, another decision, and the cognitive load of constant context switching. Whatever comes next will only make the queue move faster.

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REVIEW | GALAXY WATCH 9

A smartwatch that offers more of the same

Samsung's new Galaxy Watch 9 delivers the old hits, but does so well

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It seems like Samsung underestimated the demand for the Galaxy Watch 9's Silver colourway. I walked into the store to buy the 44mm Bluetooth model and it was only available in graphite. Nonetheless, I went for the launch offer, unboxed my Galaxy Watch 9 once I got back home, and walked on to the streets (and parks) of Delhi for long walks, short jogs, and a proper testing of the Galaxy Watch 9 (₹40,999).

The Galaxy Watch line-up, along with the accompanying Samsung Health app, have been a huge success for Samsung over the past couple of years. I know many who swear by it. Just like Apple though, Samsung wants to lock you into their ecosystem with exclusive features available only for those who have a Galaxy smartphone paired to the smartwatch.

COMFORTABLE AND POWER-PACKED

The Galaxy Watch 9 is powered by the Snapdragon Wear Elite, a proper flagship Qualcomm chip on a smartwatch. Straight off the bat you'll notice that the Galaxy Watch 9 is thin, lightweight, and almost indistinguishable from its predecessor. It has a circular face, surrounded by fixed squared bezels and rounded corners (Samsung calls it a "squircle") and an aluminium chassis. It's so light (34g) that I sometimes forget I'm even wearing it. There's IP68 along with 50m of water resistance, rugged durability and a slightly bigger battery.

It comes with all the health-tracking features you'd expect. There are some new features like monitoring of your overnight vitals, a Fitness Index, Daily Cardio Load, and a heart health checker, while the AI Running Coach feature, introduced last year, is now even better. In order to measure certain things like blood pressure or ECG, you need to own a Samsung phone with the Samsung Health Monitor app. All these new features though are mere software updates rather than the smartwatch gaining any new sensors. There is a chance that these features will be eventually available on older Galaxy Watch models as well.

The Galaxy Watch 8 was already an accurate and highly capable activity tracker and the Galaxy Watch 9 builds upon it. Auto tracking of a wide range of activities, exercises, and sports works like a charm. While the heart rate readings were fairly accurate (I was wearing the Pixel Watch 5 and Oura Ring on my other hand), it was the step count that was somewhat inflated. You also get a sleep score each morning.

While the larger 44mm model gets a hefty 445mAh battery, and Samsung gives the same 30-hour battery life estimate as the Galaxy Watch 8.

There's no doubting that the Galaxy Watch 9 is comfortable to wear, has a bright display with crisp text, and is packed with advanced health and wellness features. It is a smartwatch that delivers accurate tracking for all your fitness needs, slightly irregular sleep data, and has useful metrics like Fitness Index to provide a deeper insight into your overall health.

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REVIEW | GOOGLE PIXEL 11

When the entry-level smartphone is the best choice

The new Google Pixel 11 isn't revolutionary, but it might be the best all-round useful Android phone for most people

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In case you haven't noticed, 2026 isn't exactly a great year to buy a phone. Welcome to RAMageddon, where memory costs have gone through the roof. It's against this muted backdrop that the Pixel 11 series has arrived, and while the Pro, Pro XL and Pro Fold all bring their own assortment of new tricks, after spending time with the range, I keep returning to the phone sitting at the bottom of Google's flagship pile: the Pixel 11.

That may sound odd, but this phone gets to the heart of what makes a Pixel appealing. At ₹89,999, in a year of bloated tech prices, it is perhaps the Pixel to buy.

It doesn't stray too far from last year's aesthetic, save for a dramatically thinned-out rear-facing camera bar that helps it fit better in tight pockets (pun very much intended). You wouldn't be able to tell it

apart from the outgoing Pixel 10 (the 11 is marginally lighter at 197g), and so it remains as endearingly right-sized, easy-to-hold and operate. It's left to the colours on the glossy rear panel to do the heavy lifting this time around, so take your pick from staid Obsidian, white-lavender Frost, a very green Pistachio and the show-stopping bold pink Hibiscus.

You still get an aluminium frame, an IP68 dust and water proof rating, and Gorilla Glass Victus 2 protecting both the front and rear, along with the magnetic PixelSnap tech introduced with the Pixel 10. The latter remains a particularly neat trick, making the Pixel 11 the only major Android phone that lets you enjoy the convenience of MagSafe accessories straight out of the box. Likewise, the Pixel 11's 6.3-inch, 2,424 by 1,080-pixel Actua OLED display is 3000 nits bright, with a fluid 120Hz refresh rate, and with a snappy ultrasonic fingerprint scanner to boot.

Running the same Google Tensor G6 processor as the rest of the Pixel 11 family means the Pixel 11 is broadly on par with the Pixel 11 Pro and Pro XL when it comes to performance. Just remember that the Pixel 11 gets 12GB of RAM, regardless of whether you opt for the 256GB or 512GB model, while the Pro and Pro XL step up to 16GB once you move to 512GB of storage



or higher. For everyday use, that difference is hardly noticeable. Even while juggling multiple apps and a dozen Chrome tabs, I never once encountered any slowdown or stutter.

Where the Tensor G6 continues to fall short is raw horsepower, and that becomes much more apparent when you push the phone beyond everyday tasks. Compared with similarly priced Qualcomm- or MediaTek-powered flagships,

the Pixel 11 is noticeably less convincing under demanding gaming loads. Casual games are handled without fuss, but if you're a serious gamer or regularly throw demanding photo and video-editing workloads at your phone, this probably isn't the Pixel for you.

In regular use, the 4985mAh battery gives a full day of use, so you're going to have to plug it in at the end of the day and charge over the relatively slower 30W

wired charging speeds.

Where the Tensor platform scores in boosting the AI capabilities on the Pixel 11, which allows its Gemini Intelligence to sit at a deeper, more fundamental level across phone features. You get new features to deal with spam calls better, or dictate anything when you want to write. The Rambler speech-to-text feature filters out all the "um"s and "ah"s and other extraneous sounds to produce a more cohesive, normal-sounding sentence. Elsewhere, creators can use the phone as a teleprompter, dynamically scrolling the text at your pace, as you speak.

There's also Magic Capture, a new image-capture mode, that sifts through video footage and picks a handful of stills, with optional auto-cropping and unblurring thrown in for good measure.

Beyond AI, the Pixel 11 runs Android 17, the freshest iteration of Google's mobile OS, and it remains one of the cleanest and most refreshing Android experiences around. The design is tasteful, with well-judged colour accents and plenty of available customisations. And all that without making you wade through endless menus, and very little bloatware to speak of. There are no unwanted third-party apps, although pretty much the entire Google app ecosystem comes pre-installed.

The 48 megapixel main camera now gets a larger sensor, along with other hardware and software refinements that make this a noticeably better camera phone, likely among the best you can get for under ₹1 lakh. Giving it company is a useable 13 megapixel ultrawide and a 10.8 megapixel telephoto. The latter is equipped with a 5X optical and up to 30X optical-quality zoom, along with a 10.5-megapixel autofocus selfie camera. In daily use, the Pixel 11 consistently impressed me, delivering excellent colours, detail and dynamic range across lighting conditions. Google has also added selectable photo "looks", letting you choose everything from punchier colours to cleaner shadows and brighter or darker exposures.

The Pixel 11 isn't the best Pixel because it has the best hardware. The reason I'd rate the Pixel 11 higher than its siblings is because it knows when to stop without altering the core Pixel experience. Same chipset, same Gemini features and long-term software support, an improved camera setup too—the Pixel 11 feels less like the "cheap Pixel" and more like the Pixel most people actually need.

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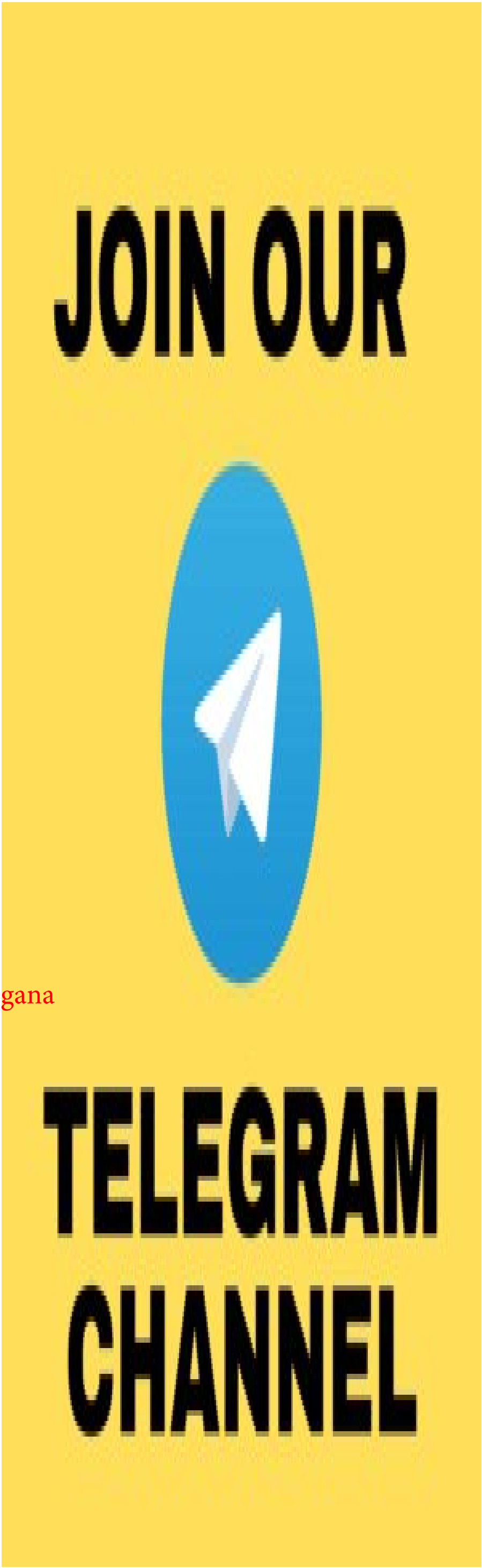
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